



CANDACE NOLA

TRANSFORMATION



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Transformation

Candace Nola



Uncomfortably Dark Horror

OceanofPDF.com

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Praise for Candace Nola

“CANDACE NOLA HAS APPEARED on the hardcore horror scene in a huge splash of blood, soaking readers with her diabolical prose. Her work is both demented and delicious.” - Kristopher Triana, author of GONE TO SEE THE RIVER MAN

“Not only is Candace a champion of indie horror, she’s also one of its shining stars. From Hank Flynn to Bishop to Frank Franklin, she creates memorable characters in horrific situations that keep you coming back for more.” -Eric Butler, author of POPE LICK MASSACRE.

“Candace Nola possesses the work ethic to match her natural writing talent-a virtue that’s aided her in becoming the loved and respected author she is today. Having read some of her titles-Breach, Hank Flynn and Bishop-I can say that her stories stay with you. Nola’s imagination, dedication, and skill are to be applauded.”-James Carlson, author of

SEVEN EXHUMATIONS.

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Dedication

DEDICATION

To the usual suspects: the kitty, the puddin', and the sir.
For Mom.

For my patrons:

Sally Feliz, Jason Artz, Christina Pfeiffer, Rebecca Rowland, Sean
Stanford, J.E. Erickson, Kendall Cupp, Kristina Lee, Gage Greenwood,
Tasha, Brennan LaFaro, Brian Bowyer, James Gallagher, Tom Deady, Adam
Messer, Robin Ginther-Venneri, Henry J. Ortlieb, John Watson

For the Unicorn.

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Contents

- [1. The Beginning](#)
- [2. Starting Out](#)
- [3. A Sudden Pursuit](#)
- [4. Civilization](#)
- [5. Morning on Main](#)
- [6. Library and Lunch](#)
- [7. Newcomers](#)
- [8. Campfire Tales](#)
- [9. Back on the Trail](#)
- [10. Lost in the Storm](#)
- [11. The Search for Dotty](#)
- [12. Dotty](#)
- [13. The Search Continues](#)

[14. Dotty: Part II](#)

[15. A Bit of Hope](#)

[16. Dotty: Part III](#)

[17. The Cave](#)

[18. Dotty: Part IV](#)

[19. Plan and Purpose](#)

[20. Dotty: Part V](#)

[21. Sudden Chaos](#)

[22. Daylight](#)

[23. Fur and Fury](#)

[24. Jack Takes Charge](#)

[25. Unexpected Changes](#)

[26. Panic on the PNT](#)

[Epilogue](#)

[About the Author](#)

[Also By](#)

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Chapter 1

The Beginning

THE DAY I DECIDED to hike the Pacific Northwest trail by myself was the day I sealed my fate. This was my “Into the Wild” moment, my “face my fears and take back control” moment. I had been a sad, invisible blob most of my life. Heavy, pasty-faced, scared of my shadow, little shit that everyone despised, including myself. I was a miserable person, shitty to my mom, rude to teachers, downright gross and despicable to kids my age, especially to females. I knew what I was, what I looked like, and I already hated them for all the coming let-downs and rejections that I was sure to face as a teen.

My mum worked her ass off and I never once said “thanks”, never once acknowledged all that she put up with in dealing with me and my attitude. I never once apologized for the rude and hateful things that I spewed at her, day and night. Never cared for how hard she worked to provide for me, how hard she worked to clean the house and make proper meals every night. Meals that I demanded were cooked to my greedy specifications. Loads of homemade pizza and pastas, cakes and donuts, bags of frozen chicken strips

but fresh hand-cut fries. She must have peeled and sliced thousands of potatoes to feed me over the years. But it was never enough. I always demanded seconds and thirds, becoming furious whenever I saw her eat before I was finished.

I'm not even sure when it started. After my dad died, things went from good to all bad. I didn't deal well with it at all, only being six years old, and mum doted on me, day, and night, trying to compensate and make it better all while she dealt with her own grief behind closed doors at night. I think my grief and confusion morphed into something ugly—the more she tried to help me deal, the more I blamed her, the more I wanted to hurt her for making things this way, for making me just another kid without a dad. It wasn't her fault. He had collapsed from an undiagnosed aneurysm in his brain, which happens more often than people might think.

He was crossing the subway platform to board the train for home when he stumbled, then collapsed on the dirty ground. Instantly gone. No time for anyone to do anything other than gasp, stifle their screams and call 9-1-1. The older I grew, the more I understood this, but I had already buried myself in layers of fat, greed, and brutality that I just couldn't shake. I was scared, honestly. That persona, as despicable as it was, kept me safe from any more grief. No one to grieve for when you don't care about anyone, and it's hard to care for people that you have made despise you.



MY LIFE CHANGED AGAIN a few months after I graduated high school. Mum was pulling another night shift at the hospital, and she hadn't left me enough food to get me through the night. That very thought makes bile rise

in my throat even now, but anyway, there it was. I woke up from a long nap to find that she only left two pizzas, cooked, and warmed in the oven, along with a tray of chicken nuggets and French fries, but there were no other snacks for me. No cakes on the counter, no cupcakes, no fresh cookies, not even a bag of chips and a six-pack of soda, which I would accept if she really didn't have time, but there was NOTHING! I was livid.

I called her cell phone repeatedly, only for her to not answer. I left ten messages on her voicemail, screaming at her to get home and bring my dessert with her from the bakery. I told her how selfish she was, what a horrid beast she had become since she killed my father. I screamed at her to die, and to die fast since she was so miserable taking care of me. No response to my twenty text messages, either. I was furious.

I stormed (waddled) around the kitchen, gathering the food she managed to cook, and threw it on the table. I flopped down in my special chair at the table, a big old recliner that she needed to buy second-hand just to seat my almost five hundred pounds at our old table, and I ate. I didn't even bother with plates. I ate directly off the baking trays. Plates annoyed me. What was the point? It's not like I was sharing with anyone. I grabbed a cheap three-liter bottle of root beer from the Dollar Tree and added it to the pile on the table. I loved their root beer; it was cold, made you belch like a drunk trucker, and it pissed mum off to no end. I made her buy 10 bottles a week.

I ate, and I stewed. I called her names as I jammed pizza down my throat. The food calmed me, and I pulled up my tablet from the side of my chair and angrily opened it to the movie I had been watching, letting the corny anime cartoon lull me into another food coma. As I sat there, mindlessly dipping French fries and chicken nuggets into BBQ sauce, the doorbell rang. I could have screamed louder than an Irish banshee at this

inconsiderate interruption of my space and my dinner. Not to mention Mum was not here to answer the door. The bell rang again, and then again. I threw down my nugget and maneuvered myself out of the chair. No easy feat, at this point. Covered in crumbs and pizza sauce, I waddled over to the living room towards the front door, wheezing the entire way.

“You better have forgotten your key, you stupid idiot!” I yelled. My only thought was that it was mum ringing the bell, there to deliver my cakes and treats from the bakery or the grocer. I knew the bitch would cave in; she always did. I wrenched the front door open just as the doorbell pealed again, with a condescending smirk on my face, ready to pounce on her as soon as I could. The police officers standing there took a step back as I violently jerked open the door, nasty words for mum dying on my lips.

“What you want?” I sneered, twisting my lips up. I would have loved to spit on both of them, them and their shiny badges and dark blue uniforms. Cops made me sick. Thought they were better than everyone else, always looking down on you. I knew I was smarter than any cop and I had no patience for stupid games tonight.

“Well? Speak up or I’m going back to my dinner, which you so rudely interrupted.” I practically spit the words at them, full of loathing and hate for what they stood for.

“Garrison Russo?” the older man asked me, shooting a quick glance at a little notebook and then up at my face, which I’m sure was covered in about two days’ worth of food and drool.

“Yes, what’s this about? My dinner is getting cold.” I replied snidely.

“Is your mother Gloria Russo?” He asked again, intently watching my face while trying to peer past me into the living room.

“Yes, she’s at work. What she does? Get a ticket?” I sneered at him, rolling my eyes. “Look, it’s not my problem. Go bother her at work. I’m going back to my dinner, which she barely cooked properly before she left me to fend for myself.”

“May we come in? This might be easier if you were sitting down, and we can talk a bit more comfortably?”

“Oh, for fuck’s sake, suit yourself. Jesus, this better be worth it.” I flung the door wide and waddled my way back into the kitchen, not waiting to see if they followed. I settled my bulk back into my chair and began shoving more nuggets in my mouth, turning my attention back to my tablet.

Their shared look of revulsion was not lost on me as they stood awkwardly at the end of the table.

“Well, go on, sit down. Or not. I don’t give a fuck.” I gestured vaguely at the other chairs and kept eating.

“Um, we will stand, if that’s okay. Don’t want to take up any more of your time than we already have. “

“Suit yourself.” I hoovered another chicken nugget. “So, what did Miss Gloria Russo do that made you arrive at our house this time of night looking for her?” I sneered her name, making it sound crass, before chugging more root beer down my gullet and belching loudly. I never once broke eye contact with the older cop.

“Listen, you smug little shit, you need to show some respect...” the younger cop began, stepping towards me, turning red in the face, and slamming his fist down on the tabletop.

“Back off, Glen.” the older guy said. I smirked.

“Yea, back off, Glen.” I gave him a shit-eating grin, as I flicked the end of a ketchup covered fry at him before stuffing it in my mouth.

“Alright, Gary, listen. Your mom collapsed tonight at the hospital. They sent us to get you.”

“It’s Garrison. And why do I need to go? They can’t help her? Do I look like a doctor to you?” I didn’t give two fucks why they were here. Little did I know that his next sentence would destroy my little bubble.

“She’s dead, Gary. She collapsed and died of a heart attack. There was nothing they could do. We need you to come with us.” Glen spat the words at me, venom in each syllable.

“Now get up and let’s go.” He stood up, towering over me as I sat in my recliner, chicken clenched in each fat fist.

For the first time, my facade cracked, and I felt my chin wobble as the nuggets fell from my hands. I could feel the color drain from my face as my dinner threatened to reappear. I barely managed to step over to the sink before I vomited up everything that I had just eaten.

“That was not the way to do things, Glen.” I heard the older man admonish the younger cop.

“I know, Marshall, but Jesus Christ, I don’t even think he cares. Look at how he was acting.”

I heaved again, still standing over the sink, the stench of sickly sweet root beer and stomach acid more disgusting than the filth coating the sink. I turned the water on to rinse the sink, my mouth, and my face, as I propped myself up on one elbow. I could feel the men watching me, but they finally had the decency to step into the living room as I composed myself. A few minutes later, I heard footsteps coming towards me.

“Garrison, are you alright now? I know it’s a shock, but we really need you to come with us. It’s a quick process, unpleasant, but short. I will stay with you, if you’d like, and then I can help you fill out the paperwork. It’s

part of our job to help you get through the process.” Marshall had nothing but kindness in his gruff voice.

“She’s really gone?” I asked, hating the whiny nasal quality my voice took on. I turned to look at him, face still dripping with water and eyes glassy from unshed tears.

“Yes, she is. Can I help you get anything so we can go? Wallet, shoes, house keys.?”

My face cracked and fell once again, no sarcasm left in it as I just stood there, leaning heavily on the table, feeling my massive body trembling, from shock, anger, or fear, I wasn’t sure.

“Umm, my wallet and keys are on the dresser in the back bedroom. I have some slides out here I can wear.” Mumbling as I gestured towards the hallway on my right and Glen started down it as I trudged towards the living room. I sat down heavily in my other recliner and slid my feet into the slides that were there. I took my belongings numbly from Glen when he handed them to me and grabbed my oversized hoodie from the arm of the chair.

Standing, I followed the men out of the house and to the waiting squad car. It never even registered when Marshall slid the keys from my hand and went back to lock the front door. The car ride was surreal and longer than I thought possible. Scenarios ran through my mind as I tried to figure out how I felt. My mum was gone. My dad was gone. I had no one left. No family, no friends, not even a grandparent left. And I had done nothing my entire life to garner any favor with anyone. I felt my chin wobble as a hot rush of tears escaped my eyes.

Feeling sorry for myself would not help the situation, but right now, it was the only emotion I knew.



THE MORGUE WAS EVERY bit as cold and clinical as I thought it might be, and I remember very little of it. Marshall was true to his word and stayed nearby throughout the entire process. My emotions had shut down, and I remained silent as I went through the paperwork, answered their questions, and was handed her belongings. Glen also remained close, but I only remember him handing me a bottle of water a few times and holding a few doors open. The rest of the night was a blur. When they took me home, Marshall left me his card and said to call him if I needed anything.

I shut the door and stood there for a long time, taking in the quiet of the living room, listening to the white noise in my head. The static roar that had been there since their pronouncement of my mother's death. And there it was, the thought that broke me. She was gone, dead and gone, and I was alone. Fury and grief tore through my body as I began to cry and rant, calling her names, calling God names, cursing my dad for being weak and my mom for being weaker, blaming God for every fault I had ever imagined and forever slight that I ever had to endure before finally, righteously, turning that anger and blame inwards.

I was the only one to blame for my being alone right now. My parents had been decent people and life happened to them, as it does to everyone, but had I been a better person, a better son, she might still be here. If I had allowed her to help me grieve, and help me heal after my dad died, I wouldn't be this disgrace of a person. I cried until I passed out, but a decision had been made.



I CALLED THE FRIENDLY cop, Marshall, the next day and asked if he could come help me that afternoon. I had some questions about what to do next and I, honestly, had no one to ask. I was embarrassed and apologized for my behavior, but he quietly shrugged the apology off and agreed to meet me. After I hung up the phone, I cleaned the kitchen again and threw away everything that was in it, unless it was a protein or a vegetable. Then I made a list of things I needed to ask Marshall. Finally, I drug that loathsome, food-soaked recliner out of the kitchen, to the curb. I would no longer eat sitting down in that monstrosity, instead, I would stand until I was small enough to sit on our normal kitchen chairs.

While I waited for Marshall to arrive, I spent some time on my tablet, searching Amazon for healthy cookbooks, cookbooks for dummies, and other items. I had never even made Ramen, let alone cooked an egg. I had spent the last few days ordering takeout salads and forcing myself to eat them. I'm not even sure how I graduated high school, but here I was, fat, alone, ignorant and useless. No job, never learned to drive, played video games all day, and trolled anyone that was doing anything good with their lives online. Yep, that was me. An online troll, arrogant, narcissistic, and miserable. I could die or I could change. I only saw one way to make things up to my mother. I would change.



MARSHALL BECAME A BETTER friend and father figure than I could ever have hoped for. He helped me with the funeral arrangements and figuring out financial things. Turns out, mum had plenty in the bank for my immediate needs and her life insurance policy would last me quite a while if I made smart choices while deciding what to do next. The hospital also had a small policy set up for her and it would cover my health expenses for the next few years until I finished college and found decent work. He taught me a few basics in home care and lawn care.

He had his wife come around. She taught me how to cook simple healthy meals and she showed me how to do laundry and the other chores that I always left up to mum. I struggled with my anger, and my old attitude, but I quickly learned that being nice was much easier to do, despite my frustrations. The rest I did on my own, and that led me here, to the beginning of my new life, standing at the trailhead for the Pacific Northwest trail. I was down to two hundred and fifty pounds, stronger and healthier than I had ever been. I had learned to cook, clean, and drive. I had joined a gym and found a therapist. For the first time, I could look in a mirror and smile back at my reflection. Almost three years after my mum died, I finally felt strong enough to say that I was sorry.



STANDING OVER THEIR GRAVES before I left for Montana, I did just that. I thanked her for everything, told her about Marshall and how much I had learned, how far I had come. I left her roses, the biggest bouquet I could find, and I caught my flight out here to finish my transformation. I was going to hike the PNT and finish before I started college classes back

home. I hoped to clear the rest of negative thoughts from my mind, show myself that I could do something big and worthy on my own and that I was strong enough and healthy enough to do it. I wanted to face the rest of my fears, head on and work out those demons before I continued into the next chapter of my life.

I had my backpack, my supplies, and my trail guide. Marshall and Glen, both had helped me field test everything so I would know how to use it once I got out here. I had a GPS tracker, rations, my tent, and had arranged for deliveries along the way, at the various checkpoints, to replenish supplies. This was my atonement for the person I had been, my punishment for all those years of cruelty and unkindness towards my mom and my peers. What remained of Garrison Russo would die out here and I would emerge as Phillip Russo, taking my middle name in honor of my father, ready to pursue a meaningful life.

Chapter 2

Starting Out

I TOOK THE OBLIGATORY selfie of myself at the trailhead, sent it to Marshall by way of letting him know I had arrived, and set off down the trail. It was early still, not quite 9am, but the heat was already rising. The dry ground screamed for water as I trudged along. I probably looked like a complete noob to any seasoned hiker, but I didn't care. I was new, new to hiking, hell, I was new to living. I was at peace for the first time since my mom had passed, and I felt better than I had in years.

I walked silently, just breathing, and reminding myself to go slow on the water. The landscape was incredible, and I fully intended to spend every second of this time in the here and now. I wanted to see the land, feel the dirt and heat on my skin, feel the sweat soak into my clothes and know it was from my hard work and determination to be here. I wanted to let my thoughts wander and take me back through time to enrage me, embarrass me, and cleanse me.

It was here that I planned to fight my final battles with myself, lose those final thirty pounds and emerge as a new person, complete with a new name,

a new home, and a new lease on life as an independent adult. I would be twenty-three when I completed the trail, almost three years to the day since my mom's death. I owed my life to Marshall and to my mom. I would make them both proud, but beyond that, I would make myself proud. I would finally have one major accomplishment behind me that I could look back on and feel pride, something to draw strength and courage from whenever life out there got too hard.

Hours passed as I made my way deeper into Glacier National park. I hoped to make it fifteen miles to the first checkpoint by the ranger station by nightfall. This would take me to the actual start of the PNT and I could start fresh in the morning. Keeping to a steady pace had knocked out ten miles before I really noticed. Just by observing the park, the people, smiling at other hikers, exchanging friendly nods, and taking a quick break for a protein bar and to fill my canteen from the small pump I had passed had occupied my mind so thoroughly that I barely noticed. By 3pm, I had about seven miles to go. I could push through and hike for a few more hours, but I wanted to stick to the schedule Marshall had made and check in with the ranger.

I trudged on, just looking around, more trees surrounded me than I had ever seen in one place, and I began admiring the sheer variety of trees, leaves, insects, and animals that I had seen and heard. More hikers passed me, both coming and going, friendly chats and names were exchanged, and I felt welcomed, rather than outcast for my clearly new gear and pale skin. I was feeling tired, and my legs were aching; setting up camp sounded great right about now.

Right on time, I arrived at the ranger's station within the hour, checked in and made the short trek over to the camping area. I was set up within

minutes for the night, used the facilities and refilled my water, drinking my fill for the first time all day. Marshall had drilled me about the water usage, filling stations, and how to filter water from streams when needed. I knew to drink as much as I could, when I could safely do so and to always, always, refill at every station, even a mouthful and to ration between stops.

I returned to my small tent, broke out the turkey sandwiches I had packed for tonight's dinner, along with an apple and a crispy granola bar. After I ate, I heated some water for a thermos of coffee, washed up my few items, repacked everything and made use of the bear boxes for food storage that were provided by the ranger station. I settled in for the night, sitting by my small fire, sipping my coffee, and thinking about the day. Fifteen miles, equivalent to slightly more than a half marathon and here I was, at tonight's finish line. For me, this was a huge milestone. Mum would be proud. I texted Marshall to check in, verified tomorrow night's camp site with him and turned off my cell, setting into sleep.



MY ALARM WENT OFF at four in the morning and I rose within minutes, quickly taking care of restroom and washing duties, I ate a simple breakfast of fruit and granola, broke down my site and set out. I had a small sense of pride as I observed the surrounding hikers all doing the same thing, saluting me with nods and greetings as we went about our routines. There was a peace in the dark morning that I had never noticed before, almost spiritual. My eyes teared up from the beauty of it and I quietly thanked God for allowing me to experience this moment. Whether or not I finished this trek,

I had come further than I had ever dreamed. This could be enough, but I knew I would go on until I finished or until I could physically not continue.

When seven rolled around. I was ready for a break and found a pleasant spot just off the trail to sit for a few minutes. I drank some water, munched on an apple and some raisins, and set off again. I set my alarm again for three hours, enjoying the beginning of a routine. I thought about my dad a lot as I went along. From my old memories, he had enjoyed being outside. I imagined us on this hike or something like it.

It made me smile to imagine the conversations we might have had on our adventures, teaching moments of fishing, hunting or archery or maybe parenting moments like understanding females, sex and relationships. I no longer felt like I had been shorted from those moments, just sad that we never had the chance to have them. I had been angry for so long I had almost lost the few memories of him that I had left to cherish.

My daydreams took the better part of the morning as I aimlessly walked along, smiling at the few other hikers that I had passed. Sipping on water or munching on trail mix as the urge struck. I was surprised when my alarm beeped again, vibrating gently on my wrist to signal lunchtime. I tapped it to turn it off, and kept walking along, but now idly looking for a place to sit and eat. I found a log a few yards off the path and happily shrugged my pack off my back, grateful to be setting it down. I had spent most of last year training for this trip but carrying that type of weight certainly was taking a toll on my back and shoulders.

I stretched before digging around for my last set of turkey sandwiches. The cold pack would be approaching lukewarm soon. I pulled the foil packages out with a small package of carrot sticks, and some trail mix and sat back against the tree trunk to eat. I drifted into my thoughts as I ate,

watching the afternoon but not really seeing it, as memories flooded my mind. My alarm startled me twenty minutes later, breaking me out of my trance.

I looked around quickly before I realized what the beeping was. Tapping my watch turned it off, and I stood up to settle my pack on my back. I adjusted my straps, rolled up the insulated pack my food had been up, stored it and the pack away for later disposal and headed back onto the trail. I was happy to be moving again, as my last set of memories hadn't been so pleasant. So many painful memories of my mum and I, so many cruel moments that I could never take back; I'd give anything to just hug her now. I felt my face flush with emotion, and I cleared my throat just for a distraction.

This was my way of setting things right. I knew she was watching me, and I knew she would be proud of me. That is all she ever wanted, for me to be alright. This was my way to let her know, to let them both know, that I was doing fine. That I would be okay. I picked up my pace, hoping for a bit of speed and a light workout now that the sun had gotten higher. I hoped the pace would keep me a more focused, only on day two, and my memories were already kicking my ass.



I MARCHED DOWN THE trail, determined to make camp by six that evening. I focused on the trail in front of me rather than my memories, choosing instead to observe the surrounding forest. It was peaceful here, not silent, but quiet. Animal and insect noises rustled all around me, in the brush and in the thick canopy overhead. Voices of other hikers filtered to

me as hushed murmurs and whispers carried on the slight wind that rustled high in the trees. I wasn't absolutely alone out here and that was a comforting thought, even though I was a lone hiker. People were all around me, if I chose to interact with them, or if I needed help.

The hours passed, and I made camp fifteen minutes before six, aching, sweating and tired as hell, but prouder of myself than I was the night before. I settled in quickly, refilling my water from the pump, rinsing my face, and setting up my single tent and cook set. After a quick dinner of a backpacker style beef stew, which wasn't too bad, despite how it looked, I sat by my small fire and relaxed while I brewed a small pot of coffee.

I nodded politely at some other hikers as they passed by, headed to surrounding camping sites or the water pumps. I recognized several of them from the night before. Comforted by their presence, I finished making the coffee, cleaned up the small pot and utensils and took the thermos into my tent to sip on while I looked over the trail map for the next day. I called Marshall as I did that, checking in and confirming my next location. I would not call him for two days now, as part of this excursion was intended for me to grow and learn on my own. As my hike went on, I would check in less frequently, but enough to let him know that I was okay.

My hike today had totaled fifteen miles, and I was right on track to make the next location. Formal campsites from here on out would be few and far in-between, and the water pumps would become more spaced out. I was entering the genuine part of the trail, and it would become a lot more challenging the further I went. I was excited about it. I was determined to see this trip through, to prove to myself that I was still worthy of my life, despite my horrible start in society.

I'm not really sure why hiking the PNT got in my head as the thing to do to prove my worth. Maybe it was the brutality of it, the actual ordeal of over six weeks alone in the woods, rain, or shine, completely alone in the elements. Having no one to do it for you, no one to lean on, no one but yourself. I had depended on my mum for so long that I felt like this was my penance. This would be my punishment and my redeemer. I guess I felt that if I finished this trail under my own power, that she would forgive me. That somehow, I would know that I was worthy of forgiveness, and a life of my own.

Whatever the reason, it had stuck in my head, and nothing could shake it loose. For better or worse, I was here now, and I would see it through.



IN THE MORNING, I quickly broke camp, grabbed a few breakfast items to eat on the go, and set off to refill my water pack already settled on my back. It had only been a few days, but I was feeling stronger and more confident carrying that much weight. My months of working out before this trip had done wonders, but nothing can really prepare you for lugging around seventy pounds on your back for ten hours straight. I could feel the straps rubbing against the bruises on my shoulders and I adjusted them once I filled the water. Dawn was just peeking through the leaves overhead, sending slivers of pink, peach, and gold to set fire to the ground below.

I set off on the trail, apple in one hand, and a smile on my face. I felt like I existed inside a cocoon of trees, moss, and warmth. The scents were comforting, rather than conflicting, reminded me of Christmas before my dad passed away. We always had the biggest pine tree in the front window,

the smell drifting through the house and mingling with mum's sugar cookies, pumpkin pies, and fresh breads.

She baked for weeks before Christmas, preparing for parties and visits from family and friends. I inhaled deeply, smelling the fir, pine, and birch, the damp moss, the crisp scent of the fresh water that trickled nearby, all mixed into one heavenly perfume. The only thing missing were the cookies. I smiled wistfully. No cookies for me anymore; apples, oranges, and trail food for a long time to come. I bit into my apple as I continued down the trail, smiling at a young couple that were resting just off the path.

Sunrise was in full effect now and the smells that it had awakened were incredible. The heat from the sunshine elevated the woodsy scent to a whole new level; this was what you missed in the city and the suburbs. The fresh scent of nature, living, breathing forest surrounding you with life and sustenance. Flowers unfurling as the light kisses their petals, squirrels chirping and rummaging through the trees, birdsong filling the silence, and insects scurrying back and forth under the damp underbrush.

Thoughts of Christmases past stayed on my mind for the next hour as I trudged along, several tears escaped my eyes as I remember my dad's face, clearly, for the first time in a decade. His loud laugh, bright smile, the stern look he would pin on me when I began misbehaving, all the things a father should be, he was and more. Those were happy times. When we lost him, mum and I lost our way for good.



I WAS SAD, BUT in a comforting kind of way. I had almost forgotten the face of my father, and the sound of his laugh. It was nice to have had such a

clear memory for the first time in a while. I had spent so much time and effort being bitter and blaming my mum for everything that I had locked all wonderful memories of life before deep in a part of my brain that I rarely visited. I never allowed myself to smile, not for a second, so intent was I on letting mum know how utterly miserable I was, that I forgot to realize, even for a second, that she had lost her husband, the love of her life. The man she had hoped to spend forever with, instead she got grief and decades of abuse by an absolute shit of a son.

Tears suddenly filled my eyes as that last thought truly hit me for the first time and I stopped walking, filled with shame at my ignorance. Yes, I had been a grieving child, but I was old enough to have realized at some point that we both were grieving, horribly devastated by our mutual loss. If not then, at least later, as I grew older; I should have realized I should have, but I had not, blinded by bitter resentment and imagined slights. I turned off the path slightly and leaned against the thick trunk of the tree, sniffing as the tears overflowed my eyes and dripped down my cheeks.

I turned slightly away from the path, not embarrassed by my breakdown, but also not wanting a kind stranger to stop to comfort me. I wanted the pain. I deserved the pain. There was a part of me that needed to feel it. I had been a disgrace and the full force of the misery I had sentenced myself and my mother to was finally staring me in the face. I was not proud of what I had done. This is what my hiking through the PNT was for, my punishment for all I had done. This was not a pleasure cruise for me. It was going to be sheer hell and the hardest thing I had ever done. This was owed to my mother. I would follow through.

I allowed myself a few minutes to grieve before I wiped my face, took a drink of water, and walked back over to the path. A few people had passed

by while I was lost in my misery and thankfully, none had stopped to see if I needed any help. I adjusted my pack and set off once more, stepping over twigs, acorns, and pinecones as I went along. The trail delved into a slight downgrade, and I enjoyed the bit of a break on my legs as the slope aided my progress. I planned to get in another fifteen miles today and so far, was making significant progress, even with my unplanned trip down memory lane.



CAMP TONIGHT WOULD BE in a small clearing. There were no more ranger stations or hiker cabins on this leg of the journey. For the next seven days, I would camp in whatever location seemed suitable when I made my stop for the night. By midday on the seventh day, I would reach the first small town on my itinerary. There I would pick up my first package of fresh supplies from Marshall, sleep in a small hiker's hostel that many of the small towns along the PNT offered, and hopefully, get a hot shower and a good meal too.

By noon, the sun was high in the sky and sweat poured down my back. I could feel my shirt sticking to my skin under the weight of my pack. I shifted the straps the best I could, trying to allow some cool air to alleviate the wetness, to no avail. The day was hot and humid; the underbrush crunched beneath my feet as I trudged along the path. The leaves were dry and dusty, and even the trees looked parched. I hoped for rain as I am sure the rest of the forest was doing too.

I didn't want to sleep on muddy ground, but right now, a cold downpour sounded great. I wiped sweat from my eyes as I looked around for a log or

stump to sit on for lunch. Nothing seemed to be close by, so I continued down the trail. There was a rather steep hill a few yards ahead, and I figured I would reach the top of it, then break somewhere for lunch. Sticking the straw from my water pouch in my mouth, I took several long drinks of the stale but cool water and sighed.

The hill was a long one, a slow, gradual incline, but much longer than I had expected. When I finally reached the top, my calves were screaming for a break. I spotted a small clearing about fifty feet from the trail and headed for it, happy to have a clear spot to rest. Reaching it, I dropped my pack near the trunk of a large elm and hurried a few dozen paces away to take a piss. I hadn't realized how much I needed to go until I had removed my pack. Relieved and chuckling at my sudden urgency, I walked back over to my pack and rummaged for some food. I grabbed a piece of fruit, some jerky and granola bars, and sat on the ground with my back against the tree. The shade was blissful, and I happily ate in silence, enjoying the peacefulness of the setting.

I set my timer for an hour and stretched out after my lunch, using my pack as backrest. I didn't plan to sleep but knew my legs and my shoulders needed a break. The trail was quiet, and I couldn't hear any other voices nearby. Insects buzzed in the grass, several butterflies flitted by, graceful in the gentle breeze as they landed on the scattered wildflowers. I watched them for a while, yawning as the sun grew warmer on my legs.

Chapter 3

A Sudden Pursuit

I MUST HAVE DRIFTED off a short while later, realizing that when I quickly snapped awake when I heard a commotion a few yards behind me in the woods. A loud rustling and the rushing of paws on the ground. I sat up, disoriented, and looked around to see several deer rushing past me. That couldn't be a good sign. I stood up as swiftly as I could and grabbed my backpack. Then I followed the deer back to the trail and started down the path. As I did so, I fumbled with one of the many netted side pouches and pulled out the bear spray, not sure if I would need it, but something had caused the deer to flee.

I stayed on the path, checking behind me as I went, not quite running but I was going at a brisk pace, hoping to put distance between myself and whatever had the animals spooked. Overheard, I heard wings beating the air and looked up to see dozens of birds taking flight, disappearing above the treetops. More rustling in the surrounding forest followed, and I saw several rabbits, and squirrels disappearing into their nests hidden in the nearby trees and underbrush.

My heart was racing in my chest as I realized that something unusual was happening and I was alone out here. I hadn't seen another hiker since I resumed the trail, and I couldn't be sure that any were within shouting distance either. A bear was seeing more and more likely as the smaller animals sought places to hide. Far behind me, I could hear something large crashing through the brush. Not knowing what to do, I ran down the path, clutching at the straps across my shoulders, bear spray grasped tightly in one hand.

I would need to hide or hope I could get far enough ahead that it would catch whatever it was pursuing and move on. The pack bounced and jostled on my back as I jogged along, dodging tree roots and rocks, but I was loathe to get off the trail, that wouldn't be smart in this panicked state, but how long would I have a choice? I pushed the thoughts away as I crested a small hill and spotted a narrow pathway that led off the one I was following. I could see a bright patch of daylight ahead and veered towards it, hoping it led away from whatever was in pursuit of something out here. But what if it was pursuing me?

My heart skipped a beat at the thought as I jogged down the narrow track, branches whipping at my face and arms, scratching me as I ran past. I could see the trail widening about fifty yards ahead and I put everything I had into the last stretch. My legs were burning, and my shoulders felt like they had been rubbed raw from the weight of the pack bouncing on it, but I ignored it.

These were not major concerns. More rustling came from the area all around me, as animals and birds came alive, desperate to get away from what pounded down the main trail. I didn't slow down to look but burst into

the clearing ahead, and kept going straight across it, back into the woods on the other side, down a small embankment and across a stream.

I finally stopped about a hundred yards from the stream, gasping for air. I doubled over, dropping my pack, chest heaving, and tried to catch my breath. I kept looking ahead of me, not willing to drop my gaze for even a moment while I waited for whatever fate was going to bring. Seconds passed, then a minute, and another minute as I waited, breathing hard, sweat dripping down my face, and stinging my eyes. I noticed the silence then as the blood ceased to pound in my ears and my heart returned to normal.

I slung my arm through my pack and dragged it as I sidestepped behind a thick stand of firs, stepping to the middle of them as I watched from between the branches. The snapping of branches and tumbling of rocks could be heard as the thing burst through the clearing but stopped at the patch of sunlight. I could only make out an enormous shadow, something on all fours, standing at least four foot tall. I caught of glimpse of eyes glittering in the shadows as the massive head scanned the area beyond the stream.



I WAS BARELY BREATHING as I watched it, confused and grateful by its sudden stop, but terrified all the same. It wasn't a bear, but it didn't look like a wolf from my vantage point, either. I watched as it reared up on its hind legs, sniffed the air, and again, swung its head in my direction. I would have sworn its eyes narrowed as it tried to see beyond the trees. I didn't move, didn't twitch as it studied the tree line, then turned back to bound back down the path.

I exhaled slowly as it disappeared, still frozen to the spot. I did not know what kind of animal it was. It had more fun than a cougar or a bobcat. It sure wasn't a wolf, but maybe it was some type of crossbreed of a wolf and some other animal. It looked too small to be a bear, but it's not like I had much experience with animals. I was just glad it was gone. It was almost five full minutes before my muscles relaxed and my shaking stopped. The forest had returned to normal, birds chirping, animals rustling quietly in the background as life around me breathed again. Safe, for now.

I sat on the ground and leaned against the tree, suddenly drained. I was also none too eager to head back down the path the creature had taken. I opened my canteen and fished a granola bar from my pack. I ate slowly, allowing a full thirty minutes to pass while I rested. I sent a message off to Marshall, too, letting him know what happened and sent him my new coordinates. Then, I checked my trail map and my watch; if I set off again now, I could still make my next planned stop, fifteen miles away. I sighed and stood up, settling my pack on my back once more, but I kept the bear spray close at hand.

Still wary of every sound, I made my way back across the stream toward the sunny clearing and paused, taking a moment to look around where the animal had stopped just shy of the bright patch of land, trying to understand why it had stopped. Nothing stood out to me, but it still struck me as odd behavior. Maybe the animal was nocturnal, and something had spooked it from wherever it dwelled, and its eyes just aren't made for the sun. It seemed unlikely, but my brain accepted it as plausible, but only barely.

I shrugged and kept going through the narrow trail, back to the main one. Nothing followed me as I went, but I kept up a brisk pace, urging myself to go faster. I would feel better the further away from here I got. It was barely

noon, so I had about eight hours of daylight left. I was covering a little over two miles an hour, so I should get to my location with time to set up my tent before it was too dark to see. Satisfied with my plan, and content with my progress, I could focus on my route, rather than the beast lurking in the woods.



A SENSE OF CALM had fully returned to the landscape as the underbrush glimmered in the sunlight, an amber glow making the leaves seem vibrant and glossy. Insects buzzed around, crickets and tree frogs could be heard and the almost constant rustling of squirrels or birds overhead. A gentle breeze had started, and it felt great on my sweat-soaked skin. I wanted to regain the sense of calm that the abundant forest life around me had reclaimed, but it eluded me.

The back of my brain was still on high alert, even as I tried a variety of ways to distract myself. I tried to name the trees that I passed to occupy my mind: birch, fir, asp, oak, elm, pine. When that failed, I began reciting the pies my mother used to bake for the holidays; my favorites were her pumpkin and Dutch apple, but she made a fabulous berry cobbler that I also loved. Those thoughts only made my stomach rumble in protest.

I shrugged off the hunger pangs and kept going, trying a new tactic, memories of my father were always elusive for me but being here, I was remembering some of them. I remembered him teaching me how to ride a bike when I was about seven years old. It was orange and black, reminded me of Halloween, which had been my favorite holiday. He spent hours walking me up and down our driveway and along our street, patiently

guiding me as I fumbled with learning to brake, and how to safely stop and dismount without falling off.

I smiled then as that thought led to another one of us riding through the park a few months later. It had been my first-time riding without the training wheels, and it had been a bright spring day. I remember going down a hill, super-fast for the first time, loving how the wind felt against my face and how it billowed up my shirt sleeves and puffed it out around me. I was so proud when I beat my dad to the bottom and could stop with no issues.

I remember how surprised I had been when he stopped by the small lake, then pulled off his backpack, asking if I was ready for lunch. I thought we were going home for lunch, but my mom had packed us a picnic to go. It was rare that I had any one-on-one time with my dad; he was always so busy, but that day, it felt like we had all the time in the world.

Sadly, less than four months later, he was gone. I can still remember what we had that day: cold turkey sandwiches, with Swiss cheese, homemade brownies with chocolate chips in them and thick swirls of fudge icing. There had been a small bag of pretzels and an apple for each of us, along with bottles of water, and a small apple juice for me. It's weird the insignificant details we remember, the little things that stick with us, and define us along the way. Apple juice hadn't tasted as good since. I distinctly remember telling my mom that I hated it, shortly after my dad had died, which I followed with a spiteful and childish, "I hate you!" as I stomped off to my room, not realizing yet just how deeply I had wounded her. It would take me almost twenty years to understand what I had started that day.



I SNIFFLED AS I felt my nose run, and then smiled ruefully, realizing that I had started to cry once more. My thoughts releasing another bout of grief that I was at least better equipped to handle now than I had been then. This time I understood that not only was I grieving for my parents, but for myself, for what I had lost, for how much I had lost. It wasn't just that I lost my mom and my dad, but I had lost part of myself, part of who I could I had been, the happier life I could have had, the son I should have been, and the memories that I should have of time with my mother. All of that was finding release now. As painful as it was, I understood that there was nothing I could change about my past, but I could be a better person now, and as I moved through this life.

I made it to my next destination with a few minutes of daylight to spare, tired but proud that I had still met my goal for the day. Quickly, I set up my tent, assembled a few things for a fire pit and got that going. Once I had my meal heating for the night, I handled some personal business behind the trees, then returned to my camp, relieved and ready to rest and recharge. As I ate, I sent a message to Marshall, then checked my map for the next day.

I would reach the pathway to the first town, Eureka, Montana, in two days' time. I had made better time than I had hoped for, averaging about fifteen miles a day. There I would collect my package of supplies from Marshall, stay the night in the small bed-and-breakfast I had reserved, and hopefully, spend an ample amount of time in a hot shower. It had been a quiet day on the trail, and I had passed no one until late afternoon, a couple

headed back past me, and two thru trekkers comfortably resting next to the trail.

I chatted with them for a few minutes, accepted an apple, and listened to them gossip like old biddies about the trail talk. My ears perked up at the mention of a large animal roaming around, but no one had agreed on what it was. The older man, Terry, claimed he heard it was a wolf, but his companion, Jerry, had snorted and said no, just a young bear.

“Folks out here get spooked by the first furry creature they see. Bunch of newbies wanting to discover nature and be one with Mother Nature but can’t tell a wolf from a bear.” He guffawed and slapped his knee as the older man just shook his head.

“Well, either way, folks need to be careful out here.” He looked at me and asked if I had my bear spray and I said that I did. He nodded his approval and tossed another apple at me.

“Are you headed into town up the way?” He had asked then. I said that I was, and he let clue me in on where to go eat. “The best diner in town is ‘Shorty’s Shack’,” he said, then chuckled. “That man knows how to feed us trekkers. He’ll give you a package to go too, all part of his deal. He’s a good man, that one.”

I thanked them when the gossip ran out and continued down the path, both relieved and troubled by the fact that other trekkers had been seeing strange animals too, or maybe just strange to them. I would be fine if I stuck to the trail and kept my wits about me. I had completed some training on animal attacks and how to best protect myself, but there was always that doubt that lingered in the quiet spaces in my mind.

The “what if” syndrome, as I call it. *What If I freeze up? What if I forget what to do? What if I drop the bear spray? What if...* just constant negative

thoughts that try to invade the rational side of thought?

I shook those thoughts from my mind as I prepared to call it a night. Eager for the next day, with people, hot food, and hot showers. It would be nice to see a town again, no matter how small. My first eight days on the trail were incredible, but the sense of isolation is profound. Civilization would be a welcome sight.



EAGER TO GET STARTED the next day, I rose promptly when my alarm went off at 4am. I broke camp quickly, having the process down to a science as I ran through my mental checklist to ensure that I skipped nothing. I made sure the fire pit was cool, dumped more water on it, and put another shovel of dirt over it. I ate standing over the fire pit, watching for any errant embers or smoke, but the fire had gone out hours ago. Satisfied, I finished the quick bit of trail mix and my apple, heaved my pack onto my shoulders, wincing slightly as it settled into the bruised places on my shoulders, then turned to the trail once more.

I loved the smell of the trail, especially in the early hours of dawn, the leaves and plant life still fresh with dew, the earthy smell of the damp soil and tree bark, the clean smell of the nearby stream gently swirling amidst the rocks. My favorite part was when the sun rose and warmed the forest, the smells deepened and grew richer, reminiscent of fall campfires, s'mores, and ghost stories. The colors brightened and set the world ablaze, vibrant golds, bronze, coppers, reds, and yellows all swirling into existence, surreal and dizzying if one were to look up into the painted canopy overhead for too long of a time.

My time on the trail had been short so far, just over a week, and I found myself wondering once more how I had missed so much beauty in the world. I had a lot of life to catch up on and a lot of redeeming to do for my past sins. I was more motivated than ever to live my life in the most positive and giving way that I could.

I stopped for a quick break just before eight in the morning, in need of water and a tree to pee on. I handled my business first, then got my water out, drank half of it down, and fished out a couple pieces of jerky from my pack. I walked as I ate, enjoying the hike, the feel of the cool breeze on my sweaty skin. I had gotten used to my own odor and was learning to relish the feel of the pain in my legs and back. Proof that I was alive and doing exactly what I had set out to do. Proof that I was not a failure and was actively pursuing my own transformation into the man my parents would have been proud of.

By noon, I had gone about halfway and was nearing the trail that would take me into town. I knew I should reach it by seven that night and be able to collapse gratefully into a bed, after a long shower, and a hot meal at the closest diner. I would find the post office the next day, retrieve my package from Marshall, then go over my inventory fully before I left the following morning. There was a store in town where I could gather more supplies and hopefully be able to purchase a couple of fresh food items that I could eat over the next couple of days.

Ice sounded heavenly right now, a tall glass of water full of thick chunks of ice, sparkling in the light, condensation running down the slick sides of the glass as I drank it down. I missed ice, in a very weird way. I was almost aroused just visualizing the frost glass. Clearly, I had been out here too long. I chuckled and swallowed the dry jerky, taking another pull of the

lukewarm water from the bladder inside my pack. It was wet, but certainly not cold or refreshing. I sighed and yanked on my straps a bit, settling my hands under each one to help ease the strain as I trudged along.

Two miles later, I stepped into the clearing and saw the signs for town. An actual grin split my face, and I quickened my steps as I went toward the gravel road, eager to see a building, a fence post, a person. While I was not exactly skipping down the road, my pace was faster and my anticipated relief growing.

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Chapter 4

Civilization

THIRTY MINUTES LATER, I reached the town. It was lovely, a picturesque Main St. with small shops, and diners lining it. Cars parked along either side, townsfolk going about their day-to-day business. The air was crisp and leaves of every color hung from the trees that lined the street and stretched for miles just behind it, bordering the trail that I had just come from. My stomach growled as fresh food smells drifted toward me: baking bread, pies, French Fries. I sniffed in appreciation and then began looking for the address of my rooming house for the night. I reminded myself that food could wait a few more minutes even though my mouth was watering at the thought of a freshly cooked meal.

Less than ten minutes later, just three blocks past the small library, I found the bed-and-breakfast. It was a lovely house with a large wrap-around porch, filled with rockers and porch swings. Framed by a waist-high wrought-iron fence, a pathway lined with flowers, and a large yard to one side that was set up with a patio area with a grill, comfortable furniture, and a fire pit. It looked like a perfect place to relax on a quiet evening.

I walked up to the front door and rang the bell as my confirmation had instructed and shortly, a lovely older woman answered the door with a gracious smile. "Hello, you must be Garrison." She said, sounding every bit as if I imagined a grandmother might greet her grandchild. I was smitten immediately.

"I am indeed." I responded with a smile, feeling my cheeks redden. This woman was just so charming and elegant. I never had a grandmother, but if I could pick one and the perfect setting for her, this would be it.

"Well. Come on in. My name is Gertrude, Gertrude Swann, but you can call me Trudy. Can't keep you standing there with that big backpack on. You must be exhausted. You hikers always are by the time you reach your first town." She waved to me inside, stepping back as I entered. As she closed the door behind me, I was greeted with an enormous staircase, inviting rooms were set on either side of me and a long hallway ran parallel to the stairs. I shrugged my pack off and winced a bit as the straps slid across the bruises and then sighed with relief when I set it down.

"Let's just leave that there while I give you the tour. We can come back for it. The kitchen is this way. You look like you could use a cold drink." She chuckled kindly and led the way down the hallway towards the back of the house. I followed, taking in the elegant décor of the house. Family portraits lined this hallway and several antique console tables stood along it, dotted with smaller pictures and vases of fresh flowers.

It smelled strongly of cinnamon the closer to the kitchen we were, and it reminded me of home. I was struck with grief and homesickness so suddenly that I had to stop walking for a moment and catch my breath. I felt my eyes well up with tears and rapidly blinked them away as she turned to check on me.

“Are you alright?” she asked, genuine concern in her voice.

“Yes, ma’am. I’m fine. Just needed a minute. These pictures are lovely, by the way.” I added with forced cheer, hoping she didn’t notice how my voice broke.

“They are indeed. All family, every last one.” She came to stand next to me, smelling like a delightful mix of lavender and rosewater. She picked up one of the silver frames on the nearest table. “These are all hikers. Everyone that has stayed here gets a spot in the hallway.” She beamed with pride and showed me another one.

“This young man stays here every few years, whether he is hiking or not, just to visit me.” She set it down and pointed at a group picture hanging over it. “This group was just delightful. All thru trekkers, who did not know each other when they started but had all booked their first room night here. By the time they left, they had decided to hike the rest together. Now, they do it every four years.” She turned to me and patted my arm, “and you’ll get your picture taken before you leave.”

“Now then, let’s get you a drink and get on the with the tour. There’s a plate of fresh cinnamon rolls in here waiting for you, too.” We both laughed when my stomach chose that moment to growl.

I followed her into the inviting kitchen and sat down at the oval table beside the window, when urged to do so. A whole platter of fresh rolls sat in the middle next to a tray piled with cookies. The aroma drifting through the air was magic. She handed me a small plate and a couple of napkins, then busied herself at the counter for a moment, retrieving a water glass and filling it with ice and water. She brought it over and sat down across from me, pouring herself a cup of coffee from the waiting carafe on the table.

“Eat, please.” She smiled, pushing the rolls toward me. “No need to be polite on my account.” I returned her smile, blushing to my ears, and took a roll, wasting no time in biting into it. Sheer bliss filled my mouth and my tastebuds delighted in the flavors.

“This is incredible, ma’am, truly.” I said, after finishing the first bite. “It’s been a long time since I have had anything homemade.” She beamed with pride as I took another bite.

We sat in comfort for a few minutes, enjoying the pastries and making small talk. She talked to me about her many guests over the years, her husband that had passed on, and how much she loved the town and the trekkers. Of course, there had been a few troublesome guests, but they were always quickly handled by other guests, but I had no doubt that she would be capable of handling most incidents on her own. She was delightful, but gave off a powerful confidence that I enjoyed. She was no dainty flower; she was strong and capable like my mother had been.

I was struck by a bit of sadness once more and she saw my face fall as I sat back in my chair, full of food, heavy of heart, and altogether exhausted.

“Are you alright, dear?” She asked, concern brimming over in her bright eyes. She reached over and squeezed my hand. “Come, you must be exhausted. Let’s get you settled in. I’m sure you could use a shower or a nap before dinner.”

“That sounds amazing right now.” I agreed as I stood and gathered my dishes, but she waved me off, taking them from me instead.

“Shoo. I’ve got this. Go on and grab your things. I’ll meet you by the stairs in a moment.” She smiled warmly at me as she turned toward the sink and I did as I was told, leaving the warmth of the kitchen for the sun-drenched entryway to gather my pack.

Within minutes, she had joined me and was leading the way up the stairs, past several rooms, to a staircase at the end of the hall. She led me up the smaller flight that opened on another level, just as warm and inviting as the rest of the house. A small living room sat at the top of the stairs with plush sofas, several armchairs, a television mounted on one wall and a media tower filled with books and movies.

I followed her past it to a narrow hallway and to the room at the back. She opened it to reveal a cozy room with a full bed, an antique wardrobe, and matching nightstands. A small pair of windows sat over the small console table on the far side, and an armchair sat in one corner.

“This will be your room.” She said with a bright smile. “I thought you would appreciate the privacy. The lounge is fully stocked with movies and things, and there is a small fridge in the corner filled with drinks and snacks. The bathroom is just opposite this room and there’s plenty of hot water, so feel free to take your time. There’s a tub for soaking and a shower. Towels are in the cabinet, just put the used ones in the hamper when you are finished.” She moved about the room and the hallway, opening the bathroom door and gesturing to various items as she spoke. Again, I blushed at her genuine warmth and personality. If I could adopt her, I would have.

“There are plenty of soaps, shaving items, and other such grooming needs in the other cabinet. Help yourself to anything that you might need. It’s all there for the guests. If you need something that you do not have or see, just ask.”

I thanked her profusely and had to resist the urge to hug her. I knew I was tired and more than a little emotional, but I rarely had a desire for human

contact, but right now, all I wanted, desperately, was a hug. She patted my hand and turned to leave.

“Alright then, I’ll leave you to it. There will be two more guests on the second floor tonight, and dinner will be in about an hour.” She stepped out into the hallway, then continued to speak, “You can find me in the kitchen, or living room, downstairs should you need me.”

She turned to leave, and I sank gratefully into the armchair, relishing the softness of the cushions as I relaxed into it. It felt amazing to sit on something other than logs or the ground. I sat there for a few minutes, letting the few tears trickle down my face as I acknowledged my grief and my regrets once more. I knew exhaustion was a big factor in my emotional state, but this trip was not meant to be easy or a vacation. It was meant as penance and I would allow myself to feel everything that I needed to along the way.



DINNER THAT NIGHT WAS a pleasant affair, weary travelers and trail conversation mixed well with a hot meal and our hosts’ gracious attention. The newcomers were Jack and Dotty, a newlywed couple from New Orleans, both new to hiking. They were hiking the trail to celebrate their honeymoon and their graduation from medical school, a much-needed vacation from several stressful years of studying and wedding planning. They were both friendly and outgoing; he was charismatic, and she was funny; the conversation flowed smoothly as we dined on the hearty chicken pot pie that Trudy had prepared. She had truly outdone herself with the dinner spread, at least in my opinion, and trust me, I know food.

The pastry was flaky and light, the chicken and vegetables were perfectly cooked, and the rolls she made to go with it were pure perfection. The scent of the apple pie she had made earlier that afternoon had filled the entire house with its aroma, and I couldn't wait to have a slice.

"So where are you from, Garrison?" Jack asked as he leaned back in his chair with a contented sigh.

"Oh, I'm from a little town in Illinois, a place called Carbon Cliff."

"Never heard of it." Came the expected reply.

"Not many people have," I chuckled as I answered with a smile. "It's a tiny town outside of Moline. Nice enough place, just small and quiet, uneventful."

"Ah, Moline, I have heard of. That's a big city there." He responded. "We've not traveled too much yet, been caught up with school, but we are both big into outdoor stuff. I'm sure the others that we have met can peg us as total rookies from a mile away." He laughed.

"How long have you been hiking, Garrison? Got any tips for two new adventurers?" Dotty chimed in, her warm smile filling the room.

"This is my first time too; guess we are all rookies." I replied, then turned my attention to Trudy, who had started to clean up. "Let me help you clean up." I said, rising from my seat and retrieving my place setting.

"Nonsense, young man. Just making room for the pie." She replied, bustling away to the kitchen.

"I'll be right back." I said to Jack and Dotty, "I don't feel right just letting her clean-up after she cooked all day."

"We can help too." Dotty chimed in, rising from her chair and gathering the dinner items. Jack did the same and within minutes the table was

cleared, and Trudy was chasing us out of the kitchen, but with a friendly smile on her face.

“I told you kids that you did not have to do that, but thank you.” The older woman said as she returned to the table with the heavenly smelling pie and a tub of French Vanilla ice cream. “I’m so used to waiting on everyone else that I’ve just settled into doing it all myself. It’s nice to have helpful folks around. Most of your fellow trekkers have all been great, but you guys are certainly some of the nicest that I’ve met this year.”

Dotty emerged from the kitchen with the coffee pot and the creamer from the fridge. “Refills, anyone?” she asked, smiling as she wagged the creamer at us.

“I would love some.” I said, lifting my mug, and Jack was quick to do the same.

She filled our mugs and Trudy’s before taking the pot back to the kitchen. By the time she settled into her chair again, the pie had been served with generous heaps of ice cream.

“This looks incredible, Trudy. Thank you so much.” I said to her before taking a bite. It was every bit as wonderful as my taste buds had imagined. The expressions on Jack’s and Dotty’s faces implied they felt the same. Trudy beamed from the head of the table as we ate our pie. We talked more as we ate dessert, Trudy being quite the storyteller as she regaled us with some funny stories of past guests and their trail experiences. By the time the evening ended, my face and my stomach hurt, both from laughter and good food.

Chapter 5

Morning on Main

THE NEXT MORNING, I woke up early, much earlier than I had expected but life on the trail had acclimated my inner clock to early rising. I took my time getting ready for the day, happy to know I had a full day to explore the town, indulge in some greasy food from the diner, and pick up my fresh supplies from Marshall.

Trudy had made us promise to be back in time for an early dinner as she was having a picnic style meal outside on the patio and two seasoned trekkers were due in this afternoon as well. I was excited to hear of this news and I hoping, as were Jack and Dotty, to gain some trail knowledge from the pair.

I relished another hot shower, enjoying the heat on my skin and the luxury of a shower. It's funny the small things that we take for granted. I had only been on the trail a little over a week, but I missed running hot water more than I missed anything else. I could heat up food, my tent and sleeping gear were comfortable enough to get by, but nothing compared to a hot shower.

I made my way downstairs when I had dressed and found Jack and Dotty already in the kitchen with Trudy. A huge breakfast was already waiting, buffet style, on the counter, and I helped myself as I listened to their chatter. Eggs, sausage and biscuits, bacon, and fresh cinnamon rolls graced the sideboard, along with a fresh fruit salad and muffins. My stomach rumbled happily as I made my choices and poured myself a mug of steaming coffee.

“What does the day look like for you, Garrison? Dotty and I are going to see the town and grab some fresh supplies and food for the trail.” Jack asked as I joined them at the cozy kitchen table.

“Same for me. I have a supply package waiting for me at the store, and I heard about a diner that is supposed to serve a great lunch. After that, I guess wander the town for a bit, talk to some of the locals before heading back here for dinner.”

“Shall we go in together then, chat while we walk? Kind of silly not to, don’t you think?” Dotty said, chuckling as Jack grinned at me and nodded.

“Sure, of course, otherwise it would just look like I’m tailing you.” I smiled as I accepted their offer.

“Trudy, breakfast was amazing. You are truly an incredible hostess.” Dotty said to the older woman, standing to clear her and Jack’s dishes.

“Thank you, dear. It gives me such joy to have guests to cook for again. It’s been so hard since George passed on. This bed-and-breakfast venture gave me a new purpose.” Trudy smiled and began preparing a fresh pot of coffee.

“The door remains unlocked, so feel free to come and go as you please. There is a laundry room on the second floor if you have any items that could use a wash before you set out on the trail again. I’ll leave you folks to

it.” Trudy set out some to-go cups for the coffee and gestured at them as she turned back to us.

“Coffee, fresh to go, if you’d like. Enjoy the town and I’ll see you folks back here for dinner.” She smiled warmly at us, and I felt my smile spread across my face in return and I could feel myself blushing once more as I admired just how elegant and gracious she truly was. She was one of the good ones that my mum always spoke of when she had tried to warn me about people in the world.

“Sometimes, Garrison, you will run across one of the good ones, and you’ll know it by the light that radiates from within them. Bad people do not carry the light with them, not like that. Look for that light, and you’ll be alright.”

I felt a sudden lump in my throat at the memory and had to blink away the onslaught of tears as my mum’s soft voice echoed in my mind.

I busied myself with my breakfast as she left the room, hoping the others wouldn’t notice my sudden unease. The food really was delicious, and I wasted no time in eating finishing my plate. Jack and Dotty happily chatted quietly as they made coffee to take with us, and I nodded when Dotty offered to prepare one for me too.

When I finished, I cleared my plate and accepted the coffee from Dotty. Jack led the way down the hall to the staircase where we stood patting pockets, checking for cell phones, wallets, other essentials. Sheepishly, Dotty giggled and then headed upstairs.

“Be right back, fellas, forgot my phone.”

Jack smiled at me as he watched her go. I shrugged good-naturedly as I donned my vest and zipped it up.

“No rush, anyway. It’s barely eight-thirty.” I said, just for something to say.

“Very true. She is just funny like that. It’s her thing, you know? She is the smartest female I know, but always forgets something when we are getting to leave for somewhere. Every time.” Jack smiled again. “It’s part of her charm, though, one of those little things that I love about her. It gives me a chance to be needed.”

“What do you mean?” I asked, truly curious of his meaning. My experience with love, relationships, or women was zero, but I found his turn of phrase interesting.

“Mean by what?” he said, struggling with his jacket zipper.

“A chance to be needed. Doesn’t she always need you? Isn’t that why she married you?”

“No, not exactly. She loves me. She needs me as her companion, as her partner, the way you would want any loved around, but no, she doesn’t *need* me. Dotty is very capable, always self-sufficient, and rarely asks for help from anyone.” He paused, thinking about what he wanted to say next, then reddened a bit when he spoke again. “When she forgets where she put things or forgets to check her pockets or her purse for things before we leave the house, it gives me the opportunity to help her, if only in a small way.”

“I guess I like to feel needed too, not just wanted, but that I have something useful for her, other than my studly body.” He flexed and laughed awkwardly, like sharing his feelings were new to him.

I laughed politely but was glad that he had answered so honestly. “I see. I guess I have a lot to learn about life still. Never had a girlfriend. Hell, I’ve

never had a friend.” I shrugged and looked down at my feet, weirdly embarrassed by my unexpected admission.

Footsteps made us glance up to see Dotty coming down, all smiles, and smelling like vanilla.

“Well, you do now, champ.” Jack gave a friendly pat on the back as Dotty joined us by the door.

“Who do what now?” Dotty said, looking at us with a raised eyebrow.

“He has new friends now, two of them.” Jack replied as he opened the door with a flourish and bowed to her. “After you, my lady.”

Dotty grinned at me, linked arms with me, and together we stepped over the threshold onto the porch. Jack followed, closing the door, and trailed us down the steps.

“Off we go.” He said, coffee in hand.

Dotty and I both raised ours in kind, and we set off down the sidewalk, gazing at the beautiful stately homes that lined the street.



THE MORNING WAS CRISP and full of sunshine. The light glowed through the trees, bringing the leaves to life in a golden rainbow of color. Yellows, gold, red, and bronze dotted the lawns and the street, and clung heavily to their trees, not yet willing to relinquish their hold.

We turned the corner to cross into the main street, and Dotty’s smile could not stretch any wider as she paused to just take it in.

“It’s so charming.” She exclaimed as we stopped beside her, all of us admiring the small town.

Stone planters lined the sidewalks, full of fall flowers in a dizzying array of colors, each interspersed between benches, parking meters, trash barrels, and mailboxes. Bright storefronts stood proudly on each side of the two-lane street. A flower shop, a small hobby and yarn shop, several small clothing boutiques, and other such stores. The diner sat about halfway down the block and several early diners stood outside, gathered in small clusters talking and sipping coffee from travel cups.

We walked along the sidewalks, pointing at unique items in the storefront windows. Dotty spotted the general store just a few stops from the diner and we headed inside. The friendly cashier found my packages quickly and then rang up the other items I had picked out while waiting.

Jack and Dotty spent a few minutes browsing the store, added their items to the basket that Dotty held, and joined me at the counter. With the shopping done, we found ourselves at a loss as to what to do next. We could return to the bed-and-breakfast and drop off our packages or carry them with us as we browsed. The cashier settled the discussion by offering to hold the packages behind the counter until we returned.

“Are you sure it’s no trouble?” I asked, after the cashier suggested it.

“Oh, sure, it’s fine. I do this for the trekkers all the time. Most of our business is from the hiking crowd. Take your time and enjoy the day.” The cashier answered. “My name is Larry, by the way. Larry Burns and this is my store. You’re in good hands here.”

“That’s so kind of you, Larry. Thank you.” Dotty said as she handed over their packages. Jack nodded his thanks, too.

“Yes, Larry. That’s real nice to do.” I said, also handing over my bags.

“Happy to do it. Gotta keep my customers happy!” Larry said with a chuckle. “Go on and get out there. Sunshine is wasting!”

With a final thanks, we said goodbye and headed out into the warm fall day. Just in the short time we had been inside the store, business had picked up on the street outside. Cars and people were much heavier now, a couple of backpackers were wandering down the sidewalk opposite, and the group of folks by the diner had dispersed.

“Well, I am going to go look around a bit more and I wanted to stop by the library, too. Do you all want to stay together or just meet at the diner for lunch?” I asked as we surveyed the busy street.

“Let’s meet at the diner. I know I wanted to see the shops and check out the hobby store, and I’m sure you will be bored to tears.” Dotty said, smiling.

“I’ll be bored to tears, too.” Jack snorted, rolling his eyes a little as he teased his new wife.

“Well, hey, why don’t you go with Garrison, and I can shop on my own?” She said.

Jack and I looked at each other and shrugged after a moment of silent communication.

“Sure, if you don’t mind?” Jack asked, still looking at me.

“Fine by me.” I replied, smiling.

With that settled, we wished Dotty happy shopping and turned the opposite direction, following the notes I had on my phone for the local library. Dotty wasted no time in crossing the street towards a specialty soap and candle shop.

“Library, huh? Looking for anything special?” Jack asked as we walked, whistling as we passed a fudge shop. The scent drifting from the open door was inviting and maddening, in equal parts. My stomach rumbled as we strode by, so I sipped my coffee again, hoping to suppress the urge.

“Just want to gain some insight into the animal life around this section of the trail. I saw something strange two nights back on the trail, and a couple of old-timers had a few stories about it too.”

“What was it?” Jack asked.

“I’m not sure. I’m not really from the country and I’ve never seen a wolf or a bear up close, but this thing didn’t look like any of the pictures that I’ve ever seen or like the ones at the zoo.” I shrugged. “It was big, wolf-like but not shaped right, somehow. Something seemed off about it. I was still a good distance away, but still, it almost looked like a cross between two animals, rather than just a wolf or a bear.”

“Weird.” Jack said, “maybe a trick of the light?”

“Possibly, but I thought while I was here, it couldn’t hurt to see what the natural wildlife is supposed to be and maybe ask some of the locals.” I said, “but I also wanted to get some information on the local legends and folklore. I thought it might be nice to learn a bit from each town I stop in, see if I can photocopy a couple stories to read on the trail while I’m in each area.”

“That will help stave off boredom, that’s for sure. And lighter than carrying books, plus you can burn the papers when you are done reading them in the campfire.” Jack said, and then pointed across the street. “That looks like a library to me.”

I looked over where Jack pointed and saw the stately Victorian flanked with white pillars and stone steps and smiled.

“Yes, it does. Let’s go check it out.”

Chapter 6

Library and Lunch

JACK LOOKED AROUND IN appreciation once inside the library. Straight ahead of us sat a massive stone fireplace, a golden fire already crackling within its confines. Four oversized leather chairs sat around it in a half circle with various stools and ottomans scattered close by. The registration desk sat on the far wall, and the stacks were situated in front of them, and all along both sides, short stacks in the open floor space with floor to ceiling shelves running down either side. Signs hung from gleaming beams overhead, clearing denoting each section. Classics, Folklore, Fiction, Children's, Sciences, Medical, and more, all marked and situated with choice volumes displayed on the end caps or on tables nearby.

Models, paintings, sculptures, and more sat within display cabinets, hung from all available wall space, and were scattered on top of the short stacks. Several hallways led away from the main room, with signs for the computer lounge, periodicals, study rooms, and more. It was beautifully designed without being pretentious and screamed comfort rather than silence.

I stood next to Jack, in awe of the surroundings. I turned slightly, taking it all in, before looking at Jack with an eyebrow raised.

“Not quite what I was expecting, either.” Jack said with a grin.

“It’s beautiful.” I said, looking around again. “Definitely not the small-town library I was expecting.”

“Well, folklore is right over there. Let’s go have a look.” Jack pointed to the left as he spoke.

“Right behind you.” Came my quiet reply as Jack set off between the stacks, weaving a path toward the tall bookshelves under the ‘Folklore’ sign.

As Jack came to a stop under the sign, I stepped into the aisle between the first set of shelves and began looking at the volumes of leather-bound tomes. Much of it was classic folklore from around the world, thick collections of gathered stories full of creatures, myths, and legends, but I was looking for local legends.

“All of this stuff looks great, really interesting, but I was hoping for more local lore.” I said to Jack, turning toward him as I spoke. Jack was paging through a thick volume, whistling softly under his breath at the artwork on the page.

“Look at this, man.” He said, showing me the page he was on. It depicted several demonic looking creatures with pointed hooves, curved talons, and devilish horns sprouting from their skulls. While creepy, the artwork was an exquisite black and white depiction, full of intricate details that showed themselves the longer you looked.

“That’s incredible, creepy as hell, but that’s an amazing illustration.”

“Right?” Jack said as he leafed through more pages. “So we need local lore, not global. Let me see what the librarian says. I’ll be right back.” He

turned and began walking to the desk, book still in hand.

I turned back to the shelves, scanning the titles as I went. I had my head tilted at that weird sideways angle that all book lovers seem to do when in a bookstore. I walked down the aisle reading the titles aloud: *Celtic Tales*, *The Book of Yokai: Mysterious Creatures of Japanese Folklore*, *Appalachian Folklore: Omens, Signs, and Superstitions*, *Superstitions from Around the World*, *Kitchen Witch*. I shook his head and continued further down the aisle. Then I spotted something and paused, pulling a book from the shelf, “The United States of Cryptids: A Tour of American Myths and Monsters”. I opened it and began leafing through the pages. The table of contents immediately made me chuckle as I read the list: *Batsquatch of Washington*, *Nain Rouge of Michigan*, *Flatwoods Monster of West Virginia*.

“Find anything good?” Jack asked, walking up from behind, causing me to look around, startled.

“Oh, not really, just more global lore. But this looks like a fun read. I might see if I can copy some of these stories.” I handed Jack the book so he could see it. “What did you find out?”

“Betty, over at the desk, said we need to go to the periodical room. That is where all the local legends, lore, myths, papers, journals, and other oddities are kept.” Jack grinned at me. “She was very nice, been here her whole life, chatty lady but kind.”

“This looks great,” Jack said, turning his attention to the book. “Batsquatch, huh? That does not sound pleasant.” He chuckled and gave it back to me.

“Well, let’s head over to the Periodical room and see what we can find. I’m sure it’ll be time to start back soon.”

“Good point,” Jack said, turning to follow. “There’s no telling how much fun Dotty is getting herself into. I bet I end up needing to ship her purchases home.” We chuckled as we walked down the corridor to the rooms beyond.



STEPPING INTO THE LOCAL history room was like stepping back in time via maps, photographs, and framed newspaper articles. The short stacks lined the walls with displays across every surface; shadowboxes, wooden carvings, and sketches set out for visitors to see. Books filled every shelf; a row of old microfiche machines were stationed across the back wall. Flanking those were tall bookshelves, but what caught my eye was the sign above them that read “Trail Journals and Diaries from the PNT.”

“Those look promising.” I said to Jack, nodding toward the shelves.

“Well, we better get to it. There’s quite a few of those.”

I nodded and headed toward the first one. Jack veered off to browse the one at the far end.

“Let’s just scan a few pages, see if anything stands out about strange animals, or odd occurrences. I know it’s probably a long shot.”

“Sounds good.” Jack said as he picked up the first journal on the shelf. “These look pretty old too.”

I reached for one of the old notebooks and began leafing through the aged pages. It looked newer than the one Jack had, and the writing was clear. After a few minutes, I returned it to the shelf and grabbed the next, and then the next, a few minutes later.

“Nothing yet, just trail descriptions, a couple animal sightings, dinner recipes and such that were shared, a few poems from one hiker. Nothing

unusual.” I said to Jack while leafing through yet another old diary. “How about you?”

“Nah, just more of the same. Boring stuff. I’m trying some of the older ones now.”

We stood at the back of the room, scanning journals for another ten minutes or so before I finally gave up.

“I’m not seeing anything noteworthy,” I said apologetically, “and I don’t want to keep you from Dotty any longer. I appreciate you coming with me, though.”

“Sure thing. It was interesting anyway. Lots of great things to see here, especially the photography. These pictures of the town are great, and did you see that old map?”

Jack nodded toward the front wall where an ancient map hung, sealed in glass, yellowed with age. I could practically smell the faded parchment.

We walked toward the front wall, gazing at the map. It depicted the town from over a hundred years ago, showing roads and buildings that no longer existed. Black and white photos were positioned along the bottom edge of the frame, showing the old main street in clearer detail. One photo of the old general store caught my eye, and I looked closer, then whistled softly.

“What did you find?” Jack asked from just behind him, causing me to jump slightly, making us chuckle.

“Jesus, man, make some noise.” I said, feeling my cheeks redden from the momentary scare.

“Sorry, Dotty yells at me too, says I walk like a cat.” Jack laughed.

“Look at this photo. See anyone familiar?” I reached up and tapped the old photo with my index finger.

“Well, I’ll be damned.” Jack said. “It can’t be. How old is this photo?”

“Not sure, but look at the sign overhead.”.

“Swann’s General Store.” Jack read and raised an eyebrow. “Relative?”

“I would assume so. Perhaps our own Trudy Swann can tell us about a few odd stories from around the trail, if her family has been here that long.”

“Wouldn’t that be something?” Jack laughed, “and here we are, chasing down old diaries in the library with our own local historian back at the house.”

“Only one way to find out. Let’s go find Dotty and head back to the diner. We can eat and be back in plenty of time to help Miss Trudy set up for tonight’s picnic.”

We settled our packs on our backs once more and left the room, making our way toward the majestic front entrance, and back out into the sunshine.



WE AMBLED BACK DOWN Main Street, easily finding Dotty in another boutique shop. This one made herbal soaps and candles. We had to agree that we could see why she found it enticing; the scent drifting from the open door was incredible. It was a deep woodsy scent, with a hint of crisp mint and something warm beneath it, like sandalwood. Pleasant and aromatic. It enveloped us when we walked inside, sniffing appreciatively. As we scanned the store, Jack saw Dotty framed near the back room, just over the threshold, also sniffing something with a smile on her face as the shopkeeper beamed with pride.

“Hey babe, find anything good?” Jack said as he walked up to her.

“Oh man, you gotta smell this?” she said, promptly lifting the candle she held to his nose and waiting for his reaction.

Jack obliged her and smiled as the scent filled his nostrils. “Oh wow, that smells just like homemade cookies, like the ones my gram used to make.” He smiled at her, “well, you have to get that one.”

“Oh, don’t worry. I did, and a few others. And the soaps are amazing. Wait until you see these.” Dotty linked her arm through his and led him away, deeper into the store. I smiled at the chatting couple and decided to give them some space. I wandered back toward the front room, idly taking in several displays geared toward men. Soaps, lotions, oils, and shaving kits were prominently scattered around the deep green display rack. Scents like ocean tide, fresh sandalwood, lemongrass, and redwood spice were printed on their labels. Many of them are arranged in matching bags, so a customer could get their favorite scent as a set.

I smelled a few of the soaps that were out and was duly impressed with the quality and the appeal of each one. None were overpowering, all were clean, crisp, and very masculine smelling. I approved and could feel my resolve weakening.

“Can you I show you anything in particular?” The shopkeeper asked as she walked over, casually keeping her distance so as not to crowd me.

“Oh, I’m just looking while my friends are shopping.” I nodded toward the back room.

“Ah, Dotty is lovely. She made several purchases.” The woman smiled and nodded. “Are you hiking with her and her husband?” she asked.

“Not exactly. We just met last night because we are both staying at the Swann Bed & Breakfast down the road.”

“Oh, Miss Trudy is wonderful. The trekkers love her.” She held her hand out for me as she introduced herself. “I’m Becca. This is my store. And I’ve known Miss Trudy since I was a little girl.”

“Oh, I’m Garrison.” I said, shaking her hand, blushing a bit at his delayed reaction. “It’s a nice store. And these do smell amazing.” I looked back toward the display and smiled.

“Well, I do ship, anywhere that you need it sent, and I’m online as well, if you’d like to order something once you return home.” Becca told him with another smile. “I’ll be at the register if you decide to get anything.”

I thanked her and watched her walk away, saw Dotty and Jack emerge from the back room, and went to meet them near the register.

“All set?” I asked, as they set a few more items on the counter.

“Yes! I need to drag her out of here before she buys more.” Jack said, laughing.

Dotty giggled as she took out her debit card. “Oh, stop! These are just for Miss Trudy, and one for the trail, because I hate smelling like dirt and wet leaves.”

Becca laughed and began ringing up her items.

“Go on ahead. I’ll join you fellas in the diner in a minute.”

Jack smiled and shook his head. “Good, cause I’m starving.” He replied and then turned to me, “Shall we?”

“Lead on.” I said, already turning to follow him from the store. The ladies’ friendly chatter followed us as we left and made a left down the block. The diner was just ahead, beyond the next crosswalk. We followed a couple of the locals inside, stowed the packs in the neat cubby room beside the entrance, and waited to be seated.

“Hello, how many?” an older woman greeted them, a smile brighter than the sun on her face.

“Three of us,” Jack said.

“Right this way.” She grabbed some menus, turned to her right, and led them through the maze of booths and tables. She stopped at a four-person table beside the window and set the menu down.

“How’s this?” She asked.

“This will do just fine.” Jack replied, pulling out a chair for Dotty as she came rushing over.

“Perfect.” The woman smiled as they all sat down. “My name is Betsy, and I’ll be right back with some waters to get you started.”

She left as they settled around the table. Jack and I filled Dotty in on the library trip, even though it didn’t pan out as I had hoped. We shared the news on Miss Trudy.

“Well, how about that?” Dotty exclaimed. “I’m sure she might know something. She’s been here that long and has been running the B&B for ten years now. She has seen a lot of trekkers. If something strange is out there, I’m sure she’s heard of it by now.”

“I’m not sure if strange is the right word, but what I saw sure didn’t look like any animal that I’ve seen. I would just like to know if any non-typical animals have made themselves at home here.” I shrugged a bit tentatively. “I’m not scared, not really, just more curious than anything. I came prepared for bears, wolves, bobcats, etc. But since I am well out of my element here, I’d just rather know what I might be facing.”

Dotty nodded. “Makes sense to me. It doesn’t sound like anything I have heard of either, but I’m a city kid, too.”

“I’m along for the ride.” Jack said, wrapping an arm around Dotty as he leaned back a little in his chair. “I’m sure it’s nothing to worry about, but safe rather than sorry has saved many an ass over the years.”

We looked up as Betsy returned with a tray of ice waters, straws, and a coffee pot. Dotty eagerly turned over her mug for the rich brew to be poured, while the guys declined.

“What can I get for you folks? Betsy asked.

“I was told to get the hiker’s special.” I said, a hopeful tone in my voice.

“You were told correctly.” She said, her eyes twinkling as she winked at me.

“That sounds intriguing. Make it two.” Jack said.

“And for you?” Betsy said to Dotty.

“Umm, well. What is it?” Dotty asked.

“You gotta wait and see,” Betsy grinned. “But I promise you won’t regret it.”

“Well. I am on an adventure. Make it three.”

“Wonderful. Just two questions. Is anyone vegan or have food allergies, and when are you headed back out on the trail?”

A round of ‘no’s’ replied to her question and Jack piped up with, “Tomorrow morning, we all head back out.”

“Got it. I’ll be back soon.” She picked up their menus and toddled off toward the kitchen.

“Okay, Garrison, what do you know that we don’t?” Dotty asked when the waitress left.

I chuckled before answering. “I know as much as you do. The two old guys on the trail told me to ask for it and said that the cook sends you back out with a full stomach and enough food in a sack to last another day or two.”

Jack laughed at Dotty’s expression. “Well, I, for one, am tired of lukewarm, bland trail food. This sounds amazing, and it smells delicious in

here, too.”

“It really does.” His wife replied, adding sugar and cream to her coffee, before tasting it.

We sat and talked, comparing trail notes and experiences had, animals seen, meals cooked. All manner of usual small talk, relishing the company, and the sunshine streaming in the window. We looked up expectantly as Betsy returned with a heavy tray laden with steaming platters of food.

“Oh, my goodness...” Dotty said, trailing off as Betsy set the first plate in front of her.

It was heaped with chopped sirloin and home fries, covered in gravy. Side bowls of carrots and corn were set down and a basket of bread. I heard his stomach growl at the same time Jack’s did.

“That looks incredible.” Jack said.

“This is just part of it.” Betsy grinned. “Eat up. I’ll be back.”

We looked at our plates, at each other, and then at her retreating back. “There’s more?” Dotty said incredulously.

Jack and I did not answer her, mouths already full of potatoes, steak, and gravy.

True to her word, Betsy returned two more times; the first time with thick slices of a triple chocolate cake smothered in ice cream, and the second with to-go bags for each of them.

“These bags contain enough food to feed you for about two days on the trail. Breakfast, lunch, and dinner. They are marked and foil wrapped. Pop them right in your fire and you’ll have a hot meal in no time.”

“This is amazing.” I said, “The food was fantastic.”

“Shorty used to be a trekker, got tired of the skimpy and overpriced meals that some of the local towns gave to the hikers, even though it was hiker

money sustaining them. He's cut from a different cloth and the folks here love him for it." Betsy smiled at them. "You all enjoy the picnic tonight at Miss Trudy's and be safe in those woods. Come back through if you get the chance."

She laughed at our confused expressions. "It's Saturday. Miss Trudy always hosts a BBQ dinner for her guests on Saturday. It's quite a good time." She winked and left to greet some other customers.

"I could move here." I said earnestly. "This town is just wonderful. The people are kind. The food is just amazing." I groaned as he stood up. "I guess we better get our packs and get moving. We need to get our parcels from the general store, too."

"I don't think I can move." Dotty said, laughing as she pushed her plate away. "You guys can carry me."

"You barely finished your meal," Jack replied, lifting both of their bags.

"Because I know you'll finish it later." She replied smugly.

We grabbed their things and made our way to the counter where I paid the check. Then we headed outside into the sunshine, returned to the general store to gather our belongings, and returned to Miss Trudy for what was sure to be another pleasant evening.

Chapter 7

Newcomers

BACK AT THE BED-AND-BREAKFAST, we stowed our belongings in our rooms and went to find Miss Trudy. We quickly found her in the kitchen, chatting with two more guests as she prepared food for that evening. Introductions were made and Miss Trudy began giving orders to the extra hands.

“I’m so glad you are all here. I hate to ask, but would you guys’ mind helping set up the patio area? The furniture covers need to be removed and stowed in the shed. Wood can be put in the fire pit too. It is behind the shed. Garrison, stay here a moment. You can help bring platters out.”

They all quickly agreed and filed out of the kitchen, leaving me with a smiling Miss Trudy in the kitchen with Dotty, whom she had stopped from leaving the kitchen with a friendly squeeze on her forearm.

“If you don’t mind, I’d like some company while I finish up. It’s so rare that I get younger guests.” She chuckled a little ruefully and shrugged.

“Of course,” Dotty replied, “I’d love to chat. The others can handle it.” She grinned at Jack as he dutifully filed past her with the rest.

“Can I help do anything?” Dotty asked as we sat down at the table.

“Oh, um, you can help me toss the salad together in a little while. Most everything else is done. Tell me how your trip to town went. Did you find everything you needed?”

“The town is great, so welcoming, and charming. The food at the diner was amazing, so much more than I could ever eat. Jack and Garrison went to the library while I did some shopping, and I found the best smelling soaps in this little boutique. The owner was just a delight!” Dotty gushed, her eyes twinkling as she told Trudy about the unique scents she had purchased.

“Becca is a good one. She had raised her, I babysat for her many times when she was growing up. I was so glad to see she stayed in town after college. Her store is so lovely, and it does a fair bit of business too, especially online.” Miss Trudy said.

“All the people I spoke to seemed to be really kind. I went into the dress shop and then the Quilting Corner too.”

“Ah, yes. Mabel Owens runs the Quilting Corner. She is a wonderful quilter. In fact, all your rooms contain her quilts on the bed. She does exquisite work.” Trudy beamed at Dotty.

“Did you guys find anything interesting at the library? Not many of the trekkers seem to go there.” She asked me, as she added corn to the boiling water on the stove.

“I didn’t quite find what I was looking for,” I replied. “I saw some type of weird animal on the trail two days ago. It spooked me and I was trying to find any mention of it in some old hiker journals we found there.” I explained, shrugging. “I looked at some local lore, but nothing seemed to

mention anything more unusual than Bigfoot.” Dotty laughed a bit and shrugged as I finished.

“Oh my, I wonder what you saw!” the older woman exclaimed, turning from the stove to look at Dotty and me. “You’ll have to ask some of the older hikers about it. I’m sure it was nothing scarier than a bear, maybe a wolf, but you don’t hear about them venturing too close to the trail.”

“I’m not sure how to describe it, but it wasn’t a bear, maybe more wolf-like, but that it doesn’t quite fit what I know a wolf to look like, but also, city kid, not like I’m an expert on it.” I shrugged.

Dotty chimed in, “I understand why you’d want to know, though. Probably best to have a point of reference for it if he sees it again. Reassurance, for the most part, it makes sense, considering he is hiking alone, as are Jack and I.”

“I agree. Can’t be too careful. There will be a couple more guests arriving tonight, regulars and old-timers on the trail. Maybe he can ask them. Tim and Blake are always good for a story or two.” Trudy chuckled and turned back to her stove.

“Oh, Jack and Garrison found an old picture of you too, in front of the General Store.” Dotty said, suddenly remembering our earlier conversation.

“Oh yes, my grandfather started that store. It’s been here a long time.” Trudy remarked, but said no more on the subject. She picked up a large bowl and brought it to the table.

“Would you mind stirring this for me while I make the deviled eggs?” She said to Dotty as she set it down.

“Not a problem at all. It’s silly that we are just sitting here watching you work, anyway. I’m happy to help.” Dotty took the large spoon Trudy

offered her, stood up to pour the dressing over the pasta salad, and began stirring it. I winced slightly at the squelching noise it made.

That sound always reminded me of what you might hear fishing around inside bodies during surgery. It was already disturbing and uncomfortable, but once I heard the sound, it immediately popped visceral and bloody images into my head. It was like having a ready-made horror movie cued up at all times, in a mental loop. I kept these thoughts to myself as she stirred the rotini pasta chock full of vegetables, meat, and cheeses. It looked incredible and my stomach growled slightly despite the full meal we had eaten earlier.

Trudy and Dotty worked in a comfortable harmony as they chatted more about the town, and all about Jack and Dotty's wedding with Miss Trudy raving over the details that Dotty shared. The older woman seemed truly content, relishing a full house, and kind guests to share friendly conversation.

I watched, content, remembering Miss Trudy confiding in me the night before. How days like this made all the quiet days Trudy endured worth it. Most her guests were good people, and she loved to make them feel welcome and at home for the short while that they stayed with her.

Loneliness was a killer and Trudy refused to succumb to it after her husband had died. Instead, she had thrown herself into the bed-and-breakfast business, joined a book club, and had a standing bridge game with her friends twice a month, other widows like herself. I was glad to be here, and glad to be a small part of her memories now.



LATER, AS I HELPED the other guests set up outside, Jack and I were enjoying trail talk from the two newcomers, Pete and Tyler, or 'Tramp', as he liked to be called. Not hiking together, but they were regulars on the trail and knew each other fairly well. They regaled us with some of their funnier moments on the trail as they went about setting up the chairs and table.

"Do you remember the night it rained so hard that Old Flannel slid right out of his tent in his sleeping bag?" Tramp said to Pete as they finished carrying a picnic table to the patio.

"I sure do. That old guy didn't know what happened. He woke up drenched, muddy, and twenty feet from his tent. We howled watching him slide down the hill toward us."

We all chuckled for a minute, Tramp's own laughter setting them off.

"He was a drinker though, so he slept through it all, right until he woke up to our laughter." Pete's eyes glistened with tears of laughter as he remembered.

"Flannel sure had some stories, though." Tramp said, shaking his head with a smile.

"How did he get the name Flannel?" I asked, assuming I knew the answer but was curious, anyway.

"Well, most trekkers don't really give out their real names. Part of the culture, as many folks use the trail for a personal cleansing experience, if that makes sense. They come out to be alone, to be anonymous, to become something better than they were before." Tramp said, his voice and countenance taking on a more serious tone.

"Some are trying to atone for some wrong while others are trying to heal. Sometimes, it's both. We respect that out here, so we leave the real names behind. Old Flannel is an older man and trail veteran, that became known

for the old ratty flannel jackets he always wore.” Tramp shrugged and smiled at them.

“So, we shouldn’t use our real names, then?” I asked, intrigued by the idea.

“It’s a personal choice, son. No rules out here. Your hike is your own along with your reasons for doing it, but we all know there is a reason, even if you don’t know it yourself. Most newbies realize their real reason along the way. Many call it a religious experience.” Pete answered him, and Tramp nodded in agreement.

“Sometimes other trekkers will name you and it sticks. Sometimes you pick your own nickname from the start and that’s what you go by. I’m guessing Garrison is your own name.” Tramp asked.

I nodded. “It is, and you’re right. I do have a reason for doing this.”

“I figured as much.” Tramp agreed. “You’re haunted by something. I could see that in your eyes. And you walk as if you carry the weight of the world on your shoulders.”

“That obvious, huh?” I asked.

“It is, but only because I’ve seen it before. It’s not up to us to ask and we won’t. But if you look out there and need to unburden yourself, our campfires are always open to you,” Tramp said, and Pete agreed with the sentiment.

“I appreciate that, but right now I’m more interested in knowing more about the types of animals that you’ve seen on the trail, or rather, any unusual sightings?” I replied.

“Animals of all kinds out here, big and small. Did you see something in particular?” Tramp asked.

I shot Jack an uneasy look. Jack looked at Tramp and Pete, then back at his new friend. "Can't hurt to tell them," Jack said.

I sighed, dropped into the nearest chair, and began to talk.



"WELL, IT WAS PRETTY gloomy and hard to see, but I could have sworn it was tracking me, but it stopped in this sunny meadow, like right at the edge where the light hit it. It was on all fours, but stood over three feet tall, maybe four. It didn't have a bear or wolf shaped head, which was weird but had thick fur like one. Thick legs and body, powerful build."

I shrugged, turning red in the face. "Honestly, it scared the shit out of me."

I sat back and stared into the fire for a long moment. "The weirdest thing was how it just suddenly stopped. Right at the edge of the clearing, like the light could hurt it somehow. I've never known an animal to do that."

Uncomfortable after a moment, I cleared his throat and looked at the small group, attempting to brush off my concern. "It's probably nothing, just felt unnatural to me somehow. Even the forest animals fled, all of them birds too. Everything scattered."

The others nodded and made empathetic grunts at this last statement. Tramp and Pete shared a long look while Jack popped open another beer. I kept silent, noticing the unspoken exchange between the two older men, but held my tongue. The night was young, and beer was flowing. Maybe later, they would share what they knew or had experienced.

Feminine laughter broke the silence as Dotty and Trudy appeared from the side door, carrying baskets of covered rolls and buns. The mood

immediately lightened as we shook themselves from the somber moment and stood up to lend a hand. Before an hour had passed, the grills were going; the tables were set, and the enticing scent of BBQ was in the air.

Trudy's other guests had arrived and several of the locals had dropped by, most with giant platters of food. It was clearly a weekly high point for the town, and I was glad that I was here to see it. I wandered away from the group and stood back against a massive oak, watching the gathering, and feeling a deep pull in my chest for home, or something akin to homesickness, not where I was from but rather where I was, here and now. I nodded to myself, agreeing with my assessment. I absolutely could see myself at home here, making a home here. This was a good place, full of good people. I could be useful here, find a job in town, help Miss Trudy around the B & B. I smiled at the thought. It felt right. For the first time in a long time, I understood what it was to be content.

I smiled warmly as Miss Trudy approached me, the two new guests following her.

"Garrison, dear. I wanted to make sure you got to meet Ed and Buck. They are old trail veterans, hike it every other year, and always find the time to pay me a visit."

"Nice to meet you both." I said, offering my hand to each of them in turn. They appeared to be middle-aged, maybe forty years old or so. Bearded, stocky, and slightly bow-legged, Buck shook my hand first.

"How are you doing?" Buck said, his handshake firm and his smile genuine. "Miss Trudy said this is your first hike?"

"Yes, sir. It is." I replied, nodding, before grasping Ed's outstretched hand.

"Nice to meet you." Ed said. He was taller and leaner than Buck, had kind eyes that twinkled with good humor. He looked like he had just heard a

good joke, his lips upturned as if he might laugh at any moment.

“Miss Trudy been treating you, right?” Ed asked with a wink, grinning as the old woman playfully smacked his arm.

“Well, of course I have been!” She exclaimed in mock indignation.

I chuckled before I answered. “She’s been a wonderful host.”

Miss Trudy beamed at me and turned her sweet smile on the other two men. “Now, then, I’ll leave you fellas to chat. Don’t forget the campfire tales in an hour. It’s the best part of the night.”

“Looking forward to it,” Ed said as she left, making her way back to the picnic tables, speaking to a few folks as she went.

“Campfire tales?” I asked when Ed and Buck turned back to me.

“Yup. We usually end the night just sitting around the fire, sharing trail stories. Lot of us have been through here a lot. We try to share tips that we’ve picked up, talk about what we have seen, etc. Some guys tell a few stories that may or may not be true, trying to spook the rookies.” Buck said.

“Sounds like a good time.” I said. “I’ll be sure I make my way over.”

“You should,” Ed said, “especially as a new hiker, might learn a few things that could help you. Speaking of that, how’s your hike been so far? You’re about eleven days out, right?”

“That’s right. I’m setting back out in the morning. Going to hike straight-through on this trip, then figure things out when I get done.”

The older men nodded, sharing a look as I pretended to study the gathering around the picnic tables.

“Not just here on a whim, are you?” Buck asked.

“No. not really.”

“I figured. You had that look about you. I won’t pry. We know why folks come to the trail. It’s your business and I’m sure you’ll figure out what your

next steps are. Most folks do, even if it's just to hike the trail again, while they make other decisions." Buck said with a shrug.

"Some folks decide trail life is *the decision* and find themselves living and working out here along the trail, taking odd jobs in winter at the small towns, and hiking all spring and summer. It's addicting for the right person."

"I can see that making sense for some people," I replied. "Probably not for me, but I am certainly fond of this town and the people that I've met so far."

Both men nodded in agreement. "Good folks here for sure." Ed said. "We met Jack and Dotty earlier. They're a nice couple. Young and full of ideas. Doctors, too. It would be nice for them to settle along the trail. Never enough doctors in these small towns."

I smiled, my eyes spotting Jack and Dotty over by the fire already. "Yes, they're very nice. We went into town earlier for our supplies and had lunch at the diner. Great people."

Buck patted his stomach and turned to scan the food table. "Well, fellas, I believe it's time for dessert. Anyone want to join me?" He turned back to them and raised an eyebrow, grinning. "Miss Trudy just brought out her triple chocolate cake."

"Say no more." Ed laughed and fell in line beside him. I watched them go for a minute, considering, then shrugged and followed. I never was one to turn down chocolate cake, especially homemade.

Chapter 8

Campfire Tales

AN HOUR LATER FOUND us gathered around the fire, huddled in flannels, and wrapped in blankets. Coffee and cocoa sat at the nearby table along with all the makings for S'mores. Beer and whiskey flowed freely, as did the conversation. The laughter was loud, and the heckling even louder as funny anecdotes and rookie mishaps were shared.

“Tell them about the time Wild Will was scared by the bear, in the middle of doing his business.” Buck said to Ed, his grinning face shining from the firelight and perhaps from the whiskey too.

“Oh, man.” Ed laughed. “That was a funny story. Scary for Will but man, funny as hell for the rest of us, after the fact, of course.” He finished soberly. He tossed back the remains of his whiskey and leaned forward.

“Okay, so Wild Will is this goofy hippie type guy. Been hiking maybe fifteen years now. Bunch of the old heads know him well even though they still call him a rookie.” He smiled as the group chuckled and nodded. Typical of the old vets to call anyone younger than themselves a rookie.

“He’s always got some weed on him, mushrooms too. He’s heavy into ‘natural remedies and psychedelics.” Ed made air quotes as he spoke, alluding to the weed, barely keeping a straight face as he remembered the story.

“This one night, its pouring rain and about a half dozen of us are gathered around a fire, trying to stay warm and shoot the shit at the same time. Wild Will is already higher than a kite. I’m pretty sure he’d been smoking all day by the time we set up camp for the night. Well, Will stands up, all legs and elbows. Man was built like a nightmare. All sharp angles and shadows, tall and skinny as a fence post. His hair was this bright red, always stuck straight up on his head like he had just seen a ghost or been electrocuted. That’s where his nickname came from, from the wild hair, both style and color.” He stood up and poured another fifth of whiskey into his glass from the table and turned back to the group.

“He’s looking like a baby giraffe trying to find its leg right after birth, all awkward and gangly. Slipping in the mud no matter what way he tried to go. Announces that he’s gotta drop a load...” Ed stopped and turned red, glancing over at the ladies. “Sorry, ladies, just what he said.” They waved him off with a chuckle.

“So, yea. Off he goes, holding onto saplings and whatnot, making his way out into the bushes to handle his business. He went pretty far out too, courtesy and privacy reasons, but I think it was because of the mud and rain, too. Hard to find stable ground to squat on.” The group chuckled as Ed took another drink and pretended to squat.

“About ten minutes later, we hear a loud shriek and I swear it sounds like a woman. Like the highest pitch squeal you ever did hear. A second later, a roar sounded off, just as loud as Will’s shriek and the man himself came

tearing out of those woods, pants down, eyes wide open, shrieking and shuffling just as fast as he could go.” Ed imitated a fast shuffle, with his eyes as wide as they could go, and opened his mouth in a faux scream. Buck had tears pouring from his eyes as he laughed.

“Well, the rest of us turned around to see the sight and there goes Will, red hair the only thing we could see, blazing a streak right past us and behind him, there goes a bear cub, roaring and bounding after his lily-white ass, toilet paper still stuck to it.”

“Old Bert grabs his bear spray and takes off after them, couple of the other guys follow suit, guns in hand. One fella grabbed a big branch from the ground and the rest of us trail along after them, just in case. Will is still shrieking for all he’s worth, so they found him pretty easily.”

“By the time we catch up to them, Will is covered in mud, cowering on the ground, all tangled up in his pants, and this little bear cub had raced right past him. Still roaring for all he’s worth, scared shitless, both of them. That little bear didn’t know what was going on and neither did we.”

“We got Will up and settled, trying not to laugh at his predicament. He shuffled back to camp, sans pants, meat and two veg just dangling in the rain, streaks of his business still on the back of his rump. He was already paler than the moon, but that night, he was damn near translucent.” The group laughed as Ed imitated the man’s shuffling walk once more and then sat back down.

“Best we can figure is the bear got separated from its momma and Will came along at the wrong time, grunting and muttering to himself out there in the bushes and the two of them right scared each other something awful.” Ed laughed again, shaking his head.

“Of course, after that, we had to move camp. Didn’t want to spend the night if a momma bear was roaming the area. We moved on about two miles up the trail and settled back down. Poor Will stuck close to the old heads for the next sixty miles of his hike, terrified the bear was going to come back.”

I chuckled with the rest of the group, then took a minute to stretch my mouth open and closed to ease the soreness there. Still smiling, I rubbed my jaw. My face was hurting from the constant laughing. This was the fifth such story of the night, and each one was funnier than the last, made even more so by the person telling the story. They had all been a riot.

I could tell that they relished sharing these stories. It was as much of a part of the trail experience as the actual hike, these moments that they shared with each other and others. I looked forward to sharing my own trail stories one day, though I doubted I would have much to tell, certainly nothing as great as these tales.



“HOW ABOUT ANY WEIRD stories? Anyone ever see anything unusual out there?” Jack asked, carefully not looking in my direction as he spoke. He looked across the fire instead, at the older hikers there, watching a few of them share some glances, before nodding at him.

“Few of us have.” Buck said.

I ignored the look Tramp and Pete shot me and focused instead on Buck and the fire. I didn’t want to share my story yet. I wanted to know what the rest had seen. I didn’t really know why I was so focused on the experience other than something just felt off about it. I couldn’t explain it better than

that. I guess maybe hearing something similar from someone else might help calm my nerves. That was my hope anyway.

I popped the top on another beer and settled deeper into his chair as Buck rose from his chair, grabbed his own refill, and faced the gathering once more.

I felt the atmosphere shift. Their moods turned somber as the firelight played off the attentive faces. This was unfamiliar territory for the night. The scary stories, the all too real times of terror on the trail. The disturbing memories that they each carried with them had risen to the surface and you could almost see the shadows of each buried memory dancing in the firelight.

Buck gazed into the fire a bit too long, maybe lost in his own memories, maybe gazing at the others that flickered there in the embers. No one stirred in the silence, waiting for him to gather his thoughts. After a moment, he spoke, still lost in the glow of the embers just beneath the flames.

“This was about ten years ago now. I was doing a hike in late fall, nearing the end of it by that point. I had about two weeks left in my hike before I would finish and head for home.”

I settled deeper into my chair, watching the others do the same, tugging blankets and jackets closer. The tone had been set.

The night swept in with a chill as Buck rose from his chair. I felt goosebumps rise on my flesh as I gazed at the old man from across the fire, watching the gold and crimson flames light the man’s face in a most disturbing way.

“I had made my campsite near a small lake that I stumbled across. It was close to sunset and seemed as good a place as any to set up. There were several good size fire rings scattered about, so I knew that others had done

the same. I set my pack down and got to work.” He took another sip of his whiskey and set it down on the picnic table. Buck stepped closer to the fire, warming his hands over it as his face took on a distant look, remembering that night.

“I chose a nice flat spot at the edge of the meadow that ran between the tree line and the lake. The tent set up was finished in minutes. I settled my sleeping pad inside with my bag and started fishing around in my pack for my matches and dinner supplies. The fire was quick work since I didn’t need to make a fresh pit and there were plenty of small pieces of wood close by. Once that was done, I started on my meal prep.”

Buck sipped his whiskey again, his eyes glinting with the dancing flames as he gazed at the small crowd. Not a word was spoken as they waited for him to continue. I glanced around the group, noting that everyone seemed to be as enraptured as I was. Clearly this was a new story for all of them.

Buck cleared his voice and continued to speak. “Well, no sooner had I gotten my dinner ready than I heard, no, not heard,” he said, feeling his words out before he found the right one, “felt. I felt this eerie quiet come over everything. Not just the clearing, but everything. Like the forest itself ceased to breathe. I felt the hairs on the back of neck stand up as I stopped what I was doing and looked around. I damn nearly stopped breathing myself as I realized just how quiet it had gotten. Then, suddenly, there was a loud snapping sound from the forest. The loudest damn snap and crack that I had ever word, then more followed it, like something huge was barreling through the trees.”

Just then, a log in the fire popped, making everyone jump. Dotty emitted a small squeal of surprise as embers danced skyward. A moment passed, and we all chuckled, even Buck. “Almost as sudden as that,” he remarked, a

wry smile on his face, making the group smile with him. “Anyway, I froze, just standing there, not daring to blink or move, and watched the treetops as they swayed from the movement of whatever it was tearing through the brush beneath. Then, not a minute later, something enormous burst through the tree line, hurtled straight toward the pond, straight toward me. I didn’t have time to think. I just moved. Took off like a bat out of hell into the forest past my camp, screaming like a banshee. I had never seen an animal like this one and I never have since.” Buck took another drink of his whiskey, grimaced as he felt the slow burn slide down his throat and looked into the flames once more. Memories filled him and his face twisted slightly, reminiscent of fear and fascination.

“What was it?” Dotty asked, unable to bear the silence any longer.

“Well, young lady. That’s just it. I don’t know. It was massive, and it was running on two legs as it burst from the trees, running like a human, but it had some type of fur, a light-colored fur over most of it. Big head, not quite like a bear or a wolf, but something else, something in-between.”

I felt sick, a lead ball suddenly lodged in the pit of my stomach. Buck’s creature sounded a lot like what I had seen. It hadn’t been on two legs, but the details were uncanny. It had to be the same thing. I shifted uncomfortably in my seat, waiting for the rest of the tale to be told.

“What happened then?” Dotty asked, breathless as Jack slung his arm over her shoulders. She leaned to his side as Buck grinned at us all.

“Well, I got away. I don’t know how or why, but I got away. I just kept running, fast as my legs could go. I darted into another small clearing, and I swear the thing was on my heels, but I ran smack dab into another campsite and the group turned their Maglite’s on me, just as the thing burst into the clearing behind me. And it stopped, just like that. It stopped as if the light

blinded it. It let out the most awful roar I have ever heard and turned around, disappearing into the trees again. That sound made my skin crawl, and I pissed myself right then. Seeing it didn't make me piss myself, but that sound? That godawful sound? That did the trick. It was like hellhounds and demons shrieking from the bowels of Hell. I've never forgotten it." Buck emptied his glass, refilled it, and sat back down in his seat.

"Jee-zus" Jack finally said, breaking the silence. "That was one hell of a story."

"It damn sure was." I added. I cast a long look at Buck, who sat gazing into the flames again. The faraway look on his face told me that every word the old man had spoken was as true as they come. I wasn't sure if I should speak about my experience or not. I remained quiet and glanced at Jack, who was watching me with a raised eyebrow.

I shook my head slightly, not quite ready to share, and stood up to get a refill instead. Behind me, the talk broke up into smaller conversations and the party-like atmosphere was back. We all enjoyed the evening for another hour or so before goodbyes were said, numbers and next stops were exchanged, and we all helped Miss Trudy clear the picnic supplies from the patio.



MORNING FOUND US ALL up early and preparing to depart. Trudy had the kitchen buzzing with the clatter of dishes, brewing coffee pots, and sizzling bacon and ham. I joined the others in the dining room after I dropped my pack on the front porch, adding to the rank of overstuffed trail packs that stood like silent sentries against the railing.

Jack and Dotty had saved me a seat beside them, and Buck was seated at the head of the table, with Ed, Pete and Tramp rounding out the other side, with a space for Miss Trudy at the foot of the long oval table. Massive platters of eggs, biscuits, potatoes, and sausage were already in the center. Coffee and juice stood at the ready on the sidebar, along with baskets of muffins and Miss Trudy's giant cinnamon rolls. My mouth watered at the sight.

I helped myself to a cinnamon roll and coffee before sitting down beside Jack.

Dishes were passed around as hungry and eager travelers stacked their plates and dug in. A comfortable silence filled the room for a few minutes as mouths were filled with the delicious home cooking. Miss Trudy appeared with another tray of food; bacon, ham, and pancakes were added to the table, then she took her own seat. As she did so, the silence was broken as we praised her cooking and helped pass around the food once more. Dotty rose and poured our host a cup of coffee and took it to her before asking if anyone else needed a refill while she was up. Several of the group held their mugs up and thanked her as she made the rounds, pouring the coffee before she sat back down.

I felt a sudden sadness come over me as I looked around the group.

Strangers that had suddenly become friends over forty-eight hours. Not something I was used to having, let alone accumulating so quickly. Miss Trudy herself struck a chord deep within me, one that resonated throughout my core. She reminded me of my home, and of my mom, of the relationship I missed out on. The idea of settling here after I concluded my trek had more and more appeal. I smiled wistfully at her when she caught my eye.

“So, how did you enjoy the picnic last night, Garrison?” she asked warmly.

“Oh, it was great. The food was amazing, but it was a lot of fun to meet everyone. I really loved the stories from the trail, too. Buck and Ed’s especially.”

This got a laugh from the group as they remembered Ed’s funny story from the night before. “It was a good time, for sure,” Dotty added. Beside her, Jack nodded, sipping his coffee, before speaking. “You know, Buck. The creature you saw. Did you ever meet anyone with a similar story or experience after that?”

Heads turned to Buck as Jack asked the question. “I just ask because surely, something that big can’t be an isolated incident.”

“Well, I have heard a few stories, but many didn’t see what it was. However, the size, and the sounds they described sounded similar. One sighting was at night, but whatever it was turned tail when lights were turned on.” Buck looked thoughtful again, “Most predators won’t leave when lights come on. Prey is prey, day, or night. The light shouldn’t matter. That’s the strange part of the story. That’s why I think they’re the same animal or there’s more than one. Whatever this animal is, it must be nocturnal, or a cave dweller. Light must hurt it somehow, like moles. That’s what I’m thinking, anyway.” Buck shrugged.

Jack gave me another pointed look. Pete and Tramp did the same, having already heard his story. I realized it was now or never. I had to tell my story. “So, I may have one more story to add to the list.” I began, meeting Buck’s gaze as the older man looked up.

“I’m all ears, son,” Buck said. “I’m sure we all are.” He looked around the table to see nodding heads and warm smiles before looking back at me.

“Let’s hear it.”

I glanced at Jack and Dotty, both of whom smiled encouragingly. Taking a breath, I pushed my plate away and settled back into my chair.

“Well, this happened just a few days into my trek. I already told the others the story, but listening to you last night, I can’t help but wonder if it’s the same animal.” I looked at Buck directly this time.

“Like you said, it stopped right before the light would hit it. It was daylight, but the forest was dim beneath the canopy. I heard this massive thing hurtling through the trees and I took off running. Found a small clearing where the sunlight was streaming through the trees. I ran through it and stopped just on the other side, back inside the forest. I saw it burst from the trees and head toward me, but then it just stopped. Just a few feet from where the sunlight was hitting the ground. It reared up and let out the most awful roar I had ever heard and turned back into the forest, vanishing down the trail into the shadows.”

I stopped speaking, shrugged slightly, and shook my head. I could feel the flush on my cheeks and on the back of my neck. I never was comfortable in the spotlight. “I know I’m a city kid, but I’ve never seen an animal like that, or heard anything sound that way.” I finished speaking, picked up my coffee and drank the rest of the lukewarm liquid, not caring how cool it was. My throat was dryer than the desert.

“Sure sounds like the same thing.” Buck said at last. The others murmured their agreement. “Do you have a weapon on you, young man?” Buck asked me. His tone was kind but serious.

“No sir, nothing more than a standard hunting knife and the bear spray.” I said, my face flushed with embarrassment again at admitting he was not fully prepared for any genuine danger.

“And you’re traveling alone?”

“I am.” I replied.

“Not anymore, he’s not.” Jack piped up. “Dotty and I were going to tag along with him for a bit anyway, isn’t that right, hun?”

“Yes, quite right. We both wanted to get you know better.” She grinned at him, giving him a slight kick under the table,

“That settles it,” Buck said. “I trust you have a weapon then, of the firepower sort?” he raised an eyebrow at Jack.

“Yes, sir. I do.” Jack grinned. “Locked and loaded.”

“You can show me before we head out. I’d like to make sure your young’uns are prepared. Trail can be dangerous.” Buck said.

“Been a fine meal, Miss Trudy. You’ve outdone yourself once more. Fellas, let’s help this lovely lady clear the table before we depart. You know the drill.” He looked at Jack, Dotty, and me. “You three follow suit. I’ll show you how we do it.”

Within minutes, we cleared the table, did the dishes, and helped Miss Trudy prepare meal bags for us to take with them.

“Fastest clean-up in the west.” She remarked as she trailed them from the kitchen. They all gathered on the porch to pull on boots, coats, and gear before hugging her warmly and saying goodbye. She took her pictures, as was her custom, and beamed with delight at the results as the group climbed down the steps.

Buck gathered us in the side yard to inspect Jack’s weapon and to be sure we knew how to use it, Dotty included. He even investigated my hunting blade, sharpening it for me, and teaching me a few defensive moves. Satisfied that we at least knew the basics, he led our group down the

sidewalk, back to the trail entrance and onward to our adventures, some separately, some together.

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Chapter 9

Back on the Trail

WE KEPT UP A steady stream of small talk as we all traversed the gravel path that led to the trail entrance. We laughed, joked, and exchanged trail recipes and tips as we went. Young and old, rookies and veterans, all strangers when we had met, now fast friends.

As we stepped off the path and set foot back upon the trail, the tone grew quiet, less jovial, and more somber as we found ourselves beneath the dim canopy once more. Sunlight streamed through the leaves, setting the underbrush ablaze with colors, reflecting the early morning sky. The greens sparkled with glints of emerald; the browns shone copper, and the red leaves glistened with a rich burgundy hue, still damp with dew.

The scent of the forest filled our nostrils as we paused and looked around, all of us were under an almost religious spell as we witnessed the spectacle of nature at her most majestic. The trees whispered above us with a gentle breeze. Chipmunks and squirrels darted around gnarled trunks and scurried along skeletal branches. Birds chirped from high above and flitted along,

heard but unseen. The moment lingered, but then was broken as a loud truck rumbled past, blaring its horn.

We were startled as one, then we all chuckled briefly, aware of the moment we had all just shared. Nature, just as it was meant to be, wild and free, unbroken, and unchallenged. But sadly, the world was only a few hundred steps away, as were jobs, and families, and reality.

It was time to go. The spell was broken. We smiled, hugged, and exchanged coordinates, frequencies, and phone numbers. Then we split off into our own groups. Jack, Dotty, and I went our own way, slightly behind Pete and Tramp, while Ed and Buck set off in the opposite direction. We walked along in silence for a while, our two groups growing a little further apart, lost in thought, stomachs full of a hearty breakfast and hearts full of new memories. Pete and Tramp were set to make another camp to meet friends by midday, so their pace was much faster than ours.

Soon enough, it was just us left on the path, walking along at a steady pace, not urgently, but steady and motivated, finding our stride as we talked. Dotty asked me questions about my life, mostly about my mom and dad. I answered them honestly, even when my voice broke, and I couldn't hide the emotional tremble in my tone. I was glad she was asking.

I was thrilled to have met them and they were quickly earning best friend status in my mind, something I had never had before.

Jack seemed content to let his wife lead the conversation, interjecting every few yards with a polite sound of interest or a chuckle when needed. He busied himself with the GPS and brought up the route to their next stop. They would camp five more nights on the trail before they would hit their next town stop.



ALMOST AN HOUR HAD passed before Dotty seemed to be content with the silence once more. Jack finally asked the one question that I had been waiting for, the one that mattered more than the rest. It seemed to be the one thing that intrigued him most about me.

“So, Garrison, why the PNT?” He asked, “of all the trails in the country, for someone with no experience, to choose something as brutal as a PNT full hike-thru for the first time out, is highly unusual.” He stopped to look at me, pulling out his water bottle as he waited for an answer. Dotty followed suit, taking a drink as she studied my face. I felt my eyes grow misty and dim, and I swallowed hard. I turned slightly, staring into the forest as I struggled for the words.

“Penance.” I said finally. One simple word uttered directly and firmly. “I owe this.”

“I don’t understand.” Jack said. “Owe what? Or to who?”

“My mother. I owe her this.”

“Why?” Dotty said.

“I told you some of my story. But what I didn’t tell you was how cruel I was to her for so long. How I berated her and yelled at her and treated her like my servant.” My voice broke, and I took a breath. Dotty put her hand on his shoulder.

“You don’t have to—” she began to say, but I nodded.

“Yes. I do. Someone needs to know. I need to tell this.” I looked at them sadly, feeling the weight on my shoulders heavier than ever before. “I was an asshole. I was an overweight, whiny slob that pretended to be better than

everyone else, including my mother. The only person that gave a shit about me, that adored me, and I failed her at every turn.” I shook my head sadly, not caring as a tear slid down my face. “The night she died; I was such a dick to the cops that came to tell me. That night, everything changed.” I pulled my water bottle out and took a drink, swallowed heavily, and when I spoke again, my voice shook with repressed sobs. The emotions were almost breaking me.

“I made my decision that night. I shed over two hundred pounds. I learned to cook and to clean, how to take care of myself, how to pay bills, all of it. And the police officer that came to the house that night has become like a father to me.” I looked at my new friends, smiling through my sadness, through the tears that fell unchecked from my eyes.

“This was my last step. My penance. Completing this trail for her, and for my father, will complete my transformation. This is what brings me from boyhood to adulthood. This is where I make them proud. If I can do this, I know I can do anything.”

Jack and Dotty said nothing. They simply stepped forward and embraced me. Allowing me to find some of the solace that I so desperately sought in their arms for a few moments. They held me while I cried, freely and openly, the sobs finally breaking free from my soul. No words. No judgement. No shame. Just the honest tears of a young man that was seeking redemption, in whatever way he could.

When the torrent ended and I could breathe again, we parted. Jack looked away for a moment, hiding his own tears. Dotty, for her part, let hers flow over her face while she rummaged for clean wipes for me and her both.

“I’m so happy we met you.” She said softly, handing me a tissue, “and your parents are already proud of you, trail or not. Look at all you’ve done

since then.”

“She’s right, bud.” Jack clapped me on the back, like a big brother might. “Hell, I just met you and I’m already proud of you.”

I smiled warmly at them, thanked them for their kind words and for listening, and we turned back to the trail. A few stray sniffles marked our steps as the pain lingered and then faded. Before too long, Dotty had pulled us into a new conversation, keeping the topic light and funny. Too much darkness had already seeped into the day, literally and figuratively, as the canopy darkened with the threat of rain. We picked up their pace, hoping to get somewhere to rest before the sky broke open.

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Chapter 10

Lost in the Storm

LESS THAN TEN MINUTES later, the rain poured from the sky, streaming through the canopy overhead like water from a fountain, drenching us before we could find shelter. The path grew slippery with mud as we trudged along the narrow trail. Our packs hung sodden and heavy from our shoulders as we marched along, single file, with Jack leading the way. The forest grew murky and thick with mist rising from the heated ground. The low light and heavy rain made it hard to see through the downpour. Up ahead, Jack spotted an offshoot from the trail, deciding to take it in the hopes of finding somewhere we could wait out the storm.

He glanced back to make sure Dotty, and I were watching and pointed toward the trail on the left when we looked at him. We nodded, both of us looking like drowned rats. Jack chuckled, taking in our disheveled state, ours and his own. Our hair was plastered on our faces, water streamed from our jackets and backpacks. Mud covered our boots and the bottoms of our pants. We made quite the sight, a trio of newbies, out on the trail.

Jack led the way up the secondary trail. He frowned, not liking how it grew narrower and more overgrown. I was growing concerned about the harsher terrain, but the direction seemed to lead parallel to the one they were on. If it led to us finding an overhang somewhere, a clearing for the tent, anyplace where we could get dry, I would be happy.

The storm pounded us as we scurried along the muddy path, branches and loam slipping and sliding beneath muddy feet. The scent of summer rain against heated pine and birch filled our nostrils, mixing with the aroma of decaying wood and greenery of all kinds. Steam lifted from the ground, the humidity and moisture reacting to the heat of the day. It clung to the ground, making it seem as if we waded through fog. After what seemed like a mile, we spotted a clearing just beyond the trail that looked large enough to fit the tent. I really didn't want to go any further beyond the main trail, and a sharp incline began just a few yards ahead.

Jack stopped and turned back to us, almost yelling to be heard over the driving rain.

"There's a clearing just through there." He said, pointing toward the cluster of trees. We nodded and followed, exhaustion clear on our soaked faces. Wet to the bone, mud up to our shins, we picked our way through the trees and brushed to the middle of the cluster of Hemlock and Ash. Moss clung to the trees like coats of emerald velvet.

Dotty leaned against one, ducking beneath its branches, waiting for Jack and me to set up the tent. She grabbed her water bottle and took a long drink, visibly shivering in her wet clothes. It had been warm, but the cloud cover and drenching rain had chilled her skin. She smirked a little as Jack and I slid around the damp clearing, struggling with the tent.

Finally, we were able to stake it down and waved her over. She ducked inside as we waited, crawled in on her knees, leaving her boots sticking just outside. She quickly took them off and brought them inside, laying them on top of her pack. At least mud wouldn't get all over the tent. We followed her actions and did the same, crawling inside and dragging packs and boots after us.

Dotty pulled out a dry towel, wiped her face, and passed it to Jack. I was already rummaging around in my pack for something dry to use. We got settled, stripping off damp overshirts and socks and putting on dry ones. As we finished trying to maneuver in the cramped space, we made ourselves as comfortable as possible and pulled out the leftovers from Miss Trudy's picnic.

"What a downpour." I said, breaking the silence as we ate. An intense shiver ran down my spine and I shuddered, still chilled from the rain.

"It really is something." Jack replied. He was finishing one of Miss Trudy's cinnamon rolls, licking his fingers as he spoke. Dotty chuckled at him, tossing him the damp towel.

"Hey, the icing is the best part," he said, but took the towel anyway. He wiped his hands and put his trash in the now empty lunch bag.

"I wonder how long it will last," Dotty said. She leaned back on her palms, stretching her legs out and leaning against her pack behind her.

"Hopefully not long," I said. "I'd like to get some more miles behind us before nightfall."

"Well, if nothing else, we bundle up, put our parkas on and make the best we can of it. It's called roughing it for a reason." Jack said, getting comfortable on his side of the tent.

“That’s true. Guess it’s just my spoiled former nature speaking,” I said, honestly. “A few years ago, I wouldn’t have gone outside in this at all. Hell, I barely went outside for any reason.”

“It’s impressive how much you’ve changed your life in just two years,” Jack replied. “Seriously, that’s a lot. To become that self-aware and put that much work into learning and doing the things you’ve done to change and grow, to better your situation, especially during a grieving period. Not many people could have done that, not the way you did it.”

Dotty was nodding as Jack spoke. “He’s right. You should be proud of yourself.”

I felt my cheeks grow hot as I blushed from the praise. I had never been able to accept compliments, but I know they meant it. They were the sincerest people I had ever met, next to Marshall and Miss Trudy.

A noise outside interrupted the sound of the driving rain, echoing off the trees before it faded into nothingness. We froze, sharing a look as the sound came again. It was louder and closer this time. A forlorn howl, deep and ominous, wolf-like but not quite the same. Something about it sounded almost human, like a wailing of pain and suffering, a deep agony mixed with rage. It went on for longer than seemed possible before it faded, then sounded again.

Branches snapped somewhere close by as the howling faded.

“What the hell is that?” I said. My voice was barely audible inside the tent. Dotty’s face had grown pale. Jack shrugged, still listening intently to the sounds outside. The rain continued, beating off the tent, the wind whipped around us, and crisp snapping came from behind us, beside us, in front of us; it could have come from any direction. The rain made it too hard to tell. I whirled around in all directions, trying to pinpoint the sound.

Jack slid to the tent flap, easing the zipper down to peer out into the misty landscape. A curtain of rain clouded his vision, thick with the rising layer of fog. Something dark filled the space between the trees beyond the clearing, shifting in and out of his line of sight. It was big, as big as a human, or an animal on hind legs. We could see nothing else except the shadowy shape moving between the trees. The howl came again, sending a shiver down my back as Jack brought the zipper back down.

“There’s something out there.” He said to us. “I can’t see what it is, but it’s the thing making that sound. Just beyond the trees ahead.”

We froze as another ripping crack sounded just outside the tent. Dotty’s eyes went wide with fear. Jack reached for his gun.



AS JACK THUMBED THE safety off, a sound like wet Velcro tore through the small tent and Dotty was gone in the blink of an eye. A shriek rent the air, then cut off before Jack could even scramble outside, with me hard on his heels.

“Dotty!!” Jack screamed in the driving rain, blinded by the downpour.

“Dotty!” My panicked shouts joined Jack’s as he dashed through the trees, slipping on moss-covered branches and slick leaves. We tore through the muck, screaming for Dotty. A deep growl resonated in the air, bouncing off the surrounding trees, followed by a single, terrified, high-pitched shriek, then silence.

“Dotty!” Jack screamed again and again. I joined him, adding my voice to the chaos. We ran deeper into the forest, blinded by rain and fueled by

adrenaline, screaming for the woman that had been violently ripped from our tent.

An hour passed as we searched the forest in the torrential downpour. Finally, the rain dwindled to a steady stream, then a sprinkle, then nothing as the forest filled with a humid mist that swirled low on the ground, hiding rocks, vines, and pitfalls of all kinds. We stumbled and fell too many times to count as we searched. Our fever pace slowed to a walk, then stalled to a halt, as we realized we had no idea what to do next.



WE WERE DEEP IN the forest, far from their camp. Dotty had vanished. The woods were silent. Not a trace of her or the thing that took her. No trail. No tracks. No clue. Jack looked at me, tears and rain dripping from his face, despair and defeat clouding his features. I stared back, swallowing my own sobs, at a complete loss of words for this man that had become a friend in less time than it normally would have taken the old me to consume a pizza. Dotty was my friend too, but was she suddenly gone for good?

I didn't know what to say. I started to speak then closed my mouth, tried again, and failed. Finally, I opted to close the distance between us and put my arms around Jack. Heartbreaking sobs filled the forest for long minutes after as Jack broke down. When he was spent, he let go of me and we silently turned and began tracing their steps back to the tent. An hour later, we gave up, realizing it was futile. The rain had washed away all signs of the frantic dash through the trees. Jack finally stopped walking, leaned against a tree, and admitted what we both had known for the last twenty minutes.

“Well, we’re fucked.” He said miserably, his voice hitching with stifled sobs as he spoke.

I watched for a moment, then looked away as Jack fought for his composure.

“We just need to keep walking,” I said. “We couldn’t have gone too far from the tent. If we can mark this spot somehow, we can walk for an hour in the other direction, then retrace here and try again, if we don’t come across our gear.”

“and what about Dotty?” Jack asked, straightening up and wiping his face on his jacket sleeve.

“We can’t help her until we can help ourselves. Running around out here blind will only get us more lost and cost her more time.” I replied, gently. “I know how upset you are, and I can’t imagine how scared she must be, but all of our gear is in the tent, including the sat phone. We can’t do anything if we don’t even know where we are and have no way to contact the rangers. This is our best move.”

“Garrison, I can’t lose her,” Jack said, swallowing hard as he spoke. “I can’t just leave her out here with whatever that was. You can go to the tent. I’ll keep searching.”

“And what then?” I countered, “I lose you too? What if I do find the tent and then need to pick which one of you to find? How is that better?”

“I can’t—“ Jack began again, but I cut him off.

“You can. We need to be rational here. We stay together. We try to find the tent first and get our gear. If we don’t find it within the next two hours, we keep searching for Dotty, and for help.”

“Two hours,” Jack asked, “Then we start searching for Dotty again.”

“Two hours,” I agreed. “It might not even take that long, but we have to try.”

Jack removed his jacket, tied it around a branch just above him, then turned back to me.

“Let’s go.” He said.

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Chapter 11

The Search for Dotty

JACK AND I SET off through the muddy forest, keeping a straight line past the tree where Jack had left his jacket. I noted the time as we went, grateful I at least had my watch on when we dashed from the tent after Dotty. Thirty minutes later, we still had not reached the clearing, or any sign of one. The woods around us looked alien and untraveled by any human traveler. We stopped for water, already eager to turn back and try a new direction.

We agreed to start again, silently turning back the way they had come and trudging back through the underbrush. Around us, the trees were quiet; I could see the animals watching our return trek, glimpsing beady eyes glinting from the treetops.

When we reached the tree where the blue jacket fluttered limply in the gentle breeze, I let Jack choose the next direction. This time we went to the left of the tree, anxiously scanning the trees for any sign of our race through the forest of Dotty, or the clearing.

I could feel the tension pouring off Jack as he called his wife's name, over and over. Every few calls, the man's voice would break, and he would stop,

stifling sobs as he did so. My heart ached for him. I picked up the call for Dotty every time Jack's voice broke off. I found myself praying to whatever deity that might be able to hear them for help, for any sign of Dotty or the tent, and for this sudden nightmare to be over. It had all been going so well.

Why the hell would any god allow this to happen? What was happening and why? What the hell was that thing that took her? Was it even the same thing that I had spotted earlier, or what Buck had seen? Was there something more to fear out here than normal woodland creatures?

My mind went wild with questions, mental ramblings consuming me as I followed Jack through the misty sea of tree trunks, vines, and rotting leaves.

Jack stopped for more water, tears trickling down his cheeks, mixing with the sweat and grime on his neck and collarbone. His eyes were red, swollen, and glassy with tears that had not yet fallen. I opened my mouth to speak but could say nothing. *What was there to say?*

I only patted his back while the man took a moment to gather himself, then I stepped in front of Jack and began to lead once more. This time, I took a slightly diagonal approach to the direction we were heading, checking my watch once more. We had about an hour left before the two-hour mark would pass and we would need to return to Jack's tree and trek deeper into the woods.

I tried not to think of what might be left to find. I blinked the fresh onslaught of tears away and coughed to cover the sound of my sniffing as I pushed deeper into the mossy rainforest.

Chapter 12

Dotty

DOTTY LAY CURLED IN a heap at the base of the cavern wall, trembling with fear as she stared at the thing blocking the entrance. It paced back and forth, on thick limbs that gouged the earth as it pawed at the ground every few minutes, angry snorts flaring its nostrils. It turned to look at her and she tensed, lowering her eyes to the ground. She stared at the ripped knees of her jeans, at the blood still seeping from the scratches beneath the tatters. Her ankle was swollen under her boot and throbbed with her every breath. She wanted to undo the laces and remove the boot, but she knew it was the only thing supporting her injury right now.

She released a shaky breath as the thing paced once more, turning its attention back to the forest. The creature had drug her through the woods with one leg, her body slamming against fallen trees, and jagged rocks. She knew her body would be covered in bruises if she ever got the chance to exam her injuries. Blood seeped into one eye from a long scratch above it. She gingerly touched it, wincing as it caused more pain to flare up in her skull as she probed it. The crimson still flowed freely, not yet clotting, so it

was deeper than she thought. She felt more welts and gouges on her face. Some of those were tacky and clotting, and only stung a little when she pressed on them. Her jawline ached, and she knew she would see a massive bruise there if she could see her reflection.

Despite the race through the torrential downpour, she was relieved that she did not have any other injuries that she could see, at least not major ones, save a badly twisted ankle. She heard the thing utter a growl, and she risked another glance at it.

The coarse fur shimmered in the dim light. It looked to be a light tan color, almost white, but was thin, close to the thick hide beneath. It bristled and appeared long from a distance, but seeing it now, up close with it calmer, the short hairs lay flat and translucent against the skin beneath. Dotty had never seen anything like it. It wasn't any animal she had ever seen and had a humanoid appearance when it reared up on the hind legs. She didn't know if it was the thing that Buck or Garrison had seen before, but whatever this was, it wasn't natural, and it scared the hell out of her.

The limbs were thick, tightly corded with muscle, and the head was rounded like a human, with a deep brow, and wide-set nostrils and eyes. The lower jaw jutted forward slightly, and fangs poked just above the bottom lip. The eyes were sunk deep into the facial structure and the entire head bore that same strange fur that covered its body. It whirled suddenly, and she gasped, quickly dropping her eyes. It was almost like it could sense her studying it. It turned fully toward her and lumbered over, moving like a silverback on knuckles and paws.

It lowered its head, sniffed her, and she saw the eyes narrow as the lips pulled back from sharp fangs. The putrid breath of the beast puffed in her face as it huffed and snorted, hovering over her.

It lifted a paw to her stomach and grasped her jacket, lifting her slightly from the ground, then it wrenched her up further, letting her dangle there in its grasp. She finally looked at it, meeting its yellow eyes as they glared at her. That was the last thing she saw as it slammed her against the cavern wall and let her drop to the ground.

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Chapter 13

The Search Continues

GROWING FRUSTRATION WAS EVIDENT in Jack's voice as I led us through the muddy terrain. Jack's calls for Dotty wavered between broken sobs and rising fear. His words to me had become short and sharp, fired like angry bullets at every turn. I stifled a sigh as the man unleashed another torrent of words at his back.

"Man, I'm telling you, we should have kept searching for her. We need to turn back! This is getting us nowhere." Jack spat.

"Dotty!" I yelled again, ignoring Jack, letting him vent.

"Garrison, are you even listening to me?"

"Dotty!" I called again, not wanting to argue with Jack. I understood his fear and his anger, both rooted in panic and worry for his wife.

"Garrison, damnit man, just stop!" Jack finally yelled.

"What?" I said, ducking beneath a clutch of vines and stepping a few feet past it.

"I said we need to turn back." Jack started to say but then stopped, joining me where I stood.

We stood stunned for a long moment, then Jack broke into sobs.

We were standing roughly fifty yards from the tent, on the opposite side of where we had raced off in pursuit of Dotty and whatever had taken her. The tent sagged under the rain and wind, strips of canvas rippling in the breeze from the claw marks.

We looked at each other, then hurried forward to retrieve the gear.

“We must have gone in a circle.” I said as I dropped to my knees in front of the tent. I slid inside and grabbed all three of the packs and pushed them outside to Jack.

“I’m sorry I yelled at you,” Jack said when I re-emerged. “I’m just so scared for Dotty—“

I immediately cut him off. “No apology needed. I know you’re scared, so am I. I didn’t know where we were going, but I knew we needed to try. The best thing we can do for her is get outside help, search and rescue, the rangers, the police. Hell, everyone, but we can’t do that without the sat phone.” I pulled the device from his pack and held it out.

“I know but—”

“No buts. We are fine. Check your pack, take only what you need. The less weight we carry, the faster we can go. I’m going to call Marshall and the rangers.” I grabbed my pack and stepped over to a fallen log to sit on while I made the call and sorted through my gear.

Jack followed suit, grabbing the other two packs and settling on a stump a few yards away. He pulled things from each bag, condensing food and weapons into his own pack and putting extra clothes and other equipment into his wife’s bag.

When I finished explaining the situation to Marshall, I ended the call with a promise to report back in four hours with coordinates. Marshall had

confirmed what I already knew; we were just over five miles away from the main trail. The storm had really gotten them turned around and the side trail Jack had taken took them deeper into the forest, not parallel to the trail like they had thought.

I sighed, put the phone back in my pack, then opened it and pulled excess clothing and cooking supplies from it. Jack turned to me when he heard the call end and waited expectantly, but I purposefully kept my head down, avoiding eye contact. Needing the moment to gather my courage for his reaction to more bad news.

“Well?” He finally asked, hefting his pack to his back, and carrying Dotty’s to the tent, sliding it back inside.

“Well, it’s more bad news.” I said, looking at him sadly. “We are a lot deeper into the woods than we thought. I sent Marshall the coordinates. He’s going to call the rangers so we can save battery.”

“How much deeper?”

“About five miles from the main trail.” I replied. “Which will only get worse as we search for Dotty. Marshall suggested we wait here for help to come, but I told him that we were going after her.”

“You damn right. Waiting any longer is not even an option.” Jack said, “You ready to go?”

“Almost. What weapons do we still have?” I asked as I stood up. “I have the hunting knife and a small can of bear spray, plus the sat phone is secured, the GPS beacon is on, and there’s enough food for a day or two.”

Jack’s smile was a tight-lipped grimace as he held up the gun and lifted his flannel, showing a large blade in a sheath. “I’ve got a few things. Stow the rest of your gear in the tent and let’s go.”

I nodded, gathered the small pile of excess supplies in my arms and slid them into my sleeping bag, using it as an extra pack. I rolled it up, secured it, and put it next to Dotty's bag inside the tent. Jack had taken the heavy roll of duct tape they had brought and was using it to secure the strips of canvas that had been torn in the attack. When I joined him outside, we finished taping the rips in the entrance flaps, zipped it closed, added more tape over the zipper for extra security then put the tape in his bag.

"At least it will keep the rain out. Won't stop anyone from stealing it, but maybe it will help."

I didn't have the heart to tell him that any animal looking for food may very well destroy the tent anyway, but I appreciated and understood the effort all the same. I knew Jack was only looking for ways to occupy the nervous energy that filled him.

"Let's go," I said quietly to Jack, leading him into the forest once more. Neither of us spoke of the drag marks that were clearly visible as we followed wide tracks made by Dotty's body as she was pulled into the woods.

Chapter 14

Dotty: Part II

DOTTY WOKE UP TO the sensation of being dragged along rough terrain. Sharp spikes of pain dug into her body inch by inch; rocks, sticks, thorns, and roots all gouged her exposed flesh where her shirt had ridden up during the trek. The creature had her by the leg, painfully gripping her twisted ankle. Her head bounced as it pulled her along, heaving her side to side, letting her body slam against the cavern walls and boulders that littered the path.

She clenched her jaw, squeezing her lips into a tight line, suppressing screams eager to burst from her mouth. She did not want this thing to know she was awake. She opened her eyes, staring at the dark cave as she was yanked along in short bursts. The creature grunted as it went, huffing and snorting from effort, as it traveled the murky corridor.

She could smell the vile odor that emanated from it and from the cave, fetid and sour with decay, wet earth, stagnant water, and the ripe stench of excrement and urine. Dotty could see no viable light source, but she was able to make out shadows and shapes. There was nothing in the cave around her to see but the thing dragging her and rocks looming over her blurry eyes.

She bit back another scream as her head slammed into a rock and blinked the tears away, letting them escape her eyes and race down her dirty cheeks. Her ankle throbbed beneath the creature's grip. She could feel it pulsing in time with her heartbeat, which slammed against her chest. She had no

choice but to play dead and hope this nightmare would end, one way or the other.

She had no foolish ideations of surviving whatever this was, but she hoped Jack would. Her only thought was that he and Garrison were safe and not foolishly rushing after this monster to save her. This deep in the earth, she knew she would never be found, her or her body. She closed her eyes and let the darkness claim her, as pain overwhelmed her once more.

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Chapter 15

A Bit of Hope

JACK TRUDGED THROUGH THE moss-covered forest, following me. He had grown silent over the last hour, throat raw from screaming, eyes burning with tears, sweat, and fear. He had tried to explain how he was overwhelmed with rage. Trying to keep his emotions from shutting him down and leaving him unable to function at all. Jack felt bad for shouting at me when he knew I was trying to help. I told him I didn't need an explanation, but he insisted on one. His nervous energy was ruling his emotions right now. I stayed quiet and let him vent.

I was a newbie to the outdoors, just like they were, and I was out here fighting my own demons, but right now, I knew I would stay by Jack's side for however long it takes. I already knew that Jack and Dotty would be friends for life, whether that ended here in the woods or many years down the road remained to be seen.

I watched Jack run his hands over his face and through his hair, wiping away tracks of sweat and tears, smearing the dirt across his cheeks, but he didn't seem to care. I could tell it was a nervous habit. He kept running his

hands over his face and then roughly massaging his scalp in one long motion. He kept doing it as we walked, in between calling for Dotty.

Even in the midst of this crisis, Jack was so earnest and endearing that it touched my heart. At this moment, there was no place else that I could think of that I would rather be right now. I was meant to be here, at this moment, to help Jack and Dotty. I could feel it in my bones. I did wish that maybe Buck or one of the other seasoned hikers we had met at Miss Trudy's was with us. I would give anything to have that entire crew with us right now, tearing apart these woods helping us search.

I beat back vines and thick underbrush with the long branch I had made into a walking stick and faux scythe as we went, helping clear a path. I heard Jack stop as I came to a halt in front of him. He stepped closer to me as I bent closer to the ground, curious to see what I found. I dropped to one knee and carefully pulled something from a twisted vine at my feet. When I stood, I showed it to Jack. Jack took the bit of yellow cloth in his hands and looked at me, nodding in response to the question that had not been asked.

"Dotty's coat, right?" I quietly said, gesturing at the fabric.

"Yeah, sure looks the same." Jack said.

"On the right path then, I thought maybe we had lost it coming up the hill back there."

"Let's keep going. I want to cover as much ground as we can before nightfall. We won't be able to see much with just our flashlights."

"Agreed. Look like whatever took her drug her the whole way through here." I turned to gesture at the semi-clear swath of brush and debris ahead of them. A clear sign that something was dragged through the muddy soil.

"Let's keep going. I'll lead for a while." Jack said, stepping forward. I agreed, quietly patting him on the back as he passed, then fell in step behind

him, setting off once more into the murky green.

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Chapter 16

Dotty: Part III

DOTTY WOKE TO A mix of deep growling, angry grunts, and the clang of rocks pounding against rock. She kept still, not wanting to open her eyes to whatever fresh hell lay before her, knowing she had to open them eventually before the horror of the unknown unleashed a wail of terror from her lips. Pain wracked her petite frame. She tried to breathe in slowly, not wanting to alert the creature to her movements. Dotty pressed her lips together in a tight barrier against the sound threatening to spill from her mouth as the simple act of breathing set her ribs on fire.

She opened her eyes, allowing only the smallest slit to widen beneath her lids, and tried to blink enough to clear her vision. Tears immediately welled in her eyes as she took in the dozen creatures standing before her, backs turned, engaged in a discussion of sorts. More of the angry grunts issued from her captor as the long arms gestured and pointed at something. A deep growl met the challenge that was being issued.

Glowing amber eyes flashed in her direction as another creature raised its head to glare at her, more gesturing from it and its kin as the first grumbled more then turned to look at her. She dropped her gaze, but kept her lids open just a fraction, not willing to be blind to whatever came next. It came toward her, lifted her by her jacket like a rag doll and shook her, grunting rancid breath in her face.

It shook her again, then a heavy paw slapped her face, shocking her eyes fully open. She gasped from the pain as her head rocked backwards. The

shaking stopped, and she lifted her head, focusing on the thing that held her in its solid grasp. It stared at her, an odd mix of anger and satisfaction on its face. It shook her again, turned and held her out toward the others. A deep grunt rumbled from its chest as the others hooted in excitement from the sound of it.

They wanted her awake for whatever came next, or maybe proof that she was still alive. The pack of creatures flew into a frenzy as they hooted their approval at the creature presenting her to the pack. Dotty took in the massive size of each lumbering form as they moved about the deep cavern. She saw several smaller forms emerge from the rear of the cave, maybe coming from another corridor or just hidden by the shadows there. Dotty couldn't be sure.

Her captor grunted again, then dropped her to the ground. Her ankle slammed against a rock as she fell and there was no stopping the shriek of pain that burst from her. The thing reared up to its full height and roared at her. Dotty clenched her jaw, anger taking over her, and screamed back. The cavern fell silent as the creatures stopped their activity to watch the new challenge.

She stared at the humanoid beast as it dropped back down on all fours, hovering over her prone body. She saw the thick lips curve into a cruel sneer, saw it move closer to her face. She even saw the motion of its rear leg as it lifted, saw the anticipation in its eyes as it watched her.

Her last thought as the thing rammed its leg down on her ankle was that these monsters, whatever they were, were intelligent. Blackness took her as the bones in her ankle snapped, crushed beneath the solid weight of her captor.

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Chapter 17

The Cave

JACK AND I CAME to a halt at the base of a rocky cliff that rose a few feet ahead of us. It was almost hidden beneath a steady rise of trees. Jack only caught sight of it just as we were about to pass. Closer inspection of the ground showed the muddy drag marks we had been following. The afternoon had grown late; the light turned a deep murky yellow highlighting leaves kissed by the first streaks of the blazing sunset.

The entrance appeared like a black hole right in front of them. Muddy underbrush littered the entrance, but another wide swath cut through the debris where Dotty had been dragged inside. We looked at each other, and suddenly words were too difficult to speak, but the look in Jack's eyes said enough.

We pulled flashlights out, got our weapons ready, and with Jack leading the way, we stepped into the void. We could hear the faint trickle of water seeping down the rock walls and the sounds of insects skittering across the ground. The crunch of dead leaves and decaying branches beneath our boots seemed to echo from every surface. I cringed when my boot kicked a small

stone and sent it tumbling into the cavern wall; it sounded louder than a gunshot. Jack turned to me, his eyes shining unnaturally white in the gloom of the cave.

I shrugged sheepishly, feeling foolish and mildly irate. It wasn't really my fault. We couldn't see for shit. We were on edge and terrified. And now here we were, walking into god only knows what, to find Dotty, or what remained. I bit my lip as that lone thought crushed my soul and my momentary annoyance. I stifled the snarky remark I was going to make to Jack. I stayed silent, understanding too well the weight we were under, Jack doubly so.

I waved Jack forward, whispering "sorry" as softly as I could. I kept my steps lighter than before, trying to place my boots as carefully as I could, shining his light on the ground rather than ahead of them. Jack could see up front. I only needed to follow him and watch my own steps.

The air in the cave was thick with the fetid stench of rot and filth. The metallic scent of stagnant water coated our tongues as we wove deeper into the earth. I shivered, grateful for my jacket, when the cave suddenly grew colder as the last of the light disappeared as we stepped around a sharp curve in the corridor. Faintly, from far ahead of them, or beneath them, came a low moan followed by hooting and rumbling sounds.

Jack froze. I did the same. We held our breath, listening intently to the noise again. A piercing shriek split the air seconds later. Jack opened his mouth to cry out, but I quickly stepped to him and slapped a hand over his mouth by pure instinct, shaking my head "no", to get him to remain quiet. The hooting came again, more rumbling, like a small freight train was passing beneath our feet.

It could have been a rockslide or a herd of animals racing through the dark. The muffled sound made it hard to discern, but we could feel the tremors deep underground. Jack tapped my hand, signaling for me to let go. He exhaled when I stepped back. The breath came out in a quivering hiss as Jack calmed down.

We stood there, rooted to the spot, waiting for more rumbling or shrieking to come. When none did, we moved forward again, slower than before. My skin was clammy, fear oozed from my pores and a cold sweat rolled down my back. Instinct told us to dim the lights and almost as one unit, we toggled the flashlight switches to the 'Low' setting, aiming them only at the ground at our feet. My ears became my guide as sight grew limited. We resorted to hand signals for communication as we moved along the tight corridors of rock and packed earth, tunneling ever deeper into the ground.



LONG MINUTES LATER, MY stomach clenched, and my bowels weakened as the coppery scent of blood assaulted my senses. Jack stopped moving and shone his light on the cavern wall opposite them. He illuminated a dark stain oozing from the rock wall, still wetly dripping in some places. Crimson trickled between crevices in the rock, running down the sides and splattering into the dirt. There was no body, no remnants of clothing, only the burgundy stain of death and violence.

“We need to keep going, Jack.” I finally said, putting a firm hand on Jack’s back to guide him away from the gruesome scene.

“But, what if—“ Jack trailed off, not able to finish the thought we both were thinking.

“We need to keep moving. We heard her scream. Just a few minutes ago, and it was much further away than this.”

“You don’t know that.” Jack whispered. The words sounded harsh and desperate, even in his low tone.

“It’s a cave,” I reminded him. “Think about it. It would have echoed much louder had she been this close. Whatever this is, it’s not from her. This is too fresh. Look, it’s still dripping.”

Jack looked at the wall, swallowing hard as he ran his light over the darkening stain. I knew I was right. I would bet on it. If it was Dotty, the scream had been almost twenty minutes ago. The blood would not still be running like it was, would it? Jack ran his light over it, and then on the ground, trying to decide for himself if I was right.

Or was he only delaying the inevitable? I mused sadly, my heart going out to him all over again. Fear gripped Jack. I saw it happen, in a slow and surreal display. Jack stood motionless, unable to breathe, unable to speak, unable to move at all. His hands trembled, violently. His body followed suit. I saw his legs buckle, and he stumbled. I caught him and guided him to the opposite wall with a steadying hand.

“Not now, man. You cannot fall apart right now. We are too far in, too close to Dotty. She needs us. She needs you. Fuck, man, I need you. I can’t do this alone.” I spoke softly, urgently. Jack’s eyes, glassy with grief, pierced me to my core. I almost broke right then and there.

“Now, I don’t know what we are facing here, but I do know that I am not leaving you to face it alone. We do this together, or we die trying.” I gave him a firm shake, gripping both his shoulders, then pulled water from his pack. “Take a drink. Take a breath and let’s go find your wife.”

Jack nodded, blinking the tears away, then wiped his face with his jacket sleeve. He took the water, drank deeply several times, rinsed his face with a small splash, then straightened up. He took a full minute to breathe, deep calming breaths, while I drank from my own bottle. I removed my hunting knife from the sheath on my hip. I saw Jack smile slightly as I did so. He pulled his gun out, checked it, and signaled he was ready. We moved forward. I took point, knife ready in one hand, light gripped in the other. Two soldiers, ready for battle, unsure of what enemy they faced.

Chapter 18

Dotty: Part IV

DOTTY CAME AWAKE TO a dull roar of water rushing past her ears. It sounded like static white noise in her head. Pain throbbed in her ankle, mimicking the rapid heartbeat of a fetus. She blinked, trying to clear her vision. Her skull ached, and the world began to fade. She struggled to move, shaking her head to regain her awareness. Droplets of moisture coated her face as she did so, and she finally came to her senses. She was lying half in a pool of water. Her left leg and hip were soaked through, and her hair was drenched.

Dotty moaned, biting her lip as she rolled slowly to her side, needing to see where she was. The pack of creatures moved around her, on the far side of the cavern. Several bodies, human and animal, lay partially submerged in the same pool she was in, bloated and oozing rank fluids into the black water.

She bit back the scream that she ached to let loose and dragged her body forward like a wounded soldier to the cave floor and out of the putrid basin of water. Two of the creatures turned to watch her, eyes narrowed under heavy brows. They turned back to whatever task they were doing when she stopped moving, making low grunting sounds as they did so. A squelching sound met her ears, and she turned her head to glance behind her.

One of the smaller creatures was squatting over a half-eviscerated corpse and was tearing strips of gray flesh from its torso with wet ripping sounds. Wide jaws chewed with loud smacking sounds; bits of skin hung from its

teeth as it stared at her. It bent low and tore another strip free from the neck of the body. More moist smacking sounds followed as it continued to eat.

Dotty turned around, bile in the back of her throat, unable to watch any longer. She clenched her jaw, refusing to give in. She breathed through her nose, willing her stomach to calm down. Dotty rested her head on her arm, covertly watching the pack of creatures. Several terms came to mind: Big Foot, Sasquatch, missing link. She almost snorted with the last term, recognizing she was near hysteria. None of these seem to fit the traditional description, but how many people had seen a sasquatch, let alone survived whatever these things were to tell about it?

Dotty inhaled, mentally steeling herself to go into research mode, like she had as a med student. Push through the pain and exhaustion, focus on the issue at hand. She needed information. Knowledge was power and it sure couldn't hurt in this situation. So, she watched, and she learned.

The creatures moved like humans, albeit more gorilla-like in stance and motion. The arms were longer than human, with hands that were topped by curved yellow claws and covered in coarse fur. Feet were heavily padded with thick claws. Their bodies were stocky, muscular, not fat, with torsos as round as whiskey barrels. The head was almost human, but larger, with a heavier bone structure than a modern human. Deep-set eyes beneath an overhanging brow and a wide chiseled jaw that extended further than a normal human. Short, coarse fur of varying shades covered most of them from head to toe. She saw the one that had captured her. The telltale scar on the snout and light-colored fur gave him away from the rest.

Several looked larger than the rest and she mused that they were females. Heavy mounds of flesh hung from their upper torsos where breasts would be on a woman. These mounds resembled the padding of their feet, like a

gorilla paw. Where the others had fur all over, these few had those odd mounds that looked like rough velvet patches on their chests.

There seemed to be a hierarchy at play, and a language, albeit mostly one of grunts and odd rumbling sounds they emitted from their throats. Dotty couldn't tell who the leader was or what it was based on, as it seemed orders came from one female and one male. She tried not to vomit as two smaller creatures yanked a rotted corpse from the pool of water and began tearing into its bloated stomach, pulling the remaining innards from its depths.

The vile stench of rot and excrement filled the cavern as they tore the flesh from the bones, piling it up on the cave floor next to the oozing entrails. The fresh corpse of a fawn was hauled from the water next, the neck still gushing crimson across the cavern floor as they pulled it next to the other body.

More creatures came over to join the meal and Dotty finally heaved as the sounds of moist tearing, ripping, chewing, and squelching filled the dim chamber. The sound turned her stomach, making her remember a warm pasta salad from a too hot Fourth of July picnic, and the nauseating symphony of wet noodles being stirred. They barely turned to her as she vomited nothing but water and stomach acid into the water. Her body trembled as she did so, every heave making her broken ankle shake and quiver.

Pain shot through her body with every lurch of her stomach and tears poured down her face as she watched the pack of humanoid beasts' gorge on the flesh of once living animals and people. She suddenly and very clearly understood why she had been brought here.

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Chapter 19

Plan and Purpose

THE SOUND OF FALLING water grew louder as we trudged through the muddy gravel that littered the cavern corridors. The corridor grew tighter, and the ceiling dropped ever lower, causing us to hunch over and crab walk sideways to fit through the passage. We were in almost total darkness, using sound to guide us and the dim beams of a single flashlight. A chaotic murmur of noise could be heard ahead: water splashing on rock, snarling, and grunting, the soft whimpering of a person in pain, and the sound of something loud smashing against rock.

Neither of us spoke as the tension grew. I could feel it like a tangible mass that clung to our bodies as we crept along, a cancerous growth borne of terror and the unknown. As the cavern widened, the sounds grew louder, and we paused, not sure how to proceed. If this passage opened into one large chamber, then we would be exposed before we could formulate a plan. Any hope of rescuing Dotty would be forfeit due to poor planning, but what other options did we have?

Jack pulled on my arm, tugging on me until we stopped a few feet from the widened opening.

“We need a plan.” Jack whispered as I turned to look at him. The upturned flashlight illuminated Jack’s face in a bizarrely creepy fashion. Goosebumps littered my arms as he stared at me for a moment, leaving me deeply unsettled.

“What do you suggest? I’ve never fought anything, and I don’t know what we are facing. But if we don’t get in there and find her soon, a plan isn’t going to help us.” I whispered.

“We have a gun. We go in loud, yelling, cause chaos and start blasting whatever monster we see.”

“How is that a plan?” Jack said, staring at me.

“Distraction,” I shrugged. “I saw it in a movie. There’s only two of us, but they don’t know that. The more noise we make, the more these creatures will be confused. Surprise them, shoot whatever moves, grab Dotty, and run.”

“So, they can chase us all the way back while we carry her out?” Jack asked, shaking his head.

“Yes, but remember how tight the tunnels have been. Only one person, or ...thing, can come through at once. We shoot it and keep moving. When the bullets run out, I’ll start stabbing and you keep going with Dotty. It’ll give you time to escape, if nothing else. It’s the best idea I have.” I said, offering a tight smile.

“Garrison, I can’t let you do that.” Jack said, his stance shifting from tension to sorrow and worry in a matter of seconds.

“Yes, you can, and you will. I’ve been a piece of shit my whole life. If I can atone for that, here and now, by helping you rescue Dotty, then so be it.

This is why I am here; I know that now. My whole journey has been about making up for what I've done with my life. This debt is owed and I'm damn sure going to pay it." I nodded at Jack as I spoke, adamant in my conviction. This was my purpose. I knew that now.

Jack hugged me, awkwardly, with the hand not holding the gun. I could feel the turmoil of emotions pouring from him. The lump in my throat almost blocked my next words.

"Let's go get your wife." I said. I turned, pulled the large knife from its sheath, and steeled myself. I took a second to recall every brave moment my dad had ever shared with me, every bit of courage that I had ever encountered, and tried to capture that feeling in my soul and in my mind.

A deep breath, a final glance at Jack, and I moved into the darkness. Jack followed; gun ready. My every sense vibrated on high alert and my blood ran cold in my veins. Terror gripped me, fear like I had never known, yet all of it was overshadowed by admiration for the man that followed me. That, and the sense of his love for his wife, pushed me headfirst into the unknown.

Chapter 20

Dotty: Part V

DOTTY WATCHED HELPLESSLY AS two of the creatures lumbered in her direction. A series of grunts and snarls issued between them as they came. Their beady eyes homed in her as she lay half in the fetid pool of water. The other creatures turned to watch. Low rumbles of approval filled the cavern as they began to hoot and growl in a language only they understood.

Tears spilled from her eyes as they came closer. She had no fight left, no desire to call out, no strength. Her ankle was shattered. She couldn't run or fight, even if she found the will to do so. She closed her eyes and sent a silent prayer out to whatever god may be listening to keep Jack from this place, to keep him safe, and to please, *please*, make whatever came next, quick.

She heard them huffing in her face as they closed in. A massive paw clutched her hair and pulled. Another paw gripped her leg, pulling her from the water. Dotty clenched her jaw as pain rippled through her body. She refused to scream, refused to alert anyone that maybe around that she was here. No one deserved to be eaten alive. They pulled her across the rocky earth, water squelching beneath their feet, mud oozing between their leathery toes. Dotty kept her eyes closed as she felt her body leave the ground.

One of them lifted her, dangling her on one leg as more grunting filled the air. Then, a startling commotion erupted from one of the connecting tunnels.

Yelling, angry male voices, and it sounded like a lot of them, echoed all around her. She felt her body swing around. A sudden impact against the cave wall jarred her entire body as she fell from the creature's grasp, landing with a sharp shriek with her shattered ankle crumpled beneath her.

As blackness enveloped her, she thought she heard Jack's voice, and then a furious growl that shocked the beasts around her into silence.

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Chapter 21

Sudden Chaos

THE CREATURES TURNED AS Jack, and I charged into the chamber, yelling all manner of curses. From the other side of the pool, a massive wolf entered the chaos, muscles rippling beneath fur as powerful legs propelled it across the black water. The dim light reflected off the almost white fur of the wolf as it roared, challenging the creatures that surrounded Dotty's fallen body.

We froze as the wolf skidded to a stop in front of us, facing the humanoid creatures that hovered in front of Dotty. Neither of us knew what to do now. Our entire plan had gone south in a hurry. We backed away, toward the tunnel, but then I grabbed Jack's arm, whispering for him to stop as realization hit me.

"That's the animal I saw in the meadow." I said, keeping my voice low as we stood just within the shadowed mouth of the tunnel.

"Are you sure?"

"Absolutely. I'll never forget the color of that fur. It's almost silver."

“What do we do?” Jack asked, urgency filled his voice as he kept his eyes on his wife, barely visible behind a dozen of the beasts.

“We wait and we grab Dotty when we can.” I said, quietly. I focused on the face-off between the beasts and the wolf. A new noise entered the cavern, water splashing as two more massive wolves entered the pool, coming to flank the first one. Teeth bared, hackles raised, snarling at the dozen creatures.

“Wait for what?” Jack said, “all of them to tear Dotty to pieces?”

“No. Watch.” I said, “the wolves are not their friends. They’re challenging them. The way they are snarling at them, see how they are standing in front of us? They’re protecting us, not threatening us. They’re threatening them.”

“You mean saving us for their dinner?” Jack sounded defeated, caught between fight or flight. I could see him rushing headlong into the standoff to save his wife, come what may. Jack tensed, his thumb releasing the safety. I grabbed his forearm and shook my head.

“Just wait, give it a minute.” I was almost in tears, begging Jack to wait. “Haven’t you ever watched Animal Planet? Just watch for a minute.”

I knew I was right. I could feel it. The tension in the cave was high. The challenge had been issued. It was about to be answered.

I stepped back, tugging Jack with me just as the first creature leapt at the Alpha wolf. We flattened ourselves against the tunnel wall as fur and blood began to fly.

The sound of the fight filled the air as the wolves pounced on the beasts, jaws clamped around throats, flesh tore open, and blood poured from gaping wounds. We watched in terror as the beasts and wolves fought. Animals rabid with fury lashed out with claws and fangs, dragging each other across the ground, bleeding into the rancid water, stumbling over the

piles of mutilated corpses. Dotty lay unmoving on the far side of the room as the battle waged all around her.

We could only watch helplessly as the fight went on. The wolves closed in on the remaining three creatures, herding them into the corner. I saw their hindquarters bunch, preparing to launch, saw their bodies ripple and release as they left the ground. I heard the crunch of bone and the snap of powerful jaws as they sunk into the chests and necks of their enemies. I saw the creatures go limp, and I watched as the wolves flung them aside, blood and gore coating their snarling maws.

Jack trembled as they neared Dotty, sniffing at her, cautiously stepping around her. I clung to his arm, refusing to let him move.

“Wait, please. Just one more minute.” I begged him. Internally, I was begging all the gods in the universe to let me get this one thing right. *Please...I thought.... Just please.*

Jack watched, terror on his face, as the enormous wolves turned and approached the tunnel. Blood dripped from their gleaming fur and razor-sharp fangs. Amber eyes narrowed on them, focused and intent on us as we stood waiting, watching destiny approach.



WE WATCHED THE WOLVES' approach, the biggest one in the lead. Majestic heads swung warily side to side, dark blood dripped from their jaws. The leader studied them, head cocked to one side as it bent toward them. I could see the intelligence in its eyes. The animal stopped just a few feet from the tunnel, then turned to its companions. A long look was shared

between the trio, and the smaller two retreated to the rear of the cave where they had entered.

The remaining wolf looked at us again, then turned its gaze to Dotty, lingered on her still form for a minute, then looked at us again, and huffed. Jack and I could only stare, dumbfounded, as the wolf watched us. It huffed once more, then turned, lumbered toward Dotty, gently pawed at her, huffed again, and stared into the shadowy mouth of the tunnel where we stood. A low whine followed, and I finally understood what was happening.

“It wants us to go to Dotty, I think.” I whispered to Jack.

“Or it wants to eat us,” Jack said. His voice trembled as he watched the animal gently sniff his fallen wife, a massive paw nudging her body.

“See how gentle it’s being? It approached us but didn’t attack. It’s not attacking her, either. I don’t think this is a normal wolf, Jack. There’s something more happening here.”

“How would you know?” Jack growled, anger gripping him. I could sense his worry for Dotty overwhelming him. We watched the wolf step around her body, watched the animal sniff at the dead creatures strewn about, watched how it kept looking at us and whining that same low-pitched whine.

“I’m going out there. We came in here, already knowing we might not come out. We need to get her out.”

I stepped out of the shadows, hesitant at first, but when the animal only watched me, I continued. The closer I got to Dotty, the further away the wolf retreated. I exhaled when I reached her side, not realizing I had been holding my breath since I left the tunnel. I heard a noise and saw Jack approaching, caution etched on his pale face.

I dropped to his knees beside Dotty and began patting her face, calling her name. Her chest rose, and relief flooded him. She was still alive, injured, but breathing. Jack reached my side and dropped down to his wife, cradling her head in his lap, oblivious to the bloody gore pooled around him.

“Dotty. Can you hear me? Baby. Open your eyes. Dotty, come on, honey, wake up.” Jack begged her, softly stroking her cheek and forehead.

“Jack, look.”

I had pulled her pant leg up, noticing the odd angle of her ankle and her leg as I had approached.

Jack gasped when he saw the swollen lump over the top of her boot. Her flesh was discolored, purple and black, red lines feathered up her shin.

“It’s broken.” Jack said. “We need to splint it somehow, stabilize her so we can move her.” The wolf behind them was all but forgotten as we looked around the cavern for something we could use.

A soft splashing from behind made us look toward the shallow pool where the creatures’ victims were piled. The wolf was coming toward us through the water, a backpack grasped in its mouth. It dropped it on the ground next to Dotty and backed away, its eyes locked on me. I stared at it, the back of his mind itching with recognition, but he couldn’t place it. He nodded once at the animal, feeling silly, but somehow the gesture felt right.

I went to the pack and opened it, hearing Jack hurry over.

“Must belong to one of the victims.” I said, taking contents from the pack. Most of it was wet from the water, but there was a small first aid kit in a sealed bag, several elastic bandages, and a couple meal kits that were still good.

Jack tore open the first aid kit, setting the supplies on a dry rock nearby as he sorted it. I didn’t see much of use, but there were alcohol pads, several

packets of pain-relief medicine, a small kit for sutures, and a couple instant ice packs.

I trusted Jack to make it work. His training would guide him. I knew he would make something work. I saw him look at the pack again. The wheels of an idea forming in his mind, clear on his face.

“Hey Garrison, take everything out of that pack. We can cut the canvas from the poles and use them to stabilize her leg. It’s not perfect, but it’s better than nothing.”

I nodded, immediately understanding what was needed. I almost felt foolish for not thinking of it right off. A splint was needed. First thing they taught in that outdoor first-aid class Marshall insisted I take. I emptied the pack as Jack began wrapping Dotty’s leg with the bandages.

“Shouldn’t you take her boot off?” I asked, stopping to watch his progress.

“No, not right now. The boot will help keep it stable. If we try to remove it, the pain will be overwhelming, and it may aggravate the injury further. She has an infection already spreading.” Jack pointed at the slender red lines crisscrossing her shin.

“I see.” I said, “I didn’t know that.”

“No worries. Normally you would remove it, but these are not normal circumstances. They can do that at the hospital.” Jack’s voice was kind but urgent as he worked on his wife.

“Let’s get those poles ready.”

I got back to work as the wolf stood in the water, watching, silver-white fur gleaming and speckled with red.

Long minutes later, we had Dotty ready to move. As we lifted her, we saw the wolf still standing in the water a few feet away. We turned to the tunnel

we followed inside, but the animal whined and snorted.

I looked at it for a moment, then we started walking toward the tunnel again. Again, the wolf snorted, but this time it lumbered over to the tunnel, blocking it.

We stopped, confused, watching it.

“What now?” Jack asked, holding Dotty in his arms.

“Not sure.” I replied. “Give it a minute. See what it does.”

The biggest wolf stepped toward the water, looking at them, whined, then took more steps deeper into the rippling basin of murky liquid. We watched, unmoving. I whispered to Jack, almost in awe at this turn of events.

“I think it wants us to follow.”

“What?” Jack retorted, his voice incredulous. “Why would we follow it?”

“Step toward the tunnel again, slowly.” I said. Together, we took slow steps toward the corridor once more. Immediately, the wolf moved, blocking it once more, huffing. We stopped.

“Fuck it. Let’s follow it.” Jack said, giving in. “We need to get her out of here. If there’s half a chance we can get her to safety, then let’s do it.”

I agreed, and we turned toward the pool, letting the wolf lead them across. I kept one hand on the gun strapped to my belt, just in case. But all my instincts told me this animal was protecting us. A line from an old movie filled my mind, *‘the enemy of my enemy is my friend’*. It finally made sense to me in a way that it hadn’t before.

We followed the beast into the darkness, facing the unknown on a much more visceral level than either of us expected.

Chapter 22

Daylight

AS WE WOVE OUR way through the murky tunnels, light filtered its way through the darkness. The beast increased its pace and lumbered toward the shaft of sunshine that waited fifty yards ahead. Jack and I followed at a slower pace, Dotty still a dead weight in her husband's arms. We watched the enormous beast disappear into the light beyond the tunnel, but said nothing. We had come this far without a threat from the beast. Hopefully, that trend would continue once we were safely back in the forest.

I slipped further ahead, taking up the lead as Jack adjusted Dotty in his arms. A slight moan rose from her lips as he did so, and he stopped to look at her, hoping she was waking up.

"Baby? Can you open your eyes?" He asked, shaking her gently as he held her to his chest.

"Can you hear me?" Jack said again. I stopped just ahead of him, waiting for her response. When none came, Jack sighed and resumed his steps. I turned back to the opening just as a forlorn howl broke the silence beyond

the tunnels. We stopped walking, frozen by the anguish of the sound, staring at the tunnel entrance ahead of them.

Another howl sounded, a bit more distant this time, then fell silent. The soft click of the safety being thumbled off sounded loud in the silence. I held the gun in my hands, just like Buck had shown me. Jack looked at me, nodding his approval at how I held the gun steady, trained on the entrance, waiting for whatever came next. Jack shuffled backwards, leaning against the rocky wall, adopting a protective stance around Dotty in his arms. I glanced back at him, getting only a shrug in response.

There hadn't been further sounds after the last howl. I waited another two minutes, then began moving ahead once more, waving for Jack to follow.

Cautiously, we emerged from the tunnel into the blinding light of the new day. The forest was silent around us, green and bright, with a gentle breeze whispering through the canopy above.

We were blinking rapidly as our eyes tried to adjust to the light. Jack found a clear patch of ground and gently laid Dotty down. He collapsed beside her and cradled her head in his lap once more, brushing the hair from her face. I stood watch nearby, scanning the woods, searching for something.

"What is it?" Jack finally asked.

"Where did it go?" I said, turning to him.

"The wolf?" Jack asked, looking at me in surprise. "Who cares? It led us out and disappeared." He shrugged as I searched the trees again.

"But you saw how it was acting. How odd for it to just lead us out then vanish..." I trailed off as a tall figure stepped through the trees.

"Garrison, is that you?" A deep voice called out. "Jack?"

Jack and I stared at the shadowy figure coming toward us.

“Who’s there?” I replied, lifting the gun slightly, alarmed at the sudden presence of the man.

“Whoa there, son. It’s me, Buck.” The man responded, lifting both hands in a peaceful gesture. “Been looking for you fellas. Heard a distress call on the radios. You guys alright?”

“Is that Dotty?” Buck’s voice rose, concerned, then the older man came into full view as he rushed over, leaving the shadow of the trees behind. “What’s happened?”

I was so relieved to see Buck that I didn’t notice the man was barefoot.

Jack explained as Buck knelt beside them, so happy to have help nearby that he also didn’t notice the dozens of scratches on the man’s forearms and knuckles nor did he pay any attention to the blood that still rimmed his fingernails. I wished I had noticed sooner than I did.

We started telling our tale as Dotty’s eyes flickered open at last.

“Jack?” she said weakly, looking at her husband, then at me and Buck. “Where am I? How did you find me?”

Tears filled her eyes, then overflowed as relief consumed her. Jack hugged her tightly to him as I once more told the tale of the last few hours to Dotty and Buck. We barely noticed the slight rustling of the trees behind us, too intent on our tale to care.



WHEN WE FINISHED TELLING the story to Buck, he stood from the half-rotted log he’d been sitting on. “That’s a hell of a story. I told you all strange creatures were out here. That’s probably the closest encounter that

most hikers have had and lived to tell the tale.” He sighed and looked down at Jack, who still held Dotty cradled in his arms.

“First things first. We need to get the little lady to safety. She needs medical attention.”

Jack nodded. “I’ve done all I can for her out here, but without supplies, I can’t hold off the infection.”

“But Buck, I still don’t understand how you even found us?” I interjected. “You were going the other way, weren’t you?”

“We sure were, but like I said, we picked up a distress call that your Marshall called in. Your officer friend, right? He’d been calling the ranger stations for hours trying to get help here. We heard the call and turned right back around. We spread out when we reached the spot where we left you. Been searching for you all night.”

I nodded, looking down at the ground, then frowned. I glanced at Buck again.

“Where’s your boots? And your gear? Why are you barefoot?”

Buck looked away for a minute, then down at his feet, pale in the sunlight. He wiggled his toes in the leafy dirt and grinned when he looked at me again.

“Well, I had a run-in of my own. I sat down a bit ago to take a rest. Needed to change my socks because a rain shower sprang up a couple hours ago. Must have been while y’all were still in the caves. Anyway, I got as far as I could before I couldn’t stand the soggy socks anymore. I knew blisters would be quick to form if I kept it up.” He shrugged and wiggled his feet again. He chuckled as if he was embarrassed and shrugged.

“No sooner than I had taken off my boots than I heard a loud noise. Something big was moving fast through the trees. I glanced up and this

giant beast was heading right toward me. Wolf, I think, but I bolted out of the way before I could see it fully. Biggest damn wolf I ever saw, too. Left everything and ran, figured I'd get to safety first and let it move on. Then I'd go back for my stuff. But no sooner had I cleared the trees back there than I heard voices. Turned out it was you guys."

Jack and I stared at each other. "That must have been the wolf that led us out of the cave." Jack said, looking at the other men with wide eyes. "I guess it really wasn't looking to attack anyone. First helping us, then running right past Buck."

"Definitely strange, but right now, I just want out of these woods." I said, still confused but deciding that, for now, the issue was not worth puzzling over. They could do that once they were back in civilization.

"Agreed." Said Dotty, Jack echoing her.

"Well, we need to carry Dotty out. Let's retrace Buck's steps, get his gear, and then we can start hiking out." I replied, looking at Buck for approval.

"Sounds like a plan to me. If those things have another den around here, the sooner we clear out, the better." The old man. He bent and took Jack's pack from him. "I got this. You carry Dotty. We can switch as we go." He helped Jack stand and get Dotty settled in his arms and then set out, back through the trees from where he'd come. Jack followed with Dotty, and I kept watch from the back of our small pack.



IT WAS SLOW GOING, carrying Dotty through the brush, but we found Buck's gear in twenty minutes. The forest was eerily silent, and I felt as if we were being tracked the entire time. Something was still out there. I could

feel it. I holstered the gun but kept one hand on it the entire time. I scanned the surrounding trees again and again. Left to right, right to left, glance behind them, pause, listen, and repeat.

I did this for the twenty minutes it took to reach Buck's boots and pack. The feeling never left. My gut churned and my head ached.

As Buck retrieved his shoes and sat down to put them on, Jack carefully sat Dotty on the log beside Buck, carefully keeping his body close to her so she could lean on him for support. I kept looking into the darkness of the forest beyond where we stood.

Flickering shafts of sunlight filtered in from the canopy overhead, but it was still silent. One may say peaceful, but the sounds were missing. The insects chirping, the rodents skittering in the dead leaves, the birdsong, the random snort of a deer, or the crunching of branches and briars as animals darted to and from their dens. Silence permeated every inch of the trees.

"What's up, Garrison?" Jack finally asked. He had been watching me. Growing more and more concerned as I stood there, staring into nothing like I was transfixed.

"Something is wrong," I whispered. "Can't you feel it?"

"Feel what, bud?" Buck asked, standing up to settle his pack on his back.

"Just listen." I replied, my voice urgent and quiet. "Don't you hear that?"

"I don't hear anything." Buck said after a moment.

"Neither do I," said Jack.

"Exactly." I said, staring at them. "Not a single sound. Where are the birds? The insects? Hell, a squirrel chittering or racing through the leaves?"

I waited for them to get it. I could feel my face growing pale.

My stomach roiled like I was lost at sea instead of in the forest. The tension grew heavy. The air was stifling. I felt like I might start screaming

right then and there if something didn't give.

"He's right." Dotty whispered. "Something is wrong. We need to get out of here. Now."

"Pick her up, Jack. Let's keep moving." I said. "Something is watching us."

"Now, hold on, let's not panic." Buck said, trying to calm us. "It's strange for sure, but let's keep our wits about us. Jack, go on and help Dotty. Let me make sure I have everything." He looked around the area to see if he had left anything, all the while carefully scanning the shadows between the trees for himself, then helped Jack get Dotty settled once more.

"Keep between Garrison and I, Jack." Buck ordered. "Garrison, keep a careful eye behind us. Call out anything that moves. Don't pull your gun yet, but keep ready."

We started off at a faster pace, falling into line on the trail. The silence held as we moved. I felt my breath hitching in his chest. Terror had me in its grip once more. I was so glad Buck was there this time. This was bad. This was all bad.

I hadn't been this scared in the caves. Now, my heart crashed into my chest with every step I took. Dotty cried softly as the cold clasp of fear crept into her soul and began to spread. We walked into the shadows as tendrils of ice slithered up our spines.

Chapter 23

Fur and Fury

THE TENSION GREW THICK as we trudged along the path. I could feel my heart pounding in my chest. My blood ran cold in my veins. Every muscle was tight, every nerve ending screaming for me to run. I had never experienced such emotions before and now, here I was experiencing the height of absolute fear and terror twice within twenty-four hours' time. The hand holding my gun shook, and I adjusted my grip on it, using both hands, like I had seen done on cop shows.

Buck looked at me as if he could read my thoughts. I nodded as the old man cocked one eyebrow. No words needed for the question being asked. Jack held Dotty tightly against him. His heavy breathing and her painful whimpers were the only sounds in the dead forest.

I swore beneath my breath as shadows closed in. Impossibly, it was getting darker, almost too dark to see the trail. Suddenly shapes loomed ahead of them, around them, behind them. Tall, massive shapes, barely visible in the darkness, hidden by heavy leaves and the underbrush of the

forest. My stomach dropped into my boots. My hand shook, and I froze. Ahead of me, Buck stopped moving.

Jack swore as he almost ran into me, jostling Dotty slightly in his arms. He adjusted his stance, shifting her to a more comfortable position.

“What the hell, Buck? Why did you stop?” Jack asked in a harsh whisper.

“Shh. Stay still.” Buck replied. His voice was barely audible.

“What’s wrong?” Jack asked again.

“Don’t you see it?” I said, stepping up beside him. I spoke directly into his ear. My lips barely moved.

“We’re surrounded. Do. Not. Move.” My eyes drilled into Jack’s and then I looked at Dotty, making sure she got the message. Fear and urgency all conveyed through a single phrase and my tone of voice. They nodded and Dotty clung tighter to Jack.

Buck stepped backwards toward their small huddle. His blade in one hand. The shadows moved stealthily, almost mirroring his motions. For every step Buck took, the shadows took two. I could damn near hear the old man’s heart crashing against his chest, matching the frantic pace of his own.

A deafening roar split the silence, and the trees exploded around us. Branches snapped. Leaves rained down. An ear-splitting wail of fury pummeled our eardrums as we dropped to our knees, screaming. Jack barely kept hold of Dotty as his unprotected ears were assaulted by the noise.

The beasts charged toward us. Shadows of darkness moving through the trees, nothing but blurs of rage. Amber eyes glowed, focused on their target. Red eyes flickered behind them. Not one set of beasts, but two! I felt my bladder let go as Dotty began to shriek. Buck stood over us, holding his ground.

The ground rumbled beneath our feet as hundreds of pounds of monstrous flesh rushed us. Madness and fury rained down from snapping jaws as they closed in. I could only stare as a new sound joined the chaos. A deep, shuddering groan came from Buck as the old man bent over, shuddering violently as the groaning came again and again. His shirt split open down the back. His jeans burst at the thigh.

Dotty fell limp in Jack's arms as Buck exploded into a fur-covered beast, with fangs thick as branches sprouting from his elongated snout. I stared, not caring that I was covered in piss, or that I was screaming at a pitch that only dogs could hear. I stared in horror as what used to be Buck leapt over us and crashed mid-air into one of the humanoid creatures from the cave.



I RECOVERED QUICKLY AND grabbed Jack, helping him carry Dotty over to a clutch of trees off the trail as the beasts fought behind us. Two more of the massive wolf creatures had joined the fray, rocketing from the forest just as Buck had leapt at the first monster. Chaos erupted around us in a foggy fever dream as the trail came alive with snarls, yelps, and ferocious growls. Blood sprayed the leaves as a half dozen creatures that should not exist, could not exist, but did, fought over the human prey huddled just out of reach.

The wolves worked as a unit, two fighting, one protecting us as we watched in shock. I clutched the gun in one hand while my other arm was wrapped around a thin sapling for support. I no longer trusted my legs to fully support me as hysteria paralyzed all my senses.

Behind me, Jack held Dotty tight against his chest, shielding her face from the nightmare in front of them. Her entire body trembled against his, and I could hear whimpers of fear coming from her. That same fear was etched onto Jack's face. Sweat trickled from his brow, and his eyes were wide as he watched the blood frenzy just feet in front of us.

I turned back to watch as several more of the creatures emerged from the fog. The wolf pacing back and forth in front of me growled louder. The warning emanating from deep in its chest. The fur along its spine rose, stiffening into spikes as the growling grew louder.

It turned an eye toward me, slowly pacing toward my direction. The head swung from me to Jack and Dotty, and back again. I backed up. The wolf approached closer, growling, head bobbing down as it kept watching me. Finally, I got the message and backed further away, bending to grab Jack once more as I did so.

I helped him and Dotty up and we pushed further into the copse of trees as the wolf kept herding us toward it. We squeezed into the tight circle of wood, vines, and leaves, and the wolf huffed, growled in warning, then turned back to the fray.

I could only stare as the scene exploded into madness, fury and bloodlust ran unchecked as the beasts attacked one another. The nearest monster to our hiding spot launched itself at the silver wolf protecting us. Its lips pulled back into an ugly snarl of rage as the thick yellow fangs dripped with foam. The thing wrapped its long, muscled arms around the wolf's neck and sank malformed jaws into its neck.

The wolf howled and whipped around in rage, smashing the monster into the nearest tree. An ancient birch that was almost the same silver as the wolf took the brunt of the blow. The thing roared in fury and sank its fangs

deeper into the wolf. The silver beast reared up on hind legs and slammed into the tree again and again, trying to dislodge it.

I stared in shock, the gun forgotten, limp in my hand. Jack nudged me.

“Shoot it, man,” Jack whispered. “Shoot that thing.”

“Which one?” I asked, staring at the mayhem in front of me. My brain struggled to keep up with the chaos, struggled to accept that this was all real.

“They’re all monsters.” Jack snapped. “Shoot them.”

“But Buck.... he’s one of the wolf things. The others must be human too, somehow.” I stared at Jack, accepting the insanity even as he spoke it.

“Clearly, the wolf things are protecting us. But what if those other things are also human?”

“Have you completely lost your shit, man?” Jack whispered, incredulously.

“Do humans eat other humans? They were going to eat Dotty in that cave. Shoot. Them. Spare the wolves, if you think they’re all good ones, but those other things are not. Did you not see all those bodies in that cave?”

“Okay. Okay, Fuck. Let me try to get a shot.” I turned from Jack and peered out into the frenzy once more.

The silver wolf that was Buck was standing over the biggest creature, ripping into its throat with vicious snarls. His enormous jaws sunk into the coarse fur and leathery skin of the beast, ripping and tearing dripping crimson chunks from its body. Blood sprayed the wolf and coated the trees beside them as the wolf tore its throat out, leaving a gaping hole in the side of the creature’s neck.

I gasped as one the creatures approached Buck from behind, a heavy stone in its grasp. I raised the gun, trying to get a clear shot, but the trees were in

the way. I swallowed hard and slid out from between the trees, taking a few steps toward the trail to get a better angle on the monster approaching Buck.

The silver wolf turned just as I squeezed the trigger. The shot rang out. The silver wolf leapt toward him, but it was a second too late. I went down as one creature slammed into my back. Dotty screamed. Jack called out. The shot went wild. I saw a flash of fur, silver and gold, streak past his eyes. Bright pain seized my body as I fell, and then I saw nothing as darkness took over.

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Chapter 24

Jack Takes Charge

JACK STARED IN HORROR as the female battered into Garrison. The shot startled all the creatures into a split second of shocked silence then two of the wolves hurtled toward Garrison and the female as she closed her jaws on his shoulder. Her teeth sank deep into his flesh, and she pulled, getting a mouthful of flannel, flesh, and bloody muscle as the golden wolf smashed into her side, knocking her from Garrison's limp form. The silver skidded to a stop over Garrison, standing guard as more of the creatures approached.

Jack slid Dotty off his lap and leaned her gently against a tree. She whimpered in pain and clutched at him, shaking her head no.

"I have to get the gun." He whispered. "It's right there." He pointed just outside the trees that protected them. "I have to do something. I can't just leave him there."

"No, Jack, No. Don't leave me here." Her eyes were huge in her pale face as he kissed her forehead. "Don't."

"Dotty, I have to. He saved you. Hell, he saved both of us. I need to try."

“But the wolves, they can help. Let them.” She begged. Her voice broke as she spoke. Fresh tears cut clean streaks through her dirty and bloodied face.

“They need our help, too.” He said, looking out between the trees as the remaining four monsters approached the three wolves, of which one was bleeding badly. “They’re outnumbered and hurt.” He looked at his new wife, sadness on his face. “I love you so much. I’m so sorry I brought you here. But I have to try. If anything happens, you go with the wolves. You know Buck is a good man. Let them protect you. They’ll keep you safe.”

Dotty clutched at her husband, desperation on her face, but he loosened her fingers, pressed his lips to hers, and stood.

“I love you.” He whispered, and then slid out between the trees.



DOTTY WATCHED HELPLESSLY AS Jack stepped onto the trail, bending slowly to pick up the gun, keeping his eyes on the wolf that hovered over Garrison. The golden one had the female on the ground and was shaking her limp form with his powerful jaws. Blood gushed from multiple wounds on her torso, and her chest was torn open, showing glints of bone and throbbing muscle.

Gore dripped from Buck’s jaws as he finally dropped the creature and backed away. The remaining creature was snarling as it pummeled the back of the smallest wolf, that had the thing caught in its jaws, twisting, and pulling at a leathery leg in its mouth. Jack lifted the gun and took aim.

Dotty’s breath caught in her chest and held. The forest seemed to grow silent around her as time slowed down in her mind. Jack squeezed the

trigger just as Buck's golden form streaked across the trail and sank his jaws into the last monster. The shot went wild. Buck roared as the bullet hit home, almost knocking him back from the beast. He almost snapped the creature's head clean off as pain exploded in his back leg. The monster fell limp.

Buck let go, dropping the vile remains of the last cave dweller, and collapsed beside it. Blood poured from his leg as ripples began to course through his body. Jack rushed over to him, then drew up short a few feet away, unsure if he should get close or not. Buck was caught in the midst of his transformation. Snarls and cries of human pain tore through the air. The other two wolves looked on, both on guard.

Jack watched, horrified, and fascinated, as Buck's form glowed bright, a blinding aura rippling over it, like a heat wave. The fur shimmered and shifted from silverish hair to tanned flesh and back again. Buck's head shifted, cracked, and morphed from beast to human then back again, before settling into Buck's grandfatherly face, creased with pain, and stained with dirt and blood. The rest of his form followed suit. Bones cracking and settling into place, fur sloughing off, revealing human flesh beneath.

Finally, the older man lay still. His chest heaved. Blood poured from his leg wound. Scratches and gouges covered both arms as well as his chest and stomach. Claw marks were clearly visible on his left shoulder. Jack approached and knelt by his side. He took his hand on his own, careful not to move him too much.

"Buck, I'm so sorry. Are you okay? I was trying to hit that thing, then you rushed it. I couldn't stop it. Are you okay?" Jack's voice was coated in anguish, despair, and sorrow as he frantically tried to get Buck to speak.

“I hear you, son. It’s okay.” Buck said with a groan. “Give me a minute. Just let me breathe.”

Jack knelt back, resting on his haunches as Buck rolled to his side, struggling to sit up. Jack offered him a hand, seeing Dotty appear a few feet from the silver wolf next to Garrison. Dotty had pulled herself from the trees and onto the trail, half-crawling, half-sliding through the underbrush with her bad leg in a splint. She leaned over to check on him as the wolf backed away a few feet. Buck followed his gaze and grimaced.

“We need to see to the boy.” He said, allowing Jack to help him up. Buck limped over to Garrison, his leg trailing blood, but not as much. Jack watched as Dotty looked up at him and Buck as they approached.

“He’s not responding,” she said, tears choking her voice.

Garrison’s face was gray, his eyes barely moving beneath closed lids. Blood poured from the deep gash in his neck. Buck stared at him, then made eye contact with the other two wolves. A moment passed, an eternity, as an unspoken question was voiced and answered. The wolves nodded at Buck.

Jack watched this all transpire, not daring to question anything at this moment. He placed a hand on Dotty’s back as she sobbed. Her pale hand stroked Garrison’s cheek. Buck stepped closer to Garrison, then knelt. A painful groan left his lips as he studied the gash in Garrison’s neck. The old man looked at Jack and Dotty.

“I can save him, but you need to understand that it will make him like us,” Buck spoke gravely, watching their faces.

“Do it.” Jack said quietly. “He saved us both, and you. Do whatever it takes. He would rather be alive by any means necessary. His life wasn’t finished yet.”

Dotty nodded in agreement, sniffing hard as Buck gave her a tight smile. He turned back to Garrison and bent over his still form.

Jack and Dotty watched, both repulsed and terrified, as Buck opened his mouth, shuddering as his fangs exploded from his upper jawline. He sank them deep into Garrison's neck, beside the gushing wound. Dotty covered her mouth to stifle a small scream, understanding setting in almost immediately.

As Buck bit down, a thick golden fluid flooded the wound, issuing from the fangs. It flowed into the gash, spread out and mixed with the blood pooled there. Dotty saw the crimson shimmer with a slight golden tint as the fluid spread. Fascinated, she watched as color returned to Garrison's pale flesh. Whatever Buck was doing to him was working. Jack nudged her, and she glanced up, then back down where Jack pointed.

As Buck tended to Garrison, the wound in his own leg was closing, sealing itself as if it had never been. Only the tacky scarlet stain remained on his bare flesh. Dotty just looked on, no longer caring for an explanation. *What did it matter? She was alive. Jack was alive. Garrison was alive. Nothing else mattered.*



BUCK FINALLY SAT UP and wiped his jaw. He stayed that way, watching the young man intently. Garrison's chest began to rise and fall more deeply. Small twitches started in his fingers and moved up his hands, his arms and through his body. His legs kicked. His torso began to thrash and flail about. His eyes never opened.

Dotty gasped and leaned forward, placing her hand on Buck's forearm. He grasped it, patted it.

"It's okay. The serum is working. Give it a minute." He said to her quietly. His voice was much stronger than before. The trio watched as Garrison's body grew frenzied on the ground. The two other wolves had gone off nearby to transform on their own and now stood a few yards away, watching. One, the veteran hiker called Tramp, held a bundle of Buck's clothes beneath his arm. Pete stood beside him, somber and on edge. He scanned the forest for any movement as they waited for Garrison to wake.



JACK GLANCED AT THEM and nodded in acknowledgment, not at all surprised that they had been the other two wolves. As close as they seemed to be during the picnic, and the silent exchanges that had taken place between them that night all made sense now. They were the other creatures in the woods they had been talking about. Jack shook his head as everything fell into place for him.

Suddenly, he was glad. Garrison would not have to face his new existence on his own. He would belong to their group now. Buck had taken to him like a father figure might, kind and patient, wisdom well beyond his years. Garrison would do well here among them. Garrison's face was healthy looking now, full of color. His skin was clear, the prior acne scars were gone. The baby fat had vanished. His body rippled with solid muscle beneath the flannel. He heard Dotty gasp as she, too, took in his slightly new, but startling, appearance. He snapped out of his reverie when he heard

a loud inhale and Garrison spoke. Jack smiled warmly at his friend as he looked at them, eyes bright but glowing amber now, like Buck's.

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Chapter 25

Unexpected Changes

“WHAT HAPPENED?” MY VOICE was hoarse and raspy. I blinked a few times, struggling to open my eyes, adjusting to the sunlight that broke through the lush emerald canopy overhead. The colors were dazzling, and I stared for a long moment, curiously watching the multi-colored dust motes in the air. The leaves were greener, the browns were fuller, streaked with rich red, oranges, yellows.

Minute details I had never seen before. Everything was just...*more*. *I must have hit my head pretty hard*, I thought to myself as Buck reached a handout. I took it, letting him help me stand. He stayed close, making sure I was steady on my feet.

“Welcome back, buddy.” Jack reached over and awkwardly hugged me with one arm. When he stepped back, he whistled softly. Jack tried to keep his face calm, but he failed. I could see the astonishment clear in his eyes.

“What’s the matter?” I asked as I took in the expressions on Jack’s and Dotty’s faces. “How bad is it?”

“Well, about that,” Buck began, “We’re going to need to talk a little, son. Why don’t we sit down over here, and I’ll explain everything. It’s going to be a bit of a shock.”



THE SMALL GROUP FOLLOWED us over to a fallen tree, where we got as comfortable as we could. Jack sat on the ground with Dotty cradled in his lap. Buck and I situated ourselves on the tree, perched like we were on a picnic bench. Tramp and Pete stood near the end of the tree, placing their bags on the jagged stump that once held the massive pine. I looked at their somber faces nervously, then looked expectantly at Buck.

“So, why so serious? I don’t seem to be hurt.” I asked. I could hear the trace of trepidation in my voice.

“Well, now, son. This is going to be hard to hear, but I need you to listen to all of it. Can you do that?”

“Of course I can. What’s the big deal?” I looked around at them again. “You’re all acting like I died.”

Buck stood up and paced in front of them. Dotty shifted closer to me and took hold of my hand.

“Well, bud. That’s just it. You almost died, would have died. If we hadn’t done something to help it.” Buck said.

“Okay...?” I said. The word was drawn out like a question rather than a statement as I tried to process what Buck had just said.

“You remember anything that happened?” Buck asked, stopping his pacing to look directly at me.

“Some of it. Flashes of those things from the cave. Then those wolves showed up again. Started attacking...” I trailed off and looked at Buck, swallowing hard. “Wait...”

Buck nodded. Pete and Tramp exchanged glances of their own, then looked at me. They both had strange expressions on their faces. The tension was so thick I could almost see it shimmering above their heads like a heat wave.

“What else?” Buck said, one hand rubbing the back of his neck. He started pacing again, nervously licking his lips and glancing at Jack and Dotty. They seemed to pick up on a silent request and scooted back a few feet. Jack carrying Dotty in a half-crouch as he did so.

“Oh, for fuck’s sake, just tell me.” I said, exasperated by all the mystery.

“I was the wolf, Garrison,” Buck said quietly, “or am the wolf.” He gestured at Pete and Tramp. “We all are. Part of a guardian pack to try to keep the hikers safe from those cave dwellers.”

“Wait, what now?” I felt the blood rush from my face. I felt faint and went to stand up, but weakly dropped back to the log.

“What are you saying?”

“We are werewolves, sort of.” Buck shrugged. “Miss Trudy, her husband, was our alpha for many years. Those Sasquatch-type creatures that dwell here, they’re not from this dimension. Decades ago, Ralph was attacked by one of their kind, but this other animal saved him. A hybrid creature from their world, more of their sworn enemy, saved Ralph, but in doing so, it made him one of them.”

“What exactly are you saying?” I could feel my face growing redder by the second. The heat in my cheeks told me all I needed to know.

“I’m going to need you to breathe, son,” Buck said, stepping back, palms out. “You’re still transforming. You could phase suddenly and you’re too close to Dotty and Jack.”

“I could what?” I demanded. My voice rose an octave. I stood from the log. The vein in the side of my neck pulsed with anger. I could feel heat creeping up my neck, deepening the already scarlet flush on my face. “What did you do to me?”

Pete and Tramp walked slowly over to me, flexing, wary, but ready. I guessed they had seen this reaction before.

“Breathe, Garrison.” Buck said, “Just listen to me.”

“Garrison, buddy, you were dying, bleeding out.” Jack interjected, panicked. “We told him to save you. He asked us, we agreed.”

“We couldn’t let you die,” Dotty added, tears clouding her voice, making it thick and hoarse. “Please listen to him. Just do what he says. Breathe, honey. It’ll be okay.”

I stared at the small group, pleading with me to understand. I could see Dotty’s eyes, tears glimmering on curved black lashes. I saw the tiny golden flecks in her pupils. I looked at Jack and saw the fear and despair on his face, heard the pleading tone in his voice. Buck waited a few steps away, watching me intently.

I stared at him the longest, seeing the coarse hair along his jaw and knuckles, seeing the ridge along his gum line where his hidden fangs had retracted. I smelled the musk coming off Buck and the men behind them. The same animal scent he now noticed coming from his own flesh.

I exhaled and looked at my clenched fists. I could see deeper pores there, hiding thick hair that seemed ready to burst from my flesh.

I ran my tongue along my gumline and felt something more there, something vibrating just beneath the tender pink flesh. I flexed and felt new muscle on my bones, a taut hardness where baby fat once resided.

I squeezed my eyes shut. Breathed. Exhaled. Listened to my body. I could hear my heartbeat pounding against my ribs. Blood pulsed in my veins. I could feel my internal organs working, pumping, throbbing, squelching as the serum rushed through it all, changing me at a cellular level. Finally, I opened my eyes.

“Tell me everything.” I said. My tone was calm, but my eyes were locked on Buck. The old man nodded. The others exhaled a heavy breath they had been holding as one when I sat back down on the fallen tree waiting for Buck to begin.



“LIKE I SAID, OLD Ralph was our Alpha until one of them beasts got him when we tried to save a family of hikers. Miss Trudy took it real hard, but she knew what he was, what we all are.”

“Ralph changed us all, over time. One by one, he saved us, when help didn’t arrive in time, he saved us the only way he could, by changing us.” Pete spoke up. His voice was kind and understanding.

“Tramp here was literally hanging on by a thread. Them creatures damn near tore his head off.”

Tramp raised his neck back so they could see the thick line that ran along it. Not quite a scar, but still a harsh reminder of something awful. I nodded at him, understanding what these men must have endured. I felt my heart slow; the anger receding.

“I didn’t have a choice. That female’s attack pierced your jugular. You would have bled to death. I told Jack and Dotty what I had to do. They agreed. Said it wasn’t your time yet, and I agreed with them.”

“So, what do I do now?” I asked, quietly. “Just live out here in the woods. I can’t go home, can’t be among society anymore? What is my life now?” Anger was creeping back into my voice.

“Garrison, you told us you were on a journey to find yourself, to find your purpose,” Jack said. “I think we were it. Dotty and me. You were here to save us, whether you knew it or not. This was your purpose.” Dotty nodded, smiling through tears.

“Don’t get me wrong. I’m glad I’m not dead. And I’m glad you’re not dead, too.” I smiled at Dotty. I could feel the tension in my jaw. “But what am I supposed to do with all this? Where do I go?”

“You go with us. You’ll stay with Miss Trudy until we can teach you all you need to know. After that, you can stay in town, live, and work there or nearby, once you learn how to control the phasing, of course. We work the trail in shifts, a few of us out here at a time. There’s two dozen of us that work in small packs.” Buck said, coming over to sit down next to me.

“You can still have a normal life, mostly. Once you learn to control it, you’ll only phase when you need to, when you’re out here on the hunt.”

“You’re family now, son,” Buck said, gently. “We know you lost yours. We know what you were searching for and maybe, just maybe, Dotty and Jack are right. Maybe you were brought here for a reason, and maybe it’s us.”

I looked at him and smiled sadly. “Maybe.”

“And what about you guys? What will you do now?” I asked Jack and Dotty. “Will I see you again?”

“You damn skippy,” Jack said. “We will come back all the time. Like Buck said, you’re family, that includes us.” Dotty nodded as Jack spoke.

“I wouldn’t be here if it wasn’t for you.” She said softly. “We will be here for you, every bit as much as we can be.”

“So, what now?” I asked. “Marshall is on his way, you said earlier. What do we tell them? And we need to get Dotty out of here.” I stood up.

“What’s done is done. I guess, for now, I’m alive and I’ll need to just deal with the rest. If you guys can handle it, I guess I can learn, too.”

“Marshall will be waiting at the ranger station. We only need to hike Dotty out about two miles to get there. We called ahead to let them know we found you, shaken up but safe,” Tramp said, gathering his pack.

“And what do I tell Marshall?” I asked Buck. “He will expect me to come back.”

“You tell him what you must. You want to finish the trail. You still have six weeks of hiking left before you were expected to come back. In the meantime, we will get you settled with Miss Trudy, train you on how to be part of the hunters and after that, you call him and tell him you decided to stay on with Miss Trudy.”

“I guess that’s as good a plan as any,” I said. “For now.”

“For now.” Buck agreed. “After we teach you how to adjust to your new nature, you can leave if you so choose. You are not a prisoner. I saved your life because I had to, not to enslave you. The rest of us chose to stay. You have a choice. I just ask that you allow us time to help you adjust first.”

I nodded, helping Jack get Dotty adjusted in his arms again. “I can agree with that.”

“Let’s get Dotty out of here, then.” I said, effectively closing the subject. Taking charge of the small group, I led them down the trail.

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Chapter 26

Panic on the PNT

WE MADE FAST WORK of the trail ahead, working together to get Dotty to safety. I stayed silent as we marched along, a tsunami of thoughts keeping my mind occupied. Along with everything that had happened, adjusting to my new reality was mind-blowing. My senses were amplified in every way. I could taste the dust motes sparkling in the air. I heard the rodents in the brush breathing, huffing, snorting, scavenging, for food. I could hear every heartbeat of my companions behind me.

My vision, taste, smell, hell, even my sense of touch was all overloaded. It was every sensation magnified a hundred times over. I could feel the additional layer of hide beneath my skin. The coarse hairs bristled there, waiting to burst free in a frenzy.

Colors were brilliant and breathtaking. A rainbow of colors that I had never seen before swirled above me in a dizzying display. I found myself running my fingers over branches, my jeans, my jacket, the silken leaves. Textures that I had never experienced were suddenly crystal clear beneath my touch. I could feel the miniscule ridges within the bark on the trees. I

felt small pulses of energy from every living thing I touched. Overwhelmed did not begin to cover how I felt.

I inhaled slowly, feeling my heart race as everything became too much. Life had suddenly become just too much. *How was I supposed to handle this, all of this, right now, at barely twenty-three?* Frantic thoughts raced through my brain as I struggled to take it all in.

I barely registered the group had slowed to a halt behind me. Static filled my skull, blood pulsed in my ears. My brain was screaming in capitals, listing all the impossible things that I now had to figure out.

It was too much.

Too much. Too much.

The thought became a heartbeat, pounding against my chest.

Too much. Too much. Too much.

My blood burned in my veins. Pain coursed through my flesh and bones. My body shook of its own accord. I heard something from far away, muted like it was underwater, breaking through the static in my ears. Buck. Buck was saying something.

“Garrison. Need you to breathe, son.”

My body trembled. Loss of control so close I could taste the metallic rush of saliva in my mouth, the layer of new fangs vibrating with the impending change. I shook, alone in a bubble of fear and panic. Hairs, my new fur, bristled under my skin, pushing into my human flesh, eager to burst free.

“Garrison. Look at me.” Buck’s face swam into focus, too clear, too sharp. His every age spot and laugh line were visible to my new animalistic eyes.

“Focus, son. That’s it. Focus on me. Just on me. You’re safe.” Buck’s voice was calm. Soothing like a father to a small child.

“Breathe with me. In. Out.”

Slowly, my brain allowed me to focus on Buck and his words. I watched him carefully, trying to imitate the old man as he breathed, willing myself to calm down. Minute by minute, I stared at Buck, forcing my mind to empty of all thought except for the breathing and Buck's voice.

Finally, my muscles relaxed, and my jaw loosened. The tips of my fangs receded and the sizzling in my taut veins faded. Conscious, clear thought returned slowly, as Buck eyed me cautiously from a few paces away.

"Okay?" the old man asked.

I nodded, tried to speak, but failed. I took another deep breath and let it out.

"What was that?" I asked, "what happened?"

"I would imagine you had a panic attack." Buck said. "It's common when we first change. A natural reaction to the stress and the worry." He approached and set a kind hand on his shoulder. "Were you thinking about everything just then? Freaking out a little?"

"Freaking out a lot is more like it," I replied, a wry chuckle escaping him.

"It's okay. Happens to all of us. I was watching you the whole time, stopped everyone a few yards back until I could calm you." Buck smiled. "You were just told that you almost died and are now a monster. I wasn't foolish enough to think that you had processed everything all at once. I know the signs. We all do by now. It'll happen a few more times as you try to deal with everything. We can help you get it under control. It'll get easier every time."

I glanced back at the group, waiting a few yards away. Pete and Tramp nodded, smiling. Dotty leaned her head against Jack as he held her, a slight smile on her face too, but worry was etched in every line, worry and pain. I felt bad. She needed a doctor. There would be time for me to panic later. I

turned back to Buck, refocused on the task at hand. Dotty was a priority right now.

“I’m okay. Let’s get them out. I’ll panic later.” I grinned at Buck and forced fear from my mind. Later. I had Buck and Pete and Tramp. *I can do this with their help. I will do this.* I told myself firmly, then shook it off, squared my shoulders, and pressed forward.

I didn’t need to look back to know the moment they followed. The crunching of the leaves beneath their feet and the vibrations deep in the soil told me all I needed to know.



FORTY MINUTES LATER, WE reached the small ranger station, where several people stood waiting. I had to remind myself to breathe slowly and steadily as Marshall approached. I watched as two medics took Dotty from Jack. Buck went over to the rangers and began talking to them.

A clearing was nestled behind the small hut intended for campsites and I could see the chopper waiting there with the pilot pacing nearby. The medics quickly settled Dotty onto the stretcher for transport, and Jack jogged over to Marshall and me.

“Going to get her loaded now.” Jack said, smiling at us. “Thank you for everything, man, seriously. We can never repay you for what you’ve done for us.”

“Go on, get out of here. Keep me posted. We can talk later, yeah?”

“Yeah, I’ll call with updates, and we will meet you back at Trudy’s later.” Jack smiled, held out his hand for a handshake, but I stepped closer, hugging him.

“Marshall. Nice to meet you, even if briefly. He’s told us a lot. Hope we get to talk more soon.” Jack said to Marshall, his words a rush as he saw the medics waving at him. “Gotta go. I’ll call.”

We watched him go, then Marshall turned to me. One eyebrow raised, a heavy pack over his shoulder, and a smile on his face.

“Well? Want to fill me in?” he finally asked.

I smiled, hiding the fact that I felt like a bowling bowl was bouncing around in the pit of my stomach.

“Let’s go sit down, shall we?” I gestured toward the picnic tables by the ranger hut. “It’s a long story.”

Together, we walked toward the tables, where Buck, Pete, and Tramp stood waiting to help me fill in the blanks for Marshall and the rangers. Behind us, the chopper lifted into the air, bending blades of grass and young saplings beneath its sudden breeze, carrying Dotty and Jack to safety.

Epilogue

Six months later

DOTTY AND JACK SAT bundled beneath blankets by the fire, listening to Tramp and Pete talk about their latest hike. Miss Trudy bustled around the tables, setting more food out and refiling coffee cups. Dotty kept looking toward the back fence, where the forest ran along the creek, waiting. Jack saw her and patted her knee.

“Soon.” He said. He took her hand and kissed it. Miss Trudy turned to the group, a beautiful smile on her face.

“Wait until you see him.” She said. “Such an incredible difference.” She walked over to the group and sat down, picking up her own mug of coffee to warm her hands.

“He’s been amazing.” She continued. “Garrison is truly a remarkable young man. The new alpha, too. The pack have all accepted him and they’ve not lost a hiker in the last three months.”

Pete and Tramp both agreed.

“It was long overdue for Buck to step down,” Pete said. “It’s been rough on him since Ralph passed.”

A breeze rustled the leaves as if something banged against the back fence. All heads turned expectantly as two shapes emerged from the brush. Dotty and Jack stood up as Buck led a massive white wolf across the yard. The blue eyes shimmered in the firelight as it came closer. Halfway to them, it stopped. Buck joined the group, smiling as he greeted the others.

The wolf let out a soft howl, a greeting to its family. In the distance, an answering howl sounded out. The glimmering white wolf reared up, silhouette by the moon, and with a deep rumble the beast exploded in a haze of fur, snarls, limbs, and flesh. A moment later, Garrison appeared in the shadows. He stood tall, covered in crimson, muscles rippling beneath tanned skin. A young man, fully transformed by fate, friends, and family.

About the Author

CANDACE NOLA IS A multiple award-winning author, editor, and publisher. She writes poetry, horror, dark fantasy, and extreme horror content. Books include *Breach*, *Beyond the Breach*, *Hank Flynn*, *Bishop*, *Earth vs The Lava Spiders*, *The Unicorn Killer*, *Unmasked*, *The Vet*, *Venus*, *Desperate Wishes*. Her short stories can be found in *The Baker's Dozen* anthology, *Secondhand Creeps*, *American Cannibal*, *Just A Girl*, *The Horror Collection: Lost Edition*, and *Exactly the Wrong Things*, with many more coming throughout 2023.

Beyond the Breach, won the "Novel of the Year" and her Debut Novel, *Breach*, was nominated for "Debut Novel of the Year", for the 2021 Horror Authors Guild awards. She is the publisher and editor of the 2022 Splatterpunk Award Winning Anthology "Uncomfortably Dark Presents: *The Baker's Dozen*." She also won the 2023 Splatterpunk Award for anthology of the year for "Camp Slasher Lake, Vol. 1", with co-editor D.W. Hitz, published by Fedowar Press.

She is the creator of Uncomfortably Dark, which focuses primarily on promoting indie horror authors and small presses with weekly book reviews, interviews, and special features. Uncomfortably Dark Horror stands behind its mission to “bring you the best in horror, one uncomfortably dark page at a time.”

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